

ESL 304 2026-2027



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Licensing

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1: Health and Wellness

Module 1: Health and Wellness

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Health touches every part of daily life — how we eat, sleep, move, work, and manage stress. In this module, students explore the theme of health and wellness while building the grammar and vocabulary they need to talk about habits, routines, and long-term well-being in English. Students will read an authentic-style article about building healthy habits, learn ten key wellness vocabulary words, and study three closely related present-tense grammar structures — simple present, present progressive, and present perfect — along with stative verbs, subject-verb agreement, and the difference between *for* and *since*. These structures are exactly what English speakers use every day to describe routines ("I exercise three times a week"), ongoing actions ("I am trying a new diet this month"), and experiences over time ("I have had this habit for two years"). Students will apply what they learn by writing a process paragraph that explains how to build a healthy habit, and by joining a discussion board conversation comparing wellness traditions across cultures.

In this module, students will:

- Read and discuss an authentic-style article about healthy habits and wellness routines
- Learn and use 10 key vocabulary words related to health and wellness
- Practice simple present, present progressive, and present perfect tenses, including stative verbs and subject-verb agreement
- Distinguish between *for* and *since* when talking about time
- Practice the reading strategy of identifying facts versus opinions
- Write a process paragraph explaining how to build a healthy habit or routine
- Participate in a discussion board comparing personal and cultural wellness traditions

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Read a multi-paragraph authentic-style text on health and wellness, identify main ideas and supporting details, and distinguish facts from opinions
Vocabulary	Define, pronounce, and correctly use 10 health/wellness vocabulary words in original sentences
Grammar	Accurately form and use simple present, present progressive, and present perfect tenses; use stative verbs correctly; apply subject-verb agreement in all three tenses; choose correctly between <i>for</i> and <i>since</i>
Writing	Plan, draft, revise, and publish a well-organized process paragraph (title, topic sentence, ordered steps with transitions, concluding sentence) about building a healthy habit
Speaking and Listening	Participate in a structured discussion comparing personal and cultural health habits, using functional language to state opinions, compare, and connect to personal experience

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1	Module introduction; vocabulary pre-teach; read "Small Steps, Big Changes" as a class or independently	Vocabulary log started
1	Day 2	Comprehension check questions; facts vs. opinions reading strategy mini-lesson	Comprehension questions
1	Day 3	Grammar lesson: simple present, present progressive, present perfect, stative verbs, subject-verb agreement, <i>for</i> vs. <i>since</i>	Grammar practice activities 1–2
1	Day 4 (In-person: pair discussion in class comparing daily routines; Zoom: breakout rooms of 2–3 students using the same discussion questions; Canvas: asynchronous discussion board post with two required peer replies)	Speaking and Listening discussion board opens; students post original responses	Original discussion post
2	Day 5	Writing lesson: process paragraph structure, transition words, model text analysis; students choose a topic	Topic choice submitted
2	Day 6	Writing workshop: drafting and peer feedback (in-person: peer review in pairs; Zoom: peer review in breakout rooms with shared document; Canvas: peer review via discussion thread or submitted draft comments)	Paragraph draft
2	Day 7	Revising and editing; Self-Check Quiz (ungraded); AI Tutor practice session	Final paragraph due

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Simple Present	Habits, routines, facts, and general truths	She <i>drinks</i> eight glasses of water every day.
Present Progressive	Actions happening right now or temporary situations happening around this time	I <i>am trying</i> to eat more vegetables this month.
Present Perfect	Actions or states that started in the past and continue to the present, or past experiences without a specific time	He <i>has exercised</i> regularly for three years.
Stative Verbs	Describing states, feelings, thoughts, or senses (not usually used with -ing)	I <i>know</i> that sleep is important. (not "I am knowing")

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Subject-Verb Agreement	Matching the verb form to a singular or plural subject in all three tenses	My doctor <i>recommends</i> daily walks. / My parents <i>have followed</i> a low-sugar diet for years.
<i>For</i> vs. <i>Since</i>	<i>For</i> + a length of time; <i>Since</i> + a specific starting point	I have practiced yoga <i>for</i> two years. / I have practiced yoga <i>since</i> 2024.

Delivery Mode Note

This module is designed to work equally well in three delivery modes. **In-person** students will complete vocabulary and grammar activities on paper or on the board, work in pairs and small groups for the discussion and writing workshop, and turn in written work in class or upload it to Canvas. **Zoom** students will use the same materials through screen-sharing and breakout rooms, with shared Google Docs replacing physical worksheets for pair and group work. **Canvas** students completing the module asynchronously will find all readings, grammar explanations, and practice activities posted as Canvas pages or PDFs, will submit the process paragraph through a Canvas assignment, and will complete the discussion board requirement through the Canvas Discussions tool with required peer replies. Instructors should confirm which combination of these modes applies to their section and adjust due dates and synchronous participation requirements accordingly.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
nutrition	noun	the process of eating the right food for good health	Good <i>nutrition</i> helps the body fight illness.
wellness	noun	the state of being healthy in body and mind	Many companies now offer <i>wellness</i> programs for employees.
habit	noun	something a person does often, almost without thinking	Drinking water before every meal is a healthy <i>habit</i> .
routine	noun	a regular series of actions done in the same order	My morning <i>routine</i> includes stretching and a healthy breakfast.
chronic	adjective	continuing for a long time; long-lasting (often about illness)	Diabetes is an example of a <i>chronic</i> condition that needs daily management.
prevention	noun	the act of stopping something from happening before it starts	Regular check-ups are an important part of disease <i>prevention</i> .
immune system	noun	the body's natural defense against illness and infection	Sleep and good nutrition help keep the <i>immune system</i> strong.
mental health	noun	a person's emotional and psychological well-being	Talking to a counselor can support a person's <i>mental health</i> .
maintain	verb	to keep something at the same level or in good condition	It is important to <i>maintain</i> a balanced diet, not just start one.
consult	verb	to ask for advice or information from an expert	You should <i>consult</i> your doctor before starting a new exercise program.

Original Reading: "Small Steps, Big Changes"

Why Healthy Habits Matter

Many people believe that good health depends only on willpower, but research shows that *wellness* is really about small, repeated actions. A single healthy meal or one good night of sleep will not change a person's life. However, when a person repeats a positive action every day, that action becomes a *habit*, and habits shape long-term health. Doctors and nutrition experts agree that most chronic diseases, including heart disease and type 2 diabetes, are strongly connected to daily lifestyle choices. This is why *prevention* has become such an important word in modern healthcare. Instead of only treating illness after it appears, many clinics and community health programs now focus on helping people build habits that stop illness before it starts.

Building a Morning Routine

One of the easiest places to begin is the morning. A consistent morning *routine* gives the body and mind a predictable start to the day. For example, some people drink a full glass of water immediately after waking up, since the body loses water during sleep. Others spend just ten minutes stretching or walking before breakfast. These actions seem small, but they send an important signal to the brain: the day has structure, and the body is a priority. Sleep specialists also note that people who wake up and go to sleep at the same time every day, even on weekends, tend to report better energy and better *mental health* overall.

Nutrition and the Immune System

Nutrition plays a central role in how the body defends itself. The *immune system* depends on vitamins, minerals, and proteins found in fruits, vegetables, lean meats, and whole grains. A person who eats a variety of colorful vegetables every day is giving their immune system the tools it needs to fight off common illnesses like colds. Since the human body cannot produce all the nutrients it needs on its own, food choices directly affect how well a person can resist infection. Some researchers believe that processed foods high in sugar can actually weaken immune function over time, although this claim continues to be studied and discussed among nutrition scientists.

Mental Health Is Physical Health

For many years, physical health and *mental health* were treated as separate topics. Today, most doctors understand that the two are deeply connected. Chronic stress raises levels of a hormone called cortisol, and over time, high cortisol levels can contribute to high blood pressure, poor sleep, and a weaker immune system. Because of this connection, many wellness programs now include meditation, breathing exercises, or short walks as part of a complete health plan. In my opinion, mental health deserves the same daily attention as diet and exercise, even though it is sometimes harder to measure.

When to Consult a Professional

Building healthy habits does not mean avoiding medical care. In fact, people who care about their wellness should still *consult* a doctor regularly, especially if they have a family history of *chronic* illness. A doctor can run tests, track changes over time, and recommend a plan based on a person's specific needs. Waiting until a symptom becomes serious is far more expensive and far more dangerous than scheduling a yearly check-up. Community clinics, student health centers, and telehealth services have made it easier than ever to consult a professional without missing work or school.

Starting Small

Perhaps the most encouraging fact about building healthy habits is that a person does not need to change everything at once. Health experts generally recommend starting with one small, specific change — such as drinking more water, walking after dinner, or going to bed fifteen minutes earlier — and *maintaining* that change for several weeks before adding another. Small steps, repeated consistently, truly can lead to big changes.

(Word count: approximately 530 words)

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word Bank: nutrition, wellness, habit, routine, chronic, prevention, immune system, mental health, maintain, consult

1. My grandmother has a morning _____ that includes tea and a short walk.
2. Doctors recommend eating vegetables daily to strengthen the _____.
3. Before starting a new exercise plan, you should _____ your doctor.
4. It is hard to break a bad _____, but it is possible with practice.

5. Good _____ means eating a balanced variety of foods.
6. Regular check-ups are an important part of disease _____.
7. Many colleges now offer _____ programs to support students' overall health, not just their physical health.
8. Talking about feelings with a friend can support your _____.
9. Diabetes is considered a _____ illness because it requires long-term management.
10. She works hard to _____ a healthy weight through diet and exercise.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. According to the reading, what is the real key to long-term health — one big change or many small habits?
2. Why do sleep specialists recommend waking up at the same time every day?
3. What role does nutrition play in the immune system, according to the passage?
4. What is the connection between chronic stress and physical health described in the reading?
5. According to the reading, what should a person do before adding a second healthy habit?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Do you have a morning or evening routine? Describe it and explain how it affects your day.
2. The reading says mental health deserves the same daily attention as diet and exercise. Do you agree or disagree? Explain your opinion with an example from your own life or culture.

Reading Strategy: Facts vs. Opinions

Strong readers learn to notice the difference between a **fact** (something that can be proven true) and an **opinion** (someone's personal belief or judgement). Authentic texts, including health articles, often mix facts and opinions together, so readers must read carefully to tell them apart.

Type	Definition	Signal Words/Clues	Example from the Passage
Fact	A statement that can be checked and proven true or false	statistics, research findings, "studies show," specific data	"The immune system depends on vitamins, minerals, and proteins found in fruits, vegetables, lean meats, and whole grains."
Opinion	A personal belief, judgment, or interpretation that cannot be proven	"I believe," "in my opinion," "some people think," strong value words	"In my opinion, mental health deserves the same daily attention as diet and exercise, even though it is sometimes harder to measure."

Practice: Find one more fact and one more opinion in "Small Steps, Big Changes" and write them below. Discuss with a partner why you classified each sentence the way you did.

Grammar Lesson

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Simple Present	base verb (+s/es for he/she/it)	habits, routines, facts, general truths, schedules	every day, usually, always, often, never	She <i>walks</i> to the gym every morning.

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Present Progressive	am/is/are + verb-ing	actions happening now, or temporary actions/trends happening around this period	now, right now, this week, currently, these days	I <i>am eating</i> more vegetables these days.
Present Perfect	have/has + past participle	actions or states that began in the past and continue now, or life experiences with no specific time	already, yet, ever, never, for, since, so far	We <i>have followed</i> this diet for six months.
Stative Verbs	simple present form only (not -ing)	mental states, emotions, senses, possession, needs	know, believe, want, need, love, seem, understand	I <i>understand</i> the importance of sleep. (not "I am understanding")
Subject-Verb Agreement	verb form matches subject (singular/plural)	required in every tense; singular subjects take singular verb forms	he/she/it = -s ending in simple present	My sister <i>exercises</i> daily. My parents <i>exercise</i> together.
For vs. Since	for + duration; since + starting point	with present perfect to describe time	for two years, for a month / since 2023, since January	I have had this habit <i>for</i> a year. I have had it <i>since</i> last January.

Simple Present Tense

Use the simple present to talk about habits, routines, facts, and things that are generally true. Add **-s** or **-es** to the verb when the subject is *he*, *she*, or *it*.

- **Form:** subject + base verb (+s/es for third-person singular)
- **Negative:** subject + do/does + not + base verb
- **Question:** Do/Does + subject + base verb?

Spelling notes: Add *-es* after verbs ending in *-ch*, *-sh*, *-ss*, *-x*, *-o* (watch → watches; go → goes). Change *-y* to *-i* and add *-es* after a consonant (study → studies), but just add *-s* after a vowel + *y* (play → plays).

Common error: Forgetting the *-s/-es* with *he/she/it*. *Incorrect:* "She exercise every day." *Correct:* "She exercises every day."

Present Progressive Tense

Use the present progressive for actions happening right now, or for temporary situations and trends happening around the current time period (this week, this month, these days).

- **Form:** subject + am/is/are + verb-ing
- **Negative:** subject + am/is/are + not + verb-ing
- **Question:** Am/Is/Are + subject + verb-ing?

Spelling notes: Double the final consonant in one-syllable verbs ending in a single vowel + consonant (run → running). Drop the silent *-e* before adding *-ing* (make → making).

Common error: Using the present progressive for habits instead of routines. *Incorrect:* "I am drinking coffee every morning." *Correct:* "I drink coffee every morning" (habit) versus "I am drinking coffee right now" (happening now).

Present Perfect Tense

Use the present perfect for actions or states that started in the past and continue into the present, or for past experiences when the exact time is not important.

- **Form:** subject + have/has + past participle

- **Negative:** subject + have/has + not + past participle
- **Question:** Have/Has + subject + past participle?

Common error: Using a specific past time word (yesterday, last year) with the present perfect. *Incorrect:* "I have started this habit yesterday." *Correct:* "I started this habit yesterday" (simple past) or "I have started this habit recently."

Stative Verbs

Stative verbs describe states rather than actions — thoughts, feelings, senses, and possession (know, believe, want, need, love, hate, seem, own, understand, prefer). These verbs are not normally used in the -ing form, even when talking about the present moment.

Common error: *Incorrect:* "I am wanting to change my habits." *Correct:* "I want to change my habits."

Subject-Verb Agreement

The verb must always agree in number with its subject, in every tense.

- **Simple present:** singular subject (he/she/it/a person's name) → verb + -s. Plural subject (they/we/two or more people) → base verb, no -s.
- **Present progressive:** the *be* verb changes (am/is/are) to match the subject; the -ing form itself never changes.
- **Present perfect:** *has* with singular subjects (he/she/it), *have* with plural subjects (I/you/we/they) and with the pronoun *I*.

Common error: *Incorrect:* "My habits has changed a lot." *Correct:* "My habits have changed a lot," because *habits* is plural.

For vs. Since

Both words are used with the present perfect to talk about time, but they answer different questions.

- **For** + a length/duration of time (for two weeks, for a year, for a long time)
- **Since** + a specific starting point (since 2022, since January, since I moved here)

Common error: *Incorrect:* "I have exercised since three months." *Correct:* "I have exercised for three months" or "I have exercised since March."

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Multiple Choice — Choosing the Correct Tense

1. My doctor always (recommend / recommends) a yearly check-up.
2. Right now, I (try / am trying) a new sleep schedule.
3. We (have followed / follow) a low-sugar diet since last year.
4. She (understands / is understanding) why sleep matters for the immune system.
5. My parents (has / have) practiced yoga for ten years.
6. He (drinks / is drinking) water right now because he just finished running.
7. Good nutrition (help / helps) the body fight illness.
8. They (have changed / changed) their eating habits since they moved to a new city.

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank — *For* or *Since*

1. I have had this habit _____ two years.
2. My sister has practiced meditation _____ 2023.
3. We have eaten dinner together every night _____ a month.
4. He has consulted the same doctor _____ he was a child.
5. She has maintained a regular exercise routine _____ several years.
6. They have lived a healthier lifestyle _____ last January.

Activity 3: Sentence Writing — Subject-Verb Agreement

Write one complete sentence for each subject, using the tense indicated. Pay careful attention to subject-verb agreement.

1. (simple present) My best friend _____
2. (present progressive) Right now, the students _____
3. (present perfect) My family _____
4. (simple present) The nurses at that clinic _____
5. (present perfect) I _____

Writing Assignment

This module's writing assignment is a **process paragraph**, a type of informational writing that explains the steps needed to complete a task, in order, from beginning to end. Process paragraphs are useful in academic writing, workplace training documents, and everyday communication — for example, explaining how to fill out a form, how to prepare a dish, or, in this module, how to build a healthy habit.

Parts of a Process Paragraph

Part	Purpose
Title	Names the process being explained, in a few clear words
Topic Sentence	States the process and previews that steps will follow
Ordered Steps with Transitions	Presents each step in logical order, connected by transition words
Concluding Sentence	Restates the value or result of completing the process

Topic Choices

Option	Topic
1	How to build a habit of drinking more water every day
2	How to create a consistent sleep routine
3	How to start a simple exercise habit as a beginner
4	How to reduce stress with a daily relaxation habit
5	Student choice: another healthy habit or wellness routine (topic must be approved by the instructor before drafting)

Assignment Requirements

- Length: one well-developed paragraph, 8–12 sentences
- Must include a clear title, topic sentence, at least four ordered steps, and a concluding sentence
- Steps must be connected with transition words (see table below)
- Must use at least four vocabulary words from this module's word list
- Must include at least three examples of the grammar structures from this module (simple present, present progressive, and/or present perfect), used correctly with subject-verb agreement
- Typed or neatly handwritten; submitted through the option that matches your class delivery mode (see Multimodal Submission Options below)

Transition Words for Process Writing

Transition Word/Phrase	Use
First, / To begin,	introduces the first step
Next, / Then,	introduces a middle step

Transition Word/Phrase	Use
After that,	introduces a step that follows another
Meanwhile,	shows a step happening at the same time as another
Finally, / Last,	introduces the final step
As a result,	shows the outcome of completing the process

Model Text

How to Build a Water-Drinking Habit

Drinking enough water every day is a simple habit that supports the whole body, but it takes a clear plan to build. First, choose a reusable water bottle that holds a specific amount, such as 32 ounces, so you can track your progress easily. Next, set a goal to refill the bottle a certain number of times each day; most adults need at least two full bottles to stay hydrated. Then, connect drinking water to habits you already have, such as drinking a glass right after you wake up or before each meal. Meanwhile, keep the bottle somewhere visible, like your desk or your bag, because a habit is much easier to maintain when it is easy to see and remember. After that, track your progress for two weeks using a simple checklist or a phone app, since research shows that tracking a new habit increases the chance that it will continue. Finally, reward small successes, like a full week of reaching your goal, to keep yourself motivated. As a result, most people who follow these steps report feeling more energetic and notice that their skin and concentration improve within a month. I have followed this routine for six months, and it has become one of my most consistent healthy habits.

The Writing Process

Step 1: Prewrite. Choose your topic and brainstorm the steps of your process using the graphic organizer below.

Prewriting Organizer	Notes
Topic (the habit/process)	
Why this habit matters (1–2 reasons)	
Step 1	
Step 2	
Step 3	
Step 4 (or more)	
Result/benefit of completing the process	

Step 2: Draft. Write a full first draft using your topic sentence, ordered steps with transitions, and a concluding sentence. Do not worry about perfect grammar yet — focus on getting your ideas in order.

Step 3: Revise. Read your draft again (or exchange with a partner) and check the content and organization using the checklist below.

Step 4: Edit. Check grammar, spelling, punctuation, and subject-verb agreement.

Step 5: Publish. Submit your final paragraph using one of the multimodal options below.

Revision Checklist

Check	Yes/No
Does the paragraph have a clear title?	
Does the topic sentence introduce the process?	
Are there at least four steps, in a logical order?	

Check	Yes/No
Does each step use a transition word?	
Is there a concluding sentence?	
Are at least four vocabulary words used correctly?	
Are simple present, present progressive, and/or present perfect used correctly?	
Do subjects and verbs agree in every sentence?	

Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Beginning (1)
Organization (title, topic sentence, steps, conclusion)	All parts present and clearly ordered	All parts present, minor ordering issues	Missing one part or steps are unclear	Missing multiple parts; hard to follow
Use of Transitions	Varied transitions used correctly throughout	Transitions used correctly, some repetition	Few transitions or used incorrectly	Little to no use of transitions
Grammar (module tenses + subject-verb agreement)	Consistently accurate use of target grammar	Mostly accurate, minor errors	Frequent errors that sometimes affect meaning	Errors that make meaning unclear
Vocabulary Use	4+ words used naturally and correctly	4 words used correctly	2–3 words used, some incorrect	Fewer than 2 words used correctly
Content Development (steps are clear and complete)	Steps are detailed, logical, and complete	Steps are clear with adequate detail	Steps are present but underdeveloped	Steps are unclear or incomplete

Total: 20 points

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 (Typed):** Type your paragraph and submit it through the Canvas assignment link, or bring a printed/taped copy to class if enrolled in-person.
- **Option 2 (Handwritten + Photo):** Handwrite your paragraph neatly, take a clear photo, and upload the photo to Canvas. This option supports students who are still building digital typing skills.
- **Option 3 (Audio Recording):** Record yourself reading your paragraph aloud and submit the audio file through Canvas. This option builds oral fluency and supports students who benefit from an alternative to written submission.

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

Post a response that addresses all three parts:

1. **Personal:** Describe one healthy habit or wellness routine that you currently practice or want to build. How long have you had this habit (use *for* or *since*)?
2. **Cultural Comparison:** Describe a health or wellness tradition from your culture or family (for example, a traditional remedy, food, exercise, or rest practice). How is it similar to or different from wellness habits you have seen in the United States?
3. **Opinion:** In your opinion, which matters more for long-term health — physical habits (diet, exercise) or mental health habits (rest, stress management)? Explain why.

Then reply to **two classmates**: ask a follow-up question to one classmate, and share a similarity or difference between your habit/tradition and theirs with the other classmate.

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	Addresses all 3 parts of the prompt; at least 6 sentences; uses 2+ vocabulary words and correct present tenses	10
Reply 1	Asks a genuine follow-up question; at least 2 sentences	5
Reply 2	Compares/contrasts habits or traditions; at least 2 sentences	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Introducing your habit	One healthy habit I practice is _____.
Using <i>for/since</i>	I have practiced this habit for/since _____.
Describing a cultural tradition	In my culture/family, we _____ to stay healthy.
Comparing	My habit is similar to/different from _____ because _____.
Giving an opinion	In my opinion, _____ matters more because _____.
Asking a follow-up question	Can you tell me more about _____?

Functional/Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrases
Stating an opinion	I believe that... / In my opinion... / From my point of view...
Supporting with a reason	This is because... / One reason is... / For example...
Comparing	Similarly,... / In the same way,... / Both... and...
Contrasting	On the other hand,... / However,... / Unlike...
Agreeing	I agree with you because... / That's a good point,...
Disagreeing (respectfully)	I see your point, but... / I have a different opinion because...

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person students will discuss the three-part prompt orally in small groups, then one member of each group will report a summary to the whole class. **Zoom** students will be placed into breakout rooms of 2–3 to discuss the same prompt, using a shared Google Doc or the Zoom chat to note down key points before returning to the main session for a brief report-back. **Canvas** students completing this module asynchronously will post their original response directly to the Canvas Discussions tool and complete both required replies within the posted deadline, allowing time-flexible participation while still meeting the same communicative goals.

Discussion Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Beginning (1)

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Beginning (1)
Content (addresses all parts of prompt)	Fully addresses personal, cultural, and opinion parts with detail	Addresses all parts, less detail	Addresses only 2 of 3 parts	Addresses only 1 part or is off-topic
Grammar (target tenses, SVA)	Accurate use of present tenses and subject-verb agreement	Mostly accurate, minor errors	Frequent errors	Errors interfere with meaning
Engagement with Peers	Both replies are thoughtful, specific, and extend the conversation	Both replies are relevant and complete	Only one reply meets requirements	Replies are missing or minimal
Vocabulary and Language Use	Uses vocabulary and functional phrases naturally and correctly	Uses vocabulary and phrases with minor errors	Limited use of vocabulary/phrases	Little to no use of module vocabulary

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is for practice only and will not be graded. Use it to check your own understanding before the module assessment.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word (1–10) to its definition (a–j).

1. nutrition
2. wellness
3. habit
4. routine
5. chronic
6. prevention
7. immune system
8. mental health
9. maintain
10. consult

a. to ask an expert for advice b. the body's natural defense against illness c. continuing for a long time d. the state of being healthy in body and mind e. a regular series of actions f. something a person does often, almost automatically g. to keep something in good condition h. the process of eating right for good health i. the act of stopping something before it happens j. a person's emotional and psychological well-being

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. A yearly physical exam is a form of disease _____.
2. Skipping breakfast every day has become a bad _____ for many students.
3. She feels calmer since she started paying attention to her _____.
4. It can be hard to _____ motivation after the first few weeks of a new plan.
5. He follows the same _____ every evening before bed.
6. Vitamin C is known to support the _____.
7. Eating a variety of whole foods is part of good _____.

8. If symptoms continue for more than a week, you should _____ a doctor.

Section 3: Grammar Identification/Application

Choose the correct verb form.

1. My brother (jog / jogs) every morning before work.
2. Right now, she (eats / is eating) a healthy breakfast.
3. We (have practiced / practiced) meditation since January.
4. He (know / knows) that sleep affects his mood.
5. They (has changed / have changed) their habits for the better.
6. I (am understanding / understand) why hydration matters.
7. My parents (walks / walk) together every evening.
8. She (has had / had) this habit for three years, and she still has it now.
9. The clinic (offer / offers) free check-ups on Fridays.
10. Currently, we (are learning / learn) about healthy routines in class.
11. My cousin (want / wants) to build a new exercise habit.
12. He has followed this diet (for / since) 2022.

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the error in each sentence.

1. My sister exercise every day after work.
2. Right now, I am wanting to change my sleep schedule.
3. We have followed this routine since two months.
4. He drink water before every meal.
5. She is knowing that stress affects sleep.
6. My parents has started a new habit together.
7. They have practiced yoga since 2021.
8. The students is learning about nutrition this week.

Section 5: Short Writing Check

In 3–4 sentences, describe one healthy habit you want to build, using at least one example of simple present, present progressive, and present perfect.

Self-Evaluation Checklist

Question	Yes/No
Did I use simple present correctly at least once?	
Did I use present progressive correctly at least once?	
Did I use present perfect correctly at least once?	
Did my subjects and verbs agree?	
Did I use at least one vocabulary word from this module?	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Quiz me on the Module 1 health and wellness vocabulary words with example sentences."	Extra practice items and instant feedback on your answers
Grammar	"Give me 5 sentences about health habits with blanks for simple present, present progressive, and present perfect, and check my answers."	Targeted grammar practice with immediate correction
Writing Feedback	"Here is my process paragraph about building a healthy habit. Can you check my transition words and subject-verb agreement?"	Specific, actionable feedback on your draft before you submit it
Discussion Practice	"Ask me the discussion board questions about healthy habits and traditions, and give me feedback on my spoken or written answers."	A low-pressure way to rehearse your ideas before posting or speaking in class

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining

Combine each pair of sentences into one sentence using an appropriate transition or connector, keeping correct verb tense.

1. I drink more water now. I feel more energetic.
2. She started yoga last year. She still practices it now.
3. He eats vegetables every day. He avoids sugary drinks every day.

Activity 2: Subject-Verb Agreement Practice

Circle the correct verb form.

1. Regular exercise (improve / improves) mental health.
2. My friends (has / have) joined a wellness program at work.
3. Sleep (play / plays) an important role in the immune system.
4. Doctors (recommends / recommend) drinking enough water daily.
5. My cousin (has maintained / have maintained) a healthy weight for years.

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

Complete the sentence with the correct form of the word in parentheses.

1. Her doctor gave her some helpful advice about _____. (nutrition/nutritious)
2. He is very _____ about eating healthy food. (habit/habitual)
3. Getting a check-up is a good _____ measure. (prevent/preventive)
4. She wants to _____ her energy throughout the day. (maintain/maintenance)

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Offers free drop-in and appointment-based tutoring for ESL students, including help with grammar, vocabulary, and writing assignments.
- **Writing Center:** Provides one-on-one and small-group support for planning, drafting, and revising paragraphs and essays at any stage of the writing process.

- **Library:** Offers access to computers, printing, quiet study space, and librarian assistance for finding readable, level-appropriate materials on health and other topics.
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and support services for students with documented disabilities, including extended time, alternative formats, and assistive technology.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary by Skill Area

Skill Area	What Students Learned
Reading/Vocabulary	Read an authentic-style article on healthy habits; learned 10 wellness vocabulary words; practiced identifying facts vs. opinions
Grammar	Practiced simple present, present progressive, and present perfect tenses; stative verbs; subject-verb agreement across all three tenses; the difference between <i>for</i> and <i>since</i>
Writing/Communication	Wrote a process paragraph explaining how to build a healthy habit; participated in a discussion board comparing personal and cultural wellness traditions using comparison and opinion language

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
Purdue OWL: Subject-Verb Agreement	Detailed grammar rules and examples for subject-verb agreement	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_w...agreement.html
BBC Learning English: Present Perfect Grammar Reference	Explanations and practice for present perfect, including <i>for</i> and <i>since</i>	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglis...12/tab/grammar
British Council LearnEnglish: Present Perfect	Clear grammar reference and examples for present perfect usage	https://learnenglish.britishcouncil....resent-perfect
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Learner-friendly definitions and example sentences for vocabulary words	https://learnersdictionary.com
VOA Learning English: Let's Learn English – Making Healthy Choices	Listening and vocabulary practice on health topics for English learners	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/...s/5780880.html
VOA Learning English: Words and Their Stories – Medical Expressions	Vocabulary and idiomatic expressions related to health	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/...79/15135.html

Looking Ahead

This Module	Connects to Future Learning
Simple present, present progressive, present perfect	Later modules build on these tenses with past perfect and past perfect progressive for comparing events across time
Process paragraph writing	Prepares students for longer informational and multi-paragraph writing tasks later in the course
Facts vs. opinions reading strategy	Supports later work on author's purpose, point of view, and evaluating supporting evidence in authentic texts
Discussion board comparison skills	Builds toward future oral presentations and persuasive language tasks

Reflection Questions

1. Which vocabulary word from this module do you think you will use most often in real life? Why?
2. Which grammar structure — simple present, present progressive, or present perfect — did you find most challenging, and why?
3. What is one small healthy habit you could realistically start this week?
4. How did comparing your own wellness habits with a classmate's change or confirm your thinking?
5. What strategy helped you most when writing your process paragraph, and how will you use it in your next writing assignment?

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 1: Health and Wellness | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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2: Natural Disasters and Emergency Preparedness

Module 2: Natural Disasters and Emergency Preparedness

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Natural disasters such as earthquakes, wildfires, floods, and storms are part of life in California and in many students' home countries. Knowing how to talk about what happened, what should have happened, and what to do next is not just a language skill; it is a survival skill. In this module, students build the vocabulary and grammar they need to describe emergencies, understand official warnings, retell what someone else said during a crisis, and reflect on decisions made under pressure. Students will practice inferring meaning from context when a speaker's exact words are unclear, take notes while listening to emergency information, and identify a speaker's purpose and tone; all skills needed to follow real news broadcasts, safety announcements, and community alerts.

In this module, students will:

- Learn and use 10 vocabulary words related to natural disasters and emergency preparedness
- Read and analyze an original informational passage about disaster preparedness
- Use past modals (*used to*, *could have*, *should have*, *was able to*, *had to*) to talk about hypothetical situations, regrets, and past ability or obligation
- Convert direct speech into indirect (reported) speech to retell warnings, instructions, and survivor accounts
- Write a short informational/news-style paragraph about a natural disaster or an emergency preparedness plan
- Participate in a discussion board exchange comparing personal or family experiences with natural disasters and emergency planning

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Identify main ideas, supporting details, and facts vs. opinions in an informational text about disaster preparedness; use context clues to infer the meaning of unfamiliar words
Vocabulary	Correctly use 10 disaster/emergency-preparedness terms in speaking and writing
Grammar	Use past modals (<i>used to</i> , <i>could have</i> , <i>should have</i> , <i>was able to</i> , <i>had to</i>) to express habits, hypothetical outcomes, regret, ability, and obligation in the past; convert direct speech into indirect/reported speech
Writing	Write a well-organized informational/news-style paragraph (topic sentence + facts/details + conclusion) about a natural disaster or emergency plan
Speaking and Listening	Take notes while listening to disaster-related audio/video; infer a speaker's purpose and tone; share and compare personal/family experiences and give advice in discussion

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1	Introduce theme; pre-teach 10 vocabulary words; vocabulary practice	In-class/live check; Canvas auto-graded practice quiz

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 2	Read "Getting Ready: How Communities Prepare for Natural Disasters"; comprehension questions; reading strategy (facts vs. opinions)	Comprehension questions due end of day
1	Day 3	Grammar Lesson: past modals (<i>used to</i> , <i>could have</i> , <i>should have</i> , <i>was able to</i> , <i>had to</i>) — explanation + guided practice	Practice Activity 1 & 2
1	Day 4 (In-person: pairs act out a "What should they have done?" role-play using disaster scenario cards in class; Zoom: breakout rooms of 3 discuss the same scenario cards using the shared Zoom whiteboard; Canvas: students post their scenario response to the async discussion thread and reply to one classmate)	Past modals speaking practice + scenario cards	Discussion post/reply (Canvas) or participation check (in-person/Zoom)
2	Day 5	Grammar Lesson continued: indirect/reported speech; note-taking practice from a short listening clip (emergency alert script)	Grammar Practice Activity 3; note-taking worksheet
2	Day 6	Writing Assignment introduced: informational/news-style paragraph; model text analysis; prewriting graphic organizer	Prewriting organizer draft
2	Day 7	Draft writing assignment; peer review using revision checklist; Discussion Board opens	First draft; Discussion Board original post
2	Day 8	Discussion Board replies due; Self-Check Quiz (ungraded); Writing Assignment final submission	Final paragraph; 2 discussion replies; self-check quiz completed

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example
<i>used to</i> + base verb	Describe a repeated past habit or state that is no longer true	"Before the earthquake, the family used to leave their windows open at night."
<i>could have</i> + past participle	Describe a past possibility that did not happen	"They could have evacuated earlier, but the road was already closed."

Structure	When to Use It	Example
<i>should have</i> + past participle	Express regret or criticism about a past action (or its absence)	"The city should have sent the alert sooner."
<i>was/were able to</i> + base verb	Describe a specific past ability or successful action	"The firefighters were able to control the fire before it reached the houses."
<i>had to</i> + base verb	Describe a past necessity or obligation	"Residents had to leave their homes within one hour."
Indirect/reported speech	Retell what someone said without quoting their exact words	Direct: "Evacuate now," the officer said. → Indirect: The officer told us to evacuate immediately.

Delivery Mode Note

This module is designed to work seamlessly across all three delivery formats offered at Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education. **In-person** students will use printed vocabulary cards, physical scenario cards for role-play, and in-class small-group discussion. **Zoom** students will engage in the same activities through breakout rooms, the Zoom shared whiteboard, and screen-shared reading passages, with the instructor rotating through rooms to monitor language use. **Canvas LMS** students will complete the same content asynchronously: the reading, grammar explanations, and self-check quiz are self-paced, the discussion board replaces real-time discussion, and the writing assignment can be submitted as typed text, a handwritten photo upload, or an audio recording. All students, regardless of mode, complete the same core outcomes and are held to the same rubrics.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
evacuate	verb	to leave a dangerous place and go somewhere safer	Officials told residents near the coast to evacuate before the storm arrived.
shelter	noun/verb	a place that protects people from danger; to take protection	The Red Cross opened a shelter at the community center for families who lost their homes.
emergency kit	noun	a set of supplies (water, food, flashlight, first aid) kept ready for a disaster	Every household should keep an emergency kit with enough water for three days.
alert	noun/verb	a warning message about possible danger; to warn someone	The city sent an alert to every phone in the area about the incoming flood.
aftermath	noun	the period and conditions following a damaging event	In the aftermath of the earthquake, volunteers cleared debris from the streets.
precaution	noun	an action taken in advance to prevent harm	As a precaution , the school canceled outdoor activities during the wildfire smoke.
survivor	noun	a person who continues to live through a dangerous event	The survivors described how they escaped the flooded building.

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
damage	noun/verb	harm or destruction caused to something	The hurricane caused severe damage to homes along the coast.
warning	noun	a statement that tells people about possible danger	The weather service issued a warning for high winds and heavy rain.
response	noun	the actions taken to deal with an event, especially an emergency	The community's quick response helped prevent further injuries after the landslide.

Original Reading: "Getting Ready: How Communities Prepare for Natural Disasters"

Why Preparation Matters

California is no stranger to natural disasters. Earthquakes can strike without warning, wildfires spread quickly during dry summers, and winter storms sometimes bring flooding to low-lying neighborhoods. Because these events are unpredictable, emergency management experts agree that the best defense is preparation, not panic. Cities, schools, and families across the state have learned — often the hard way — that a clear plan can mean the difference between a manageable emergency and a tragedy. Long before a disaster strikes, communities work to reduce risk and prepare their residents to respond quickly and safely.

Building the Emergency Kit

One of the simplest and most effective precautions any household can take is building an emergency kit. Emergency management offices recommend that every family keep enough water, non-perishable food, medication, a flashlight, and a battery-powered radio to last at least three days. Some families used to keep only a few candles and a first-aid box, believing that was enough, but after recent wildfire seasons, many have expanded their kits to include masks, portable chargers, and copies of important documents. A well-stocked emergency kit does not prevent a disaster, but it gives people the tools to manage the first critical hours after one occurs, when roads may be blocked and stores may be closed.

Warnings and Alerts

Technology has changed how quickly people receive warnings. In the past, communities relied mainly on sirens and radio broadcasts, and by the time some residents heard the alert, they had very little time to react. Today, most counties use a wireless emergency alert system that sends a message directly to residents' phones the moment a threat is identified — whether it is a wildfire, flash flood, or tsunami. Emergency officials say that early alerts have been able to save lives because families are given more time to gather belongings and evacuate calmly instead of in a rush. Still, experts note that no alert system is perfect; some rural areas have weak cell signals, so local radio and door-to-door notification remain important backup methods.

Evacuation and Shelter

When an alert calls for evacuation, families are asked to leave the danger zone and go to a designated shelter, often a school gymnasium, community center, or fairground set up by the Red Cross or county agencies. Evacuation is rarely simple. During the recent wildfires in Northern California, some residents said they should have left sooner, once the smoke turned dark orange, but they had hoped the fire would change direction. Others reported that they were able to gather their pets and important papers only because a neighbor warned them in time. These accounts show why officials repeat one message again and again: when an evacuation order comes, leave immediately rather than waiting to see what happens next.

Life in the Aftermath

The aftermath of a disaster brings its own challenges. Survivors often deal with property damage, temporary housing, and the emotional stress of rebuilding their lives. Community response teams — including firefighters, utility workers, and volunteer groups — move in quickly to restore power, clear debris, and distribute supplies. Local governments also conduct damage assessments to determine how much financial assistance families will need. Mental health counselors frequently visit shelters, because emotional recovery is just as important as physical recovery.

Learning From Experience

Emergency planners study the response to every disaster to improve future preparation. After each wildfire season, cities review what worked and what did not, updating evacuation routes, alert systems, and shelter locations. For individual families, the lesson is similar: preparation today prevents difficult decisions tomorrow. Whether the danger is an earthquake, a flood, or a fire, having a clear plan — and practicing it — gives every family a far better chance of staying safe. (approx. 520 words)

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word Bank: evacuate, shelter, emergency kit, alert, aftermath, precaution, survivor, damage, warning, response

1. The county sent an official _____ to every phone warning residents about the wildfire.
2. As a _____, the school kept extra water and blankets in every classroom.
3. Families were told to _____ the area immediately after the flood warning.
4. In the _____ of the storm, crews worked for days to clear fallen trees.
5. A basic _____ should include water, food, a flashlight, and a first-aid kit.
6. The Red Cross opened a _____ for people who could not return to their homes.
7. One _____ described how she escaped her apartment before the water rose.
8. The heavy rain caused serious _____ to roads and bridges.
9. Firefighters' quick _____ helped stop the fire before it reached the neighborhood.
10. The weather service issued a _____ about strong winds expected overnight.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. What is the main idea of the reading passage?
2. According to the passage, what items should a household emergency kit contain?
3. How has technology changed the way communities receive emergency warnings?
4. Why do some residents say they should have evacuated sooner during a wildfire?
5. What kinds of challenges do communities face in the aftermath of a disaster?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Compare how your family (or a family you know) prepares for emergencies with the recommendations in the passage. What is similar? What is different?
2. In your opinion, what is the most important precaution a family can take before a natural disaster? Explain your reasoning with at least two supporting reasons.

Reading Strategy: Facts vs. Opinions

Strong readers distinguish between statements that can be proven (facts) and statements that reflect someone's belief or judgment (opinions). Informational texts about disasters often mix both, especially when they quote officials or survivors.

Facts	Opinions
Can be checked/verified with evidence (numbers, official statements, observable events)	Express a belief, feeling, or judgment; often include words like <i>should</i> , <i>believe</i> , <i>best</i> , <i>worst</i> , <i>terrible</i>
Example from the passage: "Most counties use a wireless emergency alert system that sends a message directly to residents' phones."	Example from the passage: "Some residents said they should have left sooner."

Practice: Find one more fact and one more opinion in the reading passage and write them below.

- Fact: _____

• Opinion: _____

Grammar Lesson

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
<i>used to</i>	<i>used to</i> + base verb	A repeated action or state in the past that is no longer true	<i>before, when I was young, in the past, back then</i>	"People used to rely only on radio broadcasts for storm warnings."
<i>could have</i>	<i>could have</i> + past participle	A past possibility or option that existed but did not happen	<i>possibly, maybe, but</i>	"The family could have stayed with relatives instead of going to the shelter."
<i>should have</i>	<i>should have</i> + past participle	Regret or criticism about a past action (or missing action)	<i>unfortunately, in hindsight, it's too bad</i>	"The city should have upgraded the alert system years ago."
<i>was/were able to</i>	<i>was/were able to</i> + base verb	A specific past ability or an action that was successfully completed	<i>finally, in the end, eventually</i>	"Rescue teams were able to reach the stranded hikers before dark."
<i>had to</i>	<i>had to</i> + base verb	A past necessity or obligation (often forced by circumstances)	<i>because, due to, as a result</i>	"Residents had to boil their water after the flood damaged the pipes."
Indirect/reported speech	subject + reporting verb (<i>said, told, warned, asked</i>) + [that] + clause with shifted tense/pronouns	Retelling what someone said without quoting their exact words	<i>told me, said that, warned us, asked if/whether</i>	Direct: "The water is rising fast," the officer said. → Indirect: The officer said that the water was rising fast.

Past Modals for Hypothetical and Regret Situations

1. *Used to* — Past habits that no longer happen

Form: subject + *used to* + base verb. Use *used to* to talk about a repeated habit, routine, or state that was true in the past but is not true now. It is not used for one-time past events.

- "Our town **used to have** an old-fashioned siren system, but now we use text alerts."
- Negative form: "We **didn't use to** worry about wildfires this much."
- Question form: "**Did** your family **use to** keep an emergency kit at home?"

Common error: Do not write "use to" in the past affirmative — it must be "**used to**." Also, do not add *-ed* to the main verb: NOT "used to evacuated" — correct is "used to evacuate."

2. *Could have* + past participle — Unrealized past possibility

Form: subject + *could have* + past participle. Use this to describe something that was possible in the past but did not actually happen. It often appears in discussions of "what might have happened instead."

- "They **could have left** earlier, but the roads were still open, so they waited."
- Negative form: "The rescue team **couldn't have arrived** any faster — the roads were blocked."

Common error: Do not confuse *could have* (past possibility) with *could* (general past ability): "She could swim" (general ability) vs. "She could have swum across, but she chose to wait for the boat" (unused option).

3. *Should have* + past participle — Regret or criticism

Form: subject + *should have* + past participle. Use this to express that a past action was the right/wrong choice, usually with a tone of regret, criticism, or advice about the past.

- "We **should have packed** the emergency kit before the season started."
- Negative form: "The officials **shouldn't have waited** so long to issue the warning."

Common error: In fast speech, *should have* is often reduced to "should've" or informally "shoulda." In writing, always use the full or contracted form: **should have / should've** — never "should of."

4. *Was/were able to* + base verb — Specific past ability or success

Form: subject + *was/were able to* + base verb. Use this for a specific instance of successfully doing something in the past, especially when it required effort or overcoming difficulty. It differs from *could* because it emphasizes a completed, successful result.

- "Firefighters **were able to** contain the blaze within two days."
- "Despite the flooding, the driver **was able to** reach higher ground safely."

Common error: Do not use *could* for a single completed successful action. NOT "I could finish evacuating before the storm hit" — correct is "I **was able to** finish evacuating before the storm hit."

5. *Had to* + base verb — Past necessity or obligation

Form: subject + *had to* + base verb. Use this for something that was necessary or required in the past, often due to rules, circumstances, or emergencies.

- "After the earthquake, families **had to** stay in shelters for several nights."
- Negative form: "They **didn't have to** rebuild the whole house — only the roof needed repair."

Common error: Do not use "must" for past obligation — *must* has no past form. NOT "We must evacuate yesterday" — correct is "We **had to** evacuate yesterday."

Indirect/Reported Speech

When we retell what someone said, we usually do not repeat their exact words. Instead, we report the idea, often shifting the verb tense back one step and changing pronouns to match the new speaker's perspective.

Direct Speech	Indirect (Reported) Speech
"Evacuate now," the officer said.	The officer told us to evacuate immediately.
"The water is rising," she said.	She said that the water was rising .
"Did you take your medication?" the nurse asked.	The nurse asked if/whether I had taken my medication.
"We will open a shelter tonight," the mayor announced.	The mayor announced that they would open a shelter that night.

Key patterns:

- Statements: *said/told* + (*that*) + *clause* (present → past; will → would; can → could)
- Commands/requests: *told/asked/warned* + *object* + (*not*) + *to* + *base verb* ("Leave now" → "She told them to leave immediately.")
- Yes/No questions: *asked* + *if/whether* + *clause* (word order changes to statement order, no auxiliary at the front)
- Time/place words often shift: *now* → *then*; *today* → *that day*; *here* → *there*; *tomorrow* → *the next day*

Common error: Do not keep question word order in reported questions. NOT "He asked did I have a kit." Correct: "He asked **if I had** a kit."

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Multiple Choice — Choose the correct past modal.

1. Before smartphones, people (used to / had to) rely on radio for storm alerts.

2. The family (should have / could have) packed the car sooner, but they didn't expect the flood to rise so fast.
3. After the road collapsed, drivers (had to / used to) take a longer route to town.
4. Thanks to the new alert system, the fire department (was able to / used to) warn residents ten minutes earlier than before.
5. Looking back, the city (should have / was able to) invested in better flood walls years ago.

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank — Complete each sentence with the correct form of the modal in parentheses.

1. If the alert had come sooner, the family _____ (could / evacuate) before dark.
2. When I was a child, my grandparents _____ (used to / keep) candles ready for power outages.
3. Because of the mandatory order, everyone in the neighborhood _____ (had to / leave) within an hour.
4. Despite the damage, the rescue team _____ (was able to / reach) every trapped resident.
5. Many survivors said that officials _____ (should / warn) them earlier about the storm's strength.

Activity 3: Sentence Writing — Direct to Indirect Speech. Rewrite each direct quotation as indirect/reported speech.

1. The officer said, "Leave your homes immediately."
2. The forecaster said, "A storm will arrive tonight."
3. The survivor said, "I lost everything in the flood."
4. The nurse asked, "Do you need any medical supplies?"
5. The mayor announced, "We are opening two new shelters."

Writing Assignment

This module's writing task is a **short informational/news-style paragraph**, tied directly to the COR objective of developing informational writing with facts, details, and a conclusion. Students will report on a natural disaster or describe an emergency preparedness plan, using facts and specific details the way a news article does — clear, organized, and focused on informing the reader rather than expressing personal feelings.

Parts of an Informational/News-Style Paragraph

Part	Purpose
Topic Sentence (Lead)	Introduces the event or topic and answers a key question (what, where, when)
Supporting Detail 1	Gives a specific fact or piece of information (cause, statistic, action taken)
Supporting Detail 2	Gives another specific fact or detail (effect, response, additional context)
Supporting Detail 3	Gives a final fact or detail (outcome, current status, lesson learned)
Concluding Sentence	Summarizes the situation or notes what comes next

Topic Choices

Option	Topic
1	Report on a real natural disaster (earthquake, wildfire, flood, hurricane, etc.) that you remember or have researched
2	Describe your family's (or a family you know's) emergency preparedness plan
3	Describe how a school, workplace, or community organized its emergency response

Option	Topic
4	Report on a natural disaster that happened in your home country before you moved to the U.S.
5	Student choice: propose your own disaster/preparedness-related topic (requires instructor approval)

Assignment Requirements

- Length: 8–10 sentences (one well-developed paragraph)
- Format: topic sentence + at least 3 supporting details (facts) + conclusion
- Grammar focus: include at least **two past modals** (*used to*, *could have*, *should have*, *was able to*, *had to*) and **one example of indirect/reported speech** (e.g., quoting what an official, survivor, or family member said)
- Use at least **4 vocabulary words** from this module's list
- Use at least **2 transition words** from the table below to connect ideas
- Submit through one of the three multimodal options listed at the end of this section

Transition Words for Informational Writing

Transition Word/Phrase	Function
First, Next, Then, Finally	Sequence of events
As a result, Because of this	Cause and effect
In addition, Also, Furthermore	Adding information
However, On the other hand	Contrast
In conclusion, Overall	Summarizing

Model Text

Preparing for Wildfire Season

Every summer, wildfire season brings new challenges to families living near the hills of Southern California. Last August, a wildfire started only two miles from my cousin's neighborhood, and the county issued an evacuation warning within hours. As a result, my cousin's family had to leave their home quickly, taking only their emergency kit and important documents. Because they had practiced their evacuation plan earlier that year, they were able to load the car and leave within fifteen minutes. A neighbor later said that the family should have left even sooner, since the smoke had already turned the sky orange by midday. In addition, the fire department warned residents that conditions could get worse overnight. Fortunately, firefighters were able to contain the fire before it reached any houses. In conclusion, my cousin's experience shows that a clear plan and a ready emergency kit can make a stressful evacuation much safer.

The Writing Process

Step 1: Prewrite — Use the graphic organizer below to plan your facts and details before writing.

Prewriting Organizer	Your Notes
Topic Sentence (What event/plan? Where? When?)	
Supporting Detail 1 (Fact/cause)	
Supporting Detail 2 (Fact/response)	
Supporting Detail 3 (Fact/outcome)	
Past Modals to Include (list 2)	

Prewriting Organizer	Your Notes
Reported Speech Example (who said what?)	
Concluding Sentence	

Step 2: Draft — Write your full paragraph using your prewriting notes.

Step 3: Revise — Check your ideas and organization using the checklist below.

Revision Checklist	Yes/No
Does my topic sentence clearly introduce the event or plan?	
Do I have at least 3 supporting details with specific facts?	
Did I include at least 2 past modals correctly?	
Did I include one example of reported/indirect speech?	
Did I use at least 2 transition words?	
Does my conclusion summarize the paragraph?	

Step 4: Edit — Check grammar, spelling, capitalization, and punctuation. Read your paragraph aloud to catch errors.

Step 5: Publish — Submit your final paragraph using one of the options below.

Grading Rubric (20 points)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (3 pts)	Beginning (1–2 pts)
Organization	Clear topic sentence, 3+ details, strong conclusion	Mostly clear structure, minor gaps	Structure present but underdeveloped	Missing topic sentence or conclusion
Grammar Focus (past modals + reported speech)	Both used accurately and naturally	Both present, minor errors	Only one type used correctly	Modals/reported speech missing or incorrect
Vocabulary Use	4+ words used accurately and naturally	3 words used correctly	2 words used, some inaccuracy	Fewer than 2 words used
Mechanics	Few/no errors in grammar, spelling, punctuation	Minor errors that don't affect meaning	Several errors affecting clarity	Frequent errors that block understanding

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 — Typed:** Type your paragraph and submit through the Canvas assignment tool, or hand a printed copy to your instructor in class.
- **Option 2 — Handwritten + Photo:** Write your paragraph by hand, take a clear photo, and upload the image to Canvas (or give the paper copy to your instructor if attending in-person). This option supports students with limited digital literacy.
- **Option 3 — Audio Recording:** Record yourself reading your paragraph aloud and upload the audio file to Canvas, or play it for your instructor during a Zoom or in-person session. This option builds oral fluency and supports students who need an accessible alternative to typing.

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

Part 1: Share a personal or family experience with a natural disaster or emergency (an earthquake, flood, storm, fire, or another event). What happened? What did your family do?

Part 2: Compare your experience with at least one classmate's post. What is similar? What is different about how your families prepared or responded?

Part 3: Give one piece of advice. Based on what you now know from this module, what should a family do differently to be better prepared? Use at least one past modal (*should have*, *could have*) in your advice.

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	5–7 sentences responding to Parts 1–3; use at least 1 vocabulary word and 1 past modal	10
Reply 1	2–3 sentences responding to a classmate's experience with a genuine comparison	5
Reply 2	2–3 sentences responding to a different classmate, offering support or advice	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Introducing your experience	"One experience my family had with a natural disaster was _____."
Describing what happened	"When the _____ happened, we had to _____."
Expressing regret/reflection	"Looking back, we should have _____."
Comparing with a classmate	"Similar to you, my family also _____ / Unlike you, my family _____."
Giving advice	"I think families should _____ because _____."

Functional/Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrases
Stating an opinion	"In my opinion... / I believe that... / From my point of view..."
Supporting with a reason	"This is because... / One reason is... / For example..."
Comparing	"Similarly... / In contrast... / Just like your family, mine..."
Agreeing	"I agree with you because... / That's a good point, and..."
Disagreeing (respectfully)	"I see it a little differently... / I understand, but I think..."

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person students will discuss the prompt orally in small groups of 3–4, then one member of each group will briefly report their group's comparison back to the whole class. **Zoom** students will be placed into breakout rooms of 3–4 to discuss the same prompt aloud, taking turns sharing their experience and advice, with the option to jot notes in a shared Google Doc or the Zoom chat before returning to the main session. **Canvas** students will complete the discussion asynchronously: they will post their original response to the discussion board by the posted deadline and reply to two classmates' posts within the following two days, following the same content requirements as the in-person and Zoom groups.

Discussion Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (3 pts)	Beginning (1–2 pts)
Content/Task Completion	Fully answers all 3 parts of the prompt with detail	Answers most parts with adequate detail	Answers only part of the prompt	Minimal or off-topic response
Grammar Use (past modals)	Uses past modals accurately and naturally	Uses past modals with minor errors	Attempts past modals with several errors	Past modals missing or unclear
Comparison and Engagement	Thoughtfully compares and responds to classmates	Compares and responds adequately	Comparison is vague or generic	Little to no engagement with classmates
Vocabulary and Language Use	Uses vocabulary and sentence frames naturally and correctly	Uses vocabulary correctly with minor errors	Limited or repetitive vocabulary use	Little to no target vocabulary used

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is ungraded practice. Use it to check your own understanding before the graded assignments. Review any section where you feel unsure.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word (1–10) to its definition (a–j).

1. evacuate
2. shelter
3. emergency kit
4. alert
5. aftermath
6. precaution
7. survivor
8. damage
9. warning
10. response

a. harm caused to something b. a person who lives through a dangerous event c. to leave a dangerous area d. the period after a disaster e. a set of supplies kept ready for an emergency f. an action taken action taken to prevent harm g. a place that offers protection h. the actions taken to deal with an emergency i. a warning message sent about danger j. a statement telling people about possible danger

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. After the flood, the (aftermath / warning) left many streets covered in mud.
2. The fire department's fast (response / shelter) saved several homes.
3. Every family should have a (precaution / emergency kit) ready before storm season.
4. The (survivor / damage) to the bridge was so severe that it had to be closed.
5. Local officials issued an (alert / aftermath) about rising river levels.
6. Wearing a mask during heavy smoke is a simple (precaution / response).
7. Hundreds of people found (damage / shelter) in the school gymnasium.

8. The news interviewed a (survivor / warning) who described escaping the wildfire.

Section 3: Grammar Identification/Application

Choose the correct past modal or rewrite in reported speech, as indicated.

- Before the new alert system, people (used to / had to) wait for the newspaper for storm news.
- The family (should have / used to) packed water bottles, but they forgot in the rush.
- Because of the mandatory evacuation, residents (had to / could have) leave within the hour.
- The rescue workers (were able to / used to) reach the stranded family by boat.
- Looking back, the city (should have / was able to) built stronger flood walls.
- Rewrite in reported speech: The officer said, "Stay away from the river."
- Rewrite in reported speech: The forecaster said, "The storm will hit tonight."
- Rewrite in reported speech: The nurse asked, "Do you have any injuries?"
- Choose the modal: If they had left earlier, they _____ (avoid) the traffic.
- Choose the modal: When I was young, my family _____ (keep) candles for outages.

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the error in each sentence.

- The officials should of warned us sooner.
- Before, my family use to keep flashlights in every room.
- She could swim across the flooded street to reach her neighbor, so she did.
- The officer asked did we need help.
- We must evacuate last night because of the fire.
- The rescue team could reach the trapped hikers before the storm returned.
- He said that he will call once the roads reopened.
- They didn't had to leave because the fire changed direction.

Section 5: Short Writing Check

Prompt: In 3–4 sentences, describe one thing a family should have done differently before a natural disaster, using at least one past modal and one vocabulary word from this module.

Self-Evaluation Checklist	Yes/No
I used at least one past modal correctly.	
I used at least one vocabulary word from this module.	
My sentences are complete, with correct capitalization and punctuation.	
My writing clearly expresses a regret, possibility, or piece of advice.	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Quiz me on the 10 disaster/emergency vocabulary words from Module 2 with example sentences."	A short interactive quiz with feedback on your answers
Grammar	"Give me 5 sentences with blanks so I can practice choosing between could have, should have, and had to."	Practice sentences with immediate correction and explanation
Writing Feedback	"Here is my informational paragraph about a natural disaster. Can you check my past modals, reported speech, and paragraph structure?"	Specific feedback on grammar accuracy, organization, and vocabulary use
Discussion Practice	"Role-play a conversation with me where you share a family emergency story and I respond with a comparison and advice using past modals."	A simulated conversation to practice speaking/writing before posting on the discussion board

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity A: Sentence Combining Combine each pair of sentences using a past modal.

1. The family did not evacuate early. This was a mistake. → _____
2. The road was blocked. The firefighters found another way. → _____
3. In the past, people did not have text alerts. They used the radio. → _____

Activity B: Subject-Verb Agreement Review Correct the subject-verb agreement error in each sentence.

1. The emergency kits was placed near the front door.
2. Every survivor have a different story to tell.
3. The warnings was sent to all residents.

Activity C: Word Forms Complete the chart with the correct word form.

Noun	Verb	Adjective
preparation	prepare	_____
damage	_____	damaged
survival	survive	_____

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Free drop-in and appointment-based tutoring for reading, writing, and grammar support. Available in-person and online for students in any delivery mode.
- **Writing Center:** One-on-one help with brainstorming, drafting, and revising written assignments, including this module's informational paragraph.
- **Library:** Access to research databases, quiet study space, and librarian assistance for finding reliable information on topics like natural disasters for writing assignments.
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and support services for students with documented disabilities, including extended time, alternative formats, and assistive technology.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary by Skill Area

Skill Area	What Students Learned
Reading/Vocabulary	Read an informational passage on disaster preparedness; learned 10 key vocabulary words; practiced identifying facts vs. opinions
Grammar	Used past modals (<i>used to</i> , <i>could have</i> , <i>should have</i> , <i>was able to</i> , <i>had to</i>) to express habits, regret, possibility, ability, and obligation; converted direct speech into indirect/reported speech
Writing/Communication	Wrote an informational/news-style paragraph with facts, details, and a conclusion; discussed personal/family disaster experiences and gave advice using past modals

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
Purdue OWL: Verb Tenses	Review of modal verbs and past tense usage for writing	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_w...ses/index.html
VOA Learning English	Listening practice with news-style reports, including disaster coverage, at a learner-friendly pace	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/
BBC Learning English	Grammar and vocabulary lessons, including modal verbs and reported speech	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Simple definitions and example sentences for vocabulary words like <i>evacuate</i> , <i>shelter</i> , and <i>damage</i>	https://learnersdictionary.com/
Ready.gov	Official U.S. government guidance on building an emergency kit and family emergency plans	https://www.ready.gov/
USA.gov: Disaster and Emergency Preparedness	Official information on disaster types, alerts, and community preparedness resources	https://www.usa.gov/disasters

Looking Ahead

This Module	Connects to Future Learning
Past modals for hypothetical/regret situations	Builds toward more advanced conditional forms and hypothetical reasoning in later modules
Indirect/reported speech	Prepares students for retelling information in interviews, presentations, and workplace communication
Informational/news-style writing	Builds toward the oral presentation (introduction, details, conclusion) and persuasive writing in future modules
Note-taking and inferring meaning from context	Strengthens listening skills needed for future academic and workplace-related listening tasks

Reflection Questions

1. What new vocabulary word from this module do you think will be most useful in real life, and why?

2. Which past modal (*used to*, *could have*, *should have*, *was able to*, *had to*) did you find most difficult to use correctly? Why?
3. How did comparing your experience with a classmate's experience change or confirm your own thinking about emergency preparedness?
4. What is one thing you learned in this module that you plan to apply to your own family's emergency plan?
5. Which activity in this module helped you learn the most — the reading, the grammar practice, the writing assignment, or the discussion board? Explain.

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 2: Natural Disasters and Emergency Preparedness | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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3: Advocacy and Community Engagement

Module 3: Advocacy and Community Engagement

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Every neighborhood has problems that residents notice before anyone else does: a broken streetlight, a dangerous crosswalk, a park that needs repair, or a bus route that does not run often enough. In many communities, the people who fix these problems are ordinary residents who decide to speak up. In this module, students learn the language of civic participation — how to describe a community problem clearly, connect it to the people affected, and communicate directly with the local government office or representative who can help solve it. Students will practice combining ideas smoothly with adjectival clauses and conjunctive adverbs, ask questions that invite agreement with tag questions, and organize persuasive spoken and written arguments using parallel structure. By the end of the module, students will have written a real advocacy letter and discussed community problems with classmates — building confidence as English speakers and as engaged members of their communities.

In this module, students will:

- Learn and use 10 vocabulary words related to civic participation and local government
- Read and analyze an authentic-style article about a community advocacy campaign
- Study and practice tag questions, adjectival clauses (who/which), parallel structure, and conjunctive adverbs
- Write a persuasive letter or email to a local government agency or representative
- Participate in a structured discussion about a community problem and possible solutions
- Practice oral presentation skills, organizing ideas into an introduction, details, and a conclusion

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Identify the main idea and supporting details of an authentic-style text about civic advocacy; compare and contrast two approaches to solving a community problem
Vocabulary	Define and correctly use 10 civic/community words in speaking and writing
Grammar	Form and use tag questions with correct rising/falling intonation; combine sentences using adjectival clauses with who/which; write sentences with parallel structure; connect ideas across sentences using conjunctive adverbs
Writing	Write a clearly organized letter or email to a local government agency or representative that states a community problem, explains its effect on residents, and requests specific action
Speaking and Listening	Present an opinion about a community problem in a well-organized short oral presentation (introduction, details, conclusion); build on a classmate's idea in a discussion using appropriate functional language

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1	Introduce module theme and vocabulary; preview civic/community word list with visuals and real-life context	In-class/live notebook entry vocabulary
1	Day 2	Read "Neighbors Who Speak Up" and complete comprehension questions; introduce reading strategy (compare/contrast)	Comprehension Questions Check
1	Day 3	Grammar Lesson: tag questions and adjectival clauses (who/which); guided and independent practice	Grammar Practice Activities 1–2
1	Day 4 (In-person: pair discussion in class about a local problem; Zoom: breakout rooms of 3 discussing the same prompt with a shared Google Doc; Canvas: asynchronous discussion board post with two required replies)	Discussion Board original post	Discussion Board original post
2	Day 5	Grammar Lesson continued: parallel structure and conjunctive adverbs; sentence-combining practice	Grammar Practice Activity 3
2	Day 6	Writing Assignment: introduce letter/email format, model text analysis, prewriting graphic organizer	Prewriting organizer draft
2	Day 7	Writing workshop: peer review using revision checklist; oral presentation practice (intro/details/conclusion) for 2-minute partner presentations	Peer feedback form; draft revision
2	Day 8	Final writing submission; Self-Check Quiz review; AI Tutor practice session	Advocacy letter/email final draft; Self-Check Quiz (ungraded)

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Tag questions	To confirm information, check agreement, or invite a listener into conversation	"The city council meets on Tuesdays, doesn't it?"
Adjectival clauses (who/which)	To combine two sentences by describing a person or thing with extra information	"The representative who answered my email scheduled a meeting."

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Parallel structure	To make a list of actions, qualities, or ideas grammatically consistent and easy to follow	"Residents want the city to repair the sidewalk, install new lighting, and add a crosswalk."
Conjunctive adverbs	To connect two related independent ideas and show a logical relationship (addition, contrast, result) between them	"The park has no working lights; therefore, residents avoid it after dark."

Delivery Mode Note

This module is designed to work equally well **in-person, on Zoom, and on Canvas LMS**. In-person students will complete vocabulary and grammar activities on paper or in a shared class notebook, take part in live pair and small-group discussions, and deliver their oral presentations to a partner or small group in the classroom. Zoom students will use breakout rooms for the same pair/group activities, screen-share the reading passage and grammar tables during whole-class review, and can deliver their oral presentations live during a synchronous session or record a short video. Canvas students will complete the same readings, grammar practice, and writing assignment asynchronously, post to the discussion board with required peer replies instead of live discussion, and may submit their oral presentation as a recorded audio or video file. All three modes lead to the same learning outcomes and the same final products — only the mode of interaction changes.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
advocate	verb / noun	(v.) to publicly support a cause or a group of people; (n.) a person who does this	She decided to advocate for safer crosswalks near the elementary school.
petition	noun / verb	a written request signed by many people asking an authority to take action	Residents created a petition asking the city to fix the broken streetlights.
ordinance	noun	a local law passed by a city or county government	The city council passed a new ordinance limiting noise after 10 p.m.
resident	noun	a person who lives in a particular place	Every resident of the apartment building received a notice about the meeting.
municipal	adjective	relating to a city or town and its local government	The municipal water department is responsible for fixing the leak on Elm Street.
complaint	noun	a formal statement that something is unsatisfactory or unacceptable	Mr. Nguyen filed a complaint about the illegal dumping behind his store.
resolution	noun	a formal decision or solution agreed on by a group, especially a government body	The city council approved a resolution to add more crossing guards near schools.
public hearing	noun phrase	an official meeting where community members can share opinions before a government decision	Dozens of residents spoke at the public hearing about the new bus route.

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
representative	noun	a person elected or chosen to speak and act on behalf of others	Our city council representative promised to look into the parking problem.
civic duty	noun phrase	a responsibility that a person has as a member of a community, such as voting or attending meetings	Voting in local elections is a civic duty that many residents take seriously.

Original Reading: "Neighbors Who Speak Up"

A Problem on Maple Street

For three years, the residents of Maple Street lived with a problem that most drivers ignored: a crosswalk near Lincoln Elementary School had no working light and no clear paint on the pavement. Parents who walked their children to school every morning worried about the fast traffic. One mother, Elena Ramirez, decided she had waited long enough. "I am not a politician," she said, "but I am a resident, and I have a civic duty to speak up when children are in danger."

Starting with a Petition

Elena did not know exactly how local government worked, so she began with research. She learned that small changes to a street, like a new crosswalk light, usually require a municipal budget decision, which the city council must approve. She also learned that a public hearing is often the first step: a meeting where residents can explain a problem directly to the people who make decisions. Before the hearing, Elena and several neighbors created a petition. They walked through the neighborhood for two weekends, explaining the problem and asking residents to sign. In total, they collected 240 signatures — proof that the crosswalk mattered to many people, not just one family.

Comparing Two Approaches

Not every advocate chooses the same strategy. While Elena focused on a petition and a public hearing, her neighbor Tom Okafor took a different approach: he filed a formal complaint directly with the city's Department of Transportation and requested a meeting with his district's representative. Both approaches had advantages. The petition showed broad community support and encouraged more neighbors to get involved, whereas the direct complaint moved faster through official channels because it went straight to the department responsible for street safety. In the end, Elena and Tom combined their efforts. They attended the public hearing together, and Tom's contact inside the department helped move their shared request to the top of the list.

A Resolution and a Lesson

At the public hearing, Elena stood at the microphone with a folder of signatures. "The families who cross this street every morning," she said, "deserve a safe crossing, doesn't that seem reasonable to everyone here?" The council members, who had reviewed Tom's complaint the week before, already understood the urgency. Two months later, the city council passed a resolution approving funds for a new traffic light, fresh paint, and a crossing guard during school hours. The ordinance took effect the following semester.

What Other Residents Can Learn

Elena's story is not unusual. Community advocates across the country use similar tools: petitions, public hearings, formal complaints, and direct contact with a representative. What matters most, community organizers say, is persistence and clear communication. A resident who explains a problem calmly, backs it up with evidence, and proposes a specific solution is far more likely to see change than one who only complains without offering an answer. As Elena put it, "I did not fix the crosswalk myself. However, I made sure the right people knew exactly what needed to happen — and why."

(Word count: approximately 510 words)

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word Bank: advocate, petition, ordinance, resident, municipal, complaint, resolution, public hearing, representative, civic duty

1. Every _____ of the building signed the letter about the broken elevator.

2. The neighborhood group collected 300 signatures on a _____ asking for a new stop sign.
3. The city passed an _____ requiring all restaurants to recycle food waste.
4. She decided to _____ for better lighting in the park because she believed it would reduce crime.
5. The _____ water department shut off service for repairs on Tuesday.
6. He filed a formal _____ with the housing office about the mold in his apartment.
7. Voting in local elections and attending community meetings are examples of _____.
8. The city council will hold a _____ next month so residents can share their opinions about the new bus route.
9. Our district's _____ promised to bring the issue to the next council meeting.
10. After months of discussion, the council approved a _____ to fund new sidewalks downtown.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. What problem did residents of Maple Street want the city to fix?
2. What two steps did Elena take before the public hearing?
3. How did Tom Okafor's approach differ from Elena's?
4. What did the city council finally decide to do?
5. According to the reading, what two qualities make a resident's advocacy more likely to succeed?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Think of a problem in your own neighborhood, workplace, or school. Who would you contact about it, and why?
2. Elena says, "I did not fix the crosswalk myself. However, I made sure the right people knew exactly what needed to happen." Do you agree that this is usually how change happens in a community? Explain your opinion with a reason from your own experience.

Reading Strategy: Compare and Contrast

Compare and contrast is a reading strategy in which the reader identifies similarities and differences between two people, ideas, or approaches in a text. Writers often use signal words like *while*, *whereas*, *both*, *similarly*, *in contrast*, and *however* to highlight these relationships. Recognizing compare/contrast structure helps readers understand why a writer includes two examples instead of one, and it often reveals the writer's deeper point.

Signal Word/Phrase	What It Shows	Example from "Neighbors Who Speak Up"
while / whereas	Introduces a difference between two things	"While Elena focused on a petition and a public hearing, her neighbor Tom Okafor took a different approach."
both	Shows something shared by two subjects	"Both approaches had advantages."
in the end / combined	Shows how two different things came together	"In the end, Elena and Tom combined their efforts."

Grammar Lesson

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Tag questions	Statement + comma + auxiliary/modal + (not) + subject pronoun	To confirm information or invite agreement/response from a listener	isn't it, doesn't it, don't you, won't they, is it, can't he	"The council meeting is tonight, isn't it?"

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Adjectival clauses (who/which)	Main clause + who/which + verb phrase (who = people; which = things)	To combine two related sentences and add descriptive detail about a noun	who, which, that (informal)	"The representative who spoke at the hearing is new to the district."
Parallel structure	Repeated grammatical form (all nouns, all -ing verbs, all infinitives) in a list or comparison	To make writing and speech clear, balanced, and professional-sounding	and, or, but; lists of 2+ items	"The plan will improve safety, reduce traffic, and save money."
Conjunctive adverbs	Independent clause + semicolon + conjunctive adverb + comma + independent clause (or as a sentence opener)	To show a logical relationship (addition, contrast, result, sequence) between two complete ideas	however, therefore, in addition, moreover, as a result, nevertheless, consequently	"The park needs new equipment; however, the city has not budgeted for it this year."

Tag Questions: Form and Intonation

Tag questions turn a statement into a question that invites a response. They follow a simple pattern: if the statement is **positive**, the tag is usually **negative**; if the statement is **negative**, the tag is usually **positive**.

- The mayor **is** coming to the meeting, **isn't she**?
- The residents **didn't** receive a response, **did they**?
- You **can** attend the public hearing, **can't you**?

Pronunciation note (COR pronunciation strand): Intonation changes the meaning of a tag question. A **falling** intonation on the tag (voice drops) means the speaker is fairly certain and is simply confirming information. A **rising** intonation on the tag (voice goes up) means the speaker is genuinely unsure and is really asking a question. Practice saying "The meeting starts at 7:00, doesn't it?" first with falling intonation (confirming) and then with rising intonation (truly asking) — notice how the meaning shifts slightly even though the words stay the same.

Common errors: Using the wrong auxiliary in the tag (matching the main verb, not "do/does/did" incorrectly), forgetting to reverse positive/negative, and forgetting to match the pronoun to the subject (e.g., "Maria and Jon are coming, aren't they?" — not "isn't he").

Adjectival Clauses with Who and Which

An adjectival clause (also called a relative clause) describes a noun and is introduced by a relative pronoun. Use **who** for people and **which** for things, animals, or ideas (not people).

- The advocate **who organized the petition** lives on Maple Street. (describes a person)
- The ordinance **which the council passed last month** takes effect in July. (describes a thing)

Adjectival clauses can be combined from two shorter sentences:

- Two sentences: "The representative answered my email. The representative scheduled a meeting."
- Combined: "The representative **who answered my email** scheduled a meeting."

Common errors: Using "which" for people ("the woman which spoke" ✗ → "the woman who spoke" ✓); forgetting the relative pronoun entirely; creating a sentence fragment by leaving the adjectival clause without a main clause attached.

Parallel Structure

Parallel structure means using the same grammatical form for items in a series or comparison. This makes sentences clearer and sound more professional — an important skill for advocacy writing and public speaking.

- **Not parallel:** "The group wants to repair the sidewalk, adding new lights, and to plant trees."
- **Parallel:** "The group wants to repair the sidewalk, add new lights, and plant trees."

Parallel structure applies to verbs, nouns, adjectives, and infinitive/gerund phrases:

- Verbs: "She called the office, wrote a letter, and attended the hearing."
- Adjectives: "The proposal is clear, reasonable, and affordable."
- Gerunds: "Advocacy involves researching, organizing, and communicating."

Common errors: Mixing verb forms within one list (e.g., mixing "-ing" and base form); mixing nouns and clauses in the same series; forgetting to repeat a needed word (like "to" before every infinitive) when clarity requires it.

Conjunctive Adverbs

Conjunctive adverbs connect two independent (complete) ideas and show how they relate to each other — addition, contrast, cause/result, or sequence.

Relationship	Common Conjunctive Adverbs
Addition	in addition, moreover, furthermore, also
Contrast	however, nevertheless, on the other hand, still
Result/Cause	therefore, as a result, consequently, thus
Sequence	then, next, finally, meanwhile

Punctuation pattern: independent clause ; conjunctive adverb , independent clause.

- "The city council reviewed the petition; **however**, it did not approve funding immediately."
- "Residents attended the hearing. **In addition**, they submitted written comments."

Common errors: Using only a comma instead of a semicolon or period before the conjunctive adverb (creating a run-on/comma splice); forgetting the comma after the conjunctive adverb; confusing conjunctive adverbs with coordinating conjunctions (however vs. but — "however" cannot directly join clauses with only a comma).

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Multiple Choice — Tag Questions

Choose the correct tag to complete each sentence.

1. The public hearing starts at 6:00 p.m., _____?
a) doesn't it b) isn't it c) does it
1. The residents haven't received an answer yet, _____?
a) haven't they b) have they c) didn't they
1. You can come to the meeting on Thursday, _____?
a) can't you b) don't you c) can you
1. The council members won't vote until next week, _____?
a) will they b) won't they c) don't they
1. Elena organized the petition, _____?
a) doesn't she b) isn't she c) didn't she

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank — Adjectival Clauses

Combine each pair of sentences using **who** or **which**.

1. The petition collected 240 signatures. The petition was created by neighbors.
2. The representative visited Maple Street. The representative wanted to see the crosswalk.
3. The ordinance passed last spring. The ordinance requires new lighting downtown.

4. The residents spoke at the hearing. The residents live near the park.
5. The department received the complaint. The department is responsible for street repairs.

Activity 3: Sentence Writing — Parallel Structure and Conjunctive Adverbs

Rewrite each sentence to fix the parallel structure error, OR combine the two sentences using an appropriate conjunctive adverb.

1. Fix parallel structure: "The plan will save money, improving safety, and reducing traffic."
2. Fix parallel structure: "Good advocates listen carefully, ask clear questions, and are being persistent."
3. Combine with a conjunctive adverb (contrast): "The city approved the petition. It has not released the funds yet."
4. Combine with a conjunctive adverb (addition): "Residents attended the public hearing. They wrote letters to the newspaper."
5. Combine with a conjunctive adverb (result): "The crosswalk had no working light. Several accidents occurred there."

Writing Assignment

The Letter/Email of Advocacy

In this module, students write a short, persuasive **letter or email to a local government agency or elected representative** advocating for a specific community improvement. This assignment builds directly on the COR objective of composing a well-constructed short email or letter with supporting details, using academic/content-specific vocabulary for tone, and it connects that skill to real civic participation. A strong advocacy letter states the problem clearly, explains who is affected and why it matters, and requests a specific, realistic action.

Parts of an Advocacy Letter/Email

Part	Purpose
Greeting	Addresses the correct person or office respectfully (e.g., "Dear Council Member Diaz," or "To the Department of Public Works,")
Opening statement	Introduces the writer and states the purpose of the letter in one or two sentences
Body: description of the problem	Explains the specific community problem with concrete details (location, how long it has existed, who is affected)
Body: request for action	States a specific, realistic solution or action the writer would like the agency/representative to take
Closing statement	Thanks the reader for their time and expresses willingness to provide more information
Signature	Writer's name and, if appropriate, address or contact information

Topic Choices

Option	Description
1. Street or traffic safety	Write to your city's Department of Transportation or a council member about an unsafe street, crosswalk, or intersection
2. Public space improvement	Write to your local Parks and Recreation department about a park, playground, or public space that needs repair or improvement
3. Sanitation or housing concern	Write to your city or county housing/health department about a sanitation, trash, or building-maintenance issue affecting residents
4. Public transportation	Write to your local transit authority about a bus route, schedule, or bus stop that needs improvement

Option	Description
5. Student's choice (instructor approval required)	Propose your own community issue and the appropriate agency or representative to contact; must be approved by the instructor before drafting begins

Assignment Requirements

- Length: 150–200 words (one clear paragraph structure or 3–4 short paragraphs)
- Format: business letter or email format, following the parts listed above
- Must include: at least **one tag question** used naturally (for example, in a closing line inviting response), at least **one adjectival clause with who or which**, at least **one example of parallel structure** (a list of 2–3 items or requests), and at least **one conjunctive adverb** connecting two related ideas
- Must use at least **4 of the 10 module vocabulary words** naturally
- Must state the problem, explain its effect on residents, and request a specific, realistic action
- Tone must remain respectful and professional throughout, even when describing a frustrating problem

Transition Words for Advocacy Writing

Transition/Conjunctive Adverb	Use
In addition	Adding another point or request
However	Introducing a contrast or concern
Therefore / As a result	Showing a consequence or conclusion
For example	Introducing a specific detail or evidence
Finally	Introducing the last point or the request for action

Model Text

> Dear Council Member Torres, > > My name is Kim Tran, and I am a resident of the Westview neighborhood. I am writing to ask the city to install a new streetlight at the corner of Birch Avenue and 5th Street. > > For over a year, this corner has had no working light. Several neighbors, including elderly residents who walk to the bus stop before sunrise, have told me they feel unsafe crossing there in the dark. Last month, a resident who was walking home was almost struck by a car because the driver could not see her. This is not a small problem; it is a safety issue that affects dozens of families every day. > > I am asking the city to repair the existing light, add reflective paint to the crosswalk, and consider a temporary solar light until permanent repairs are complete. A public hearing on street safety is coming up next month, and I plan to attend. However, I wanted to reach out to you directly first, since you represent our district. > > Thank you for your attention to this issue. You have supported similar safety projects before, haven't you? I would be happy to gather signatures from neighbors if that would help move this request forward. > > Sincerely, > Kim Tran > Westview Neighborhood Resident

The Writing Process

Step 1 — Prewrite: Choose a topic and complete the graphic organizer below.

Prewriting Question	Your Notes
What is the specific problem?	
Where is it, and how long has it existed?	
Who is affected, and how?	
Who is the correct agency or representative to contact?	
What specific action are you requesting?	

Prewriting Question	Your Notes
Which 4 vocabulary words will you use?	

Step 2 — Draft: Write a complete first draft following the Parts of an Advocacy Letter/Email table. Do not worry about perfect grammar yet — focus on getting your ideas down clearly.

Step 3 — Revise: Reread your draft for content and organization using the checklist below.

Revision Checklist	Yes/No
Does my letter clearly state the problem in the opening?	
Do I explain who is affected and why it matters?	
Do I request a specific, realistic action?	
Do I use at least 4 vocabulary words naturally?	
Do I include a tag question, an adjectival clause, parallel structure, and a conjunctive adverb?	
Is my tone respectful and professional throughout?	

Step 4 — Edit: Check capitalization, punctuation (especially semicolons before conjunctive adverbs), spelling, and subject-verb agreement. Read your letter aloud to catch awkward phrasing.

Step 5 — Publish: Submit your final letter using one of the Multimodal Submission Options below.

Grading Rubric (20 points)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (3 pts)	Beginning (1–2 pts)
Content & Organization	Problem, effect, and request are all clear and well-organized	Content is present but organization is slightly unclear	Content is incomplete or organization is confusing	Problem or request is missing or very unclear
Grammar Focus (tag question, adjectival clause, parallel structure, conjunctive adverb)	All 4 structures used correctly and naturally	3 of 4 structures used correctly	1–2 structures used correctly	Structures missing or used incorrectly throughout
Vocabulary Use	4+ vocabulary words used naturally and correctly	3 vocabulary words used correctly	1–2 vocabulary words used	Little to no module vocabulary used
Tone & Format	Respectful, professional tone; correct letter/email format throughout	Mostly professional tone and format with minor lapses	Tone or format inconsistent	Tone unprofessional or format not followed

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 (Typed):** Type the final letter/email in a Word document or directly into the Canvas text-entry box; in-person students may also type and print.
- **Option 2 (Handwritten + Photo):** Write the letter by hand, then take a clear photo or scan and upload it to Canvas — a good option for students with limited digital literacy or typing speed.
- **Option 3 (Audio Recording):** Record yourself reading the letter aloud as a short audio or video file and submit it along with the written text — this option supports oral fluency practice and provides accessibility for students who process spoken language more easily than text.

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

Part 1: Describe one problem you have noticed in your neighborhood, workplace, or community. Where is it, and who does it affect?

Part 2: Compare your problem to a problem a classmate has described (once posts are visible). What is similar? What is different?

Part 3: Propose one specific action that could help solve your problem. Who should be contacted — a representative, a department, or another organization? Use at least one persuasive phrase and one piece of module vocabulary in your proposal.

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	Answers all 3 parts of the prompt in 5–7 sentences; uses at least 2 vocabulary words	10
Reply 1	Builds on a classmate's idea using functional language (agreeing, adding, or respectfully disagreeing)	5
Reply 2	Compares your proposed solution to a classmate's solution; asks a follow-up question	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Introducing your problem	"One problem I have noticed in my neighborhood is _____."
Explaining who is affected	"This problem affects _____, especially _____."
Comparing to a classmate	"My problem is similar to/different from [Name]'s because _____."
Proposing a solution	"I think the best way to solve this would be to _____."
Building on an idea	"Building on what [Name] said, I would also suggest _____."

Functional/Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrases
Stating an opinion	"In my opinion, ..." / "I believe that ..." / "From my point of view, ..."
Supporting with a reason	"This matters because ..." / "One reason for this is ..." / "For example, ..."
Comparing	"Similarly, ..." / "In contrast, ..." / "Both problems involve ..."
Agreeing	"I agree with [Name] that ..." / "That's a good point, and I would add ..."
Disagreeing respectfully	"I see your point, but I think ..." / "I understand that view; however, I would suggest ..."

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person students will discuss the prompt orally in pairs or small groups of three, taking notes on their partner's problem and proposed solution, and then briefly report one idea back to the whole class. **Zoom** students will be placed in breakout rooms of 2–3 to discuss the same prompt aloud, using a shared Google Doc to jot down each person's problem and solution before returning to the main session for a short whole-group share-out. **Canvas** students will complete the discussion asynchronously: post an original response to the discussion board by the assigned deadline, then return within 48 hours to post two required replies to classmates, following the Discussion Requirements table above.

Discussion Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (3 pts)	Beginning (1–2 pts)
Content/Task Completion	All 3 parts of the prompt fully addressed with specific detail	Most parts addressed with adequate detail	Only 1–2 parts addressed, or details are vague	Prompt not fully addressed
Use of Vocabulary & Language Frames	Uses vocabulary and persuasive phrases naturally and correctly	Uses vocabulary/phrases with minor errors	Limited use of vocabulary/phrases	Little to no module language used
Building on Others' Ideas (Replies)	Both replies clearly build on or respond to classmates' specific ideas	One reply builds on a classmate's idea effectively	Replies are generic or only partially connected to classmates' posts	Replies missing or unrelated to classmates' posts
Clarity & Organization	Post is clearly organized and easy to follow	Post is mostly clear with minor organization issues	Post is somewhat disorganized or hard to follow	Post is very unclear or too brief to evaluate

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is ungraded practice to help you check your own understanding before the module assessments. Use the answer keys to see how you did, and revisit any section that was difficult.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word (1–10) to its definition (a–j).

1. advocate
2. petition
3. ordinance
4. resident
5. municipal
6. complaint
7. resolution
8. public hearing
9. representative
10. civic duty

- a) a person who lives in a particular place b) a local law passed by a city or county government c) a formal decision or solution agreed on by a government body d) relating to a city or town's local government e) a person who speaks and acts on behalf of others f) a written request signed by many people asking for action g) a responsibility a person has as a community member h) a formal statement that something is unsatisfactory i) to publicly support a cause, or a person who does this j) an official meeting where the public can share opinions before a decision

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. The (municipal / civic duty) library extended its hours after residents requested it.
2. Attending the town meeting is part of my (resolution / civic duty) as a community member.
3. Several (residents / representatives) signed the petition about the pothole on Grant Street.
4. The council will hold a (complaint / public hearing) before voting on the new ordinance.
5. Our (advocate / representative) in the state assembly agreed to review the proposal.
6. The neighbors filed a formal (complaint / resolution) about the noise from the construction site.
7. The city passed an (ordinance / petition) banning parking on Main Street during street cleaning.
8. After months of debate, the board approved a (petition / resolution) to fund the new library wing.

Section 3: Grammar Identification/Application

Identify the grammar structure used in each sentence (tag question, adjectival clause, parallel structure, or conjunctive adverb), then complete items 9–12.

1. The bus route hasn't changed in years, has it?
2. The representative who visited last week seemed genuinely interested.
3. The group wants to raise awareness, gather signatures, and meet with officials.
4. The city approved the plan; however, funding is still uncertain.
5. Isn't the public hearing scheduled for Thursday?
6. The ordinance which passed in March affects all downtown businesses.
7. Residents can write letters, attend meetings, or call their representative directly.
8. The park needs new equipment; therefore, the committee is applying for a grant.

For items 9–12, write your own original sentence using the structure named.

1. Write a sentence with a tag question.
2. Write a sentence with an adjectival clause using "who."
3. Write a sentence using parallel structure (a list of 3 items).
4. Write a sentence using a conjunctive adverb to show contrast.

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the error in each sentence.

1. The mayor is attending the meeting, is she?
2. The woman which organized the petition lives on our street.
3. The plan will save money, reducing traffic, and to improve safety.
4. The city approved the request, however they have not released the funds.
5. The residents doesn't agree with the new schedule.
6. The complaint were filed last Tuesday.
7. He is the representative which answered my letter.
8. The council members won't vote today, will they?

Section 5: Short Writing Check

Prompt: In 3–5 sentences, describe one municipal service in your community (such as trash pickup, street repair, or public transportation) and explain one way it could be improved. Try to use at least one adjectival clause and one conjunctive adverb.

Self-Evaluation Checklist	Yes/No
I described a specific municipal service.	
I explained one clear way it could be improved.	
I used at least one adjectival clause (who/which).	
I used at least one conjunctive adverb correctly punctuated.	
I used at least one module vocabulary word.	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Quiz me on the 10 civic vocabulary words from Module 3 — give me a sentence with a blank and let me guess the word."	An interactive vocabulary quiz with immediate feedback
Grammar	"Give me 5 sentences to practice combining with adjectival clauses using who or which, then check my answers."	Extra guided practice with correction and explanation
Writing Feedback	"Here is my draft advocacy letter [paste draft]. Please check if I used a tag question, an adjectival clause, parallel structure, and a conjunctive adverb correctly, and suggest improvements."	Personalized feedback on grammar use and letter organization
Discussion Practice	"I want to practice talking about a community problem. Ask me follow-up questions like a classmate would, and help me practice building on your responses."	Simulated conversation practice for the discussion board task
Pronunciation	"Give me 5 tag questions and explain when I should use rising intonation versus falling intonation for each."	Practice items with intonation guidance for oral rehearsal

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity A: Sentence Combining Combine each pair of sentences using an adjectival clause (who/which) or a conjunctive adverb, your choice.

1. The city council meets every Tuesday. The city council reviews resident complaints.
2. The petition had 500 signatures. The city still delayed its decision.
3. The new ordinance affects downtown businesses. The ordinance passed last month.

Activity B: Subject-Verb Agreement Review (with civic vocabulary) Choose the correct verb form.

1. The residents (wants / want) a faster response from the city.
2. Each representative (has / have) a different district to serve.
3. The committee (meets / meet) every other Thursday.

Activity C: Word Forms Complete the chart with the correct word form.

Noun	Verb	Adjective

Noun	Verb	Adjective
advocacy	advocate	_____
resolution	resolve	_____
_____	complain	_____ / complaining

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Offers free one-on-one and small-group tutoring in reading, writing, and grammar for continuing education students. Drop in or schedule an appointment for extra help with this module's grammar or writing assignment.
- **Writing Center:** Provides feedback on drafts, including advocacy letters and discussion board posts, at any stage of the writing process — from brainstorming to final editing.
- **Library:** Offers access to computers, printing, and research support, including help finding information about local government agencies and representatives for the writing assignment.
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and support services for students with documented disabilities, including extended time, alternative formats, and assistive technology — contact DSPS early in the module if you need accommodations for reading, writing, or oral presentation tasks.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary by Skill Area

Skill	What Students Learned
Reading/Vocabulary	Read an authentic-style article about community advocacy; learned 10 civic/community vocabulary words; practiced the compare/contrast reading strategy
Grammar	Learned to form tag questions with correct intonation; combined sentences using adjectival clauses with who/which; wrote sentences with parallel structure; connected ideas using conjunctive adverbs
Writing/Communication	Wrote a persuasive letter or email to a local government agency or representative; practiced building persuasive, well-organized oral presentations and discussion contributions that build on others' ideas

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
USAGov: Find and Contact Elected Officials	How to identify and contact federal, state, and local elected officials	https://www.usa.gov/elected-officials
USAGov: Where to File a Complaint Against a Government Agency	Step-by-step guidance on filing a formal complaint with a government agency	https://www.usa.gov/government-agency-complaints
VOA Learning English: Everyday Grammar — Tag Questions	Clear grammar explanation and audio examples of tag question intonation	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/...s/3255174.html
Purdue OWL: Adjective or Adverb / Grammar Resources	Reference guide for grammar structures including clause use and sentence combining	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_w...erb/index.html

Resource	What It Covers	URL
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Learner-friendly definitions, pronunciations, and example sentences for vocabulary review	https://www.learnersdictionary.com
BBC Learning English	Free listening and speaking practice, including discussion and opinion-sharing lessons	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish

Looking Ahead

This Module	Connects To
Persuasive letter/email writing	Module 4's business letter/email and job application writing
Adjectival clauses (who/which)	Continued sentence-combining work in later writing assignments
Oral presentation structure (intro/details/conclusion)	Module 4's oral interview practice and future presentation tasks
Civic/community vocabulary	Broader academic and workplace vocabulary development in upcoming modules

Reflection Questions

1. What is one civic vocabulary word from this module that you had never used before? How might you use it outside of class?
2. Which grammar structure, tag questions, adjectival clauses, parallel structure, or conjunctive adverbs, did you find most challenging, and why?
3. After writing your advocacy letter, do you feel more confident contacting a real government agency or representative about a community issue? Why or why not?
4. What did you learn from a classmate's discussion post that changed or added to your own thinking about a community problem?
5. How might the skills from this module (describing a problem clearly, proposing a solution, using persuasive language) help you in situations outside of this class?

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 3: Advocacy and Community Engagement | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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4: Employment and Workplace Communication

Module 4: Employment and Workplace Communication

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Looking for a job, applying for a job, and succeeding at a job all depend on clear communication. In this module, students build the language skills needed to move through the full hiring process — reading a job posting, filling out an application, writing a professional email or cover letter, and answering interview questions with confidence. The grammar focus on past perfect and past perfect progressive questions gives students the tools to talk about work history in detail ("Had you worked in customer service before you applied here?"), while embedded questions help students ask for information politely and professionally — a skill that matters in interviews, at work, and in everyday life. This module also strengthens students' ability to structure spoken answers clearly, a skill directly transferable to job interviews, parent-teacher conferences, and other real-world speaking situations.

In this module, students will:

- Learn and use 10 key vocabulary words related to job searching and the workplace
- Read an original passage about preparing for a job interview and practicing workplace communication
- Ask and answer Yes/No, Or, and Wh- questions using the past perfect and past perfect progressive tenses
- Form and use embedded questions to ask for information politely
- Write a professional email or cover letter responding to a job posting
- Practice structuring oral answers with an introduction, details, and a conclusion, and ask clarifying questions in a mock interview activity

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Identify main ideas and supporting details in a workplace-themed text; use context clues to determine the meaning of unfamiliar job-related vocabulary
Vocabulary	Correctly use 10 employment-related words in speaking and writing, in context
Grammar	Form and use Yes/No, Or, and Wh- questions in the past perfect and past perfect progressive tenses; construct embedded questions for polite, indirect requests for information
Writing	Write a clear, well-organized professional email/cover letter responding to a job posting, using correct business email format and appropriate tone
Speaking and Listening	Structure an oral answer with an introduction, supporting details, and a conclusion; ask and respond to clarifying questions in an interview-style exchange

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1–2	Vocabulary introduction; read "Preparing for the Interview of Your Life"; complete comprehension questions	Comprehension questions due Day 2

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 3	Grammar Lesson: Yes/No, Or, and Wh- questions with past perfect and past perfect progressive	Grammar Practice Activity 1 due Day 3
1	Day 4	Grammar Lesson continued: embedded questions; Grammar Practice Activities 2–3 (In-person: pairs quiz each other aloud using question cards; Zoom: breakout rooms practice with shared question cards on screen; Canvas: interactive H5P-style or discussion-post question drill, submitted asynchronously)	Grammar Practice Activities due Day 4
1	Day 5	Writing Assignment introduced: model email/cover letter analysis; brainstorming and prewriting graphic organizer	Prewriting organizer due Day 5
2	Day 6–7	Draft and revise professional email/cover letter; peer feedback using revision checklist	Draft due Day 6; peer feedback due Day 7
2	Day 8	Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board — share work experience/goals and give interview advice (In-person: oral small-group discussion with report-back to class; Zoom: breakout rooms with a shared Google Doc for notes; Canvas: asynchronous discussion board post with two required peer replies)	Original discussion post due Day 8
2	Day 9	Mock interview practice (clarifying questions, intro/details/conclusion answer structure); final writing assignment due	Final email/cover letter due Day 9
2	Day 10	Self-Check Quiz (ungraded); Module wrap-up and reflection	Self-Check Quiz recommended by Day 10

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Yes/No questions — past perfect	To ask if something had (or had not) happened before another past moment	"Had you finished your application before the deadline?"

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Or questions — past perfect	To ask someone to choose between two past-before-past options	"Had you worked as a cashier or as a stock clerk before this job?"
Wh- questions — past perfect	To ask for specific information about an action completed before another past point	"Where had you worked before you applied here?"
Yes/No, Or, and Wh- questions — past perfect progressive	To ask about an ongoing action that was in progress before another past moment	"Had you been looking for work for a long time before you found this job?"
Embedded questions	To ask a question politely or indirectly, often inside a longer statement or question	"Could you tell me what your previous responsibilities were?"

Delivery Mode Note

This module is designed to work seamlessly across all three delivery formats used at Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education. **In-person** students complete vocabulary and grammar activities using printed handouts and interview practice with a partner face-to-face. **Zoom** students use breakout rooms for pair and small-group speaking tasks, screen-share the reading passage for guided annotation, and use the chat box for quick vocabulary or grammar checks. **Canvas LMS** students complete the same content asynchronously: reading and vocabulary quizzes are auto-graded where possible, the discussion board replaces live conversation, and the writing assignment can be submitted as typed text, a photographed handwritten page, or an audio recording. Instructors should post the same core materials in Canvas regardless of delivery mode, so that all students — whatever their format — receive equivalent content and equivalent opportunities to practice speaking, listening, reading, and writing.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
applicant	noun	a person who formally applies for a job or program	Over fifty applicants sent in their resumes for the warehouse position.
qualification	noun	a skill, quality, or experience that makes someone suitable for a job	Her main qualification for the job was three years of experience in retail.
reference	noun	a person who can describe your character or work history to a new employer	The application asked for the names and phone numbers of two references.
supervisor	noun	a person who oversees and manages the work of other employees	My supervisor reviews my work every Friday afternoon.
shift	noun	a scheduled period of work time	She works the morning shift, from 6:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m.
benefits	noun	additional advantages provided by an employer besides salary, such as health insurance	The company offers benefits, including health insurance and paid vacation.
responsibility	noun	a duty or task that a person is expected to do	Answering customer emails is one of my main responsibilities.
interview	noun	a formal meeting in which someone is asked questions to see if they are suitable for a job	I have an interview with the hiring manager on Tuesday morning.

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
application	noun	a formal written request for a job, often on a form	Please complete the online application before the end of the week.
employer	noun	a person or company that hires and pays workers	My employer requires all new hires to complete an orientation.

Original Reading: "Preparing for the Interview of Your Life"

Finding the Right Opportunity

Looking for a job can feel overwhelming, but a little preparation makes a big difference. Marisol Delgado, a job counselor at a community career center, tells every applicant the same thing: "The interview doesn't start when you sit down in the chair. It starts the moment you decide to apply." Before applying, Marisol encourages job seekers to read the job posting carefully and list the qualifications the employer wants. If a posting mentions customer service experience, teamwork, or the ability to work a flexible shift, applicants should think of real examples that show those skills. This preparation helps later, on both the application and the interview.

Completing the Application

Many applications happen online now, but the basic parts are the same as paper forms: contact information, work history, education, and references. Marisol reminds her clients to list a supervisor or coworker as a reference only after asking that person's permission. She also stresses accuracy: dates of employment, job titles, and responsibilities should match the resume. A small mistake, like the wrong dates, can make an employer question the rest of the application. Marisol suggests preparing answers to common short-answer questions ahead of time, such as "Describe a time you solved a problem at work" or "What are your greatest strengths?"

Answering Interview Questions with Confidence

During the interview, employers often ask about a candidate's past experience using questions in the past perfect or past perfect progressive tense, such as "Had you worked in a similar position before you applied here?" or "How long had you been working at your last job before it closed?" These questions ask about actions completed, or in progress, before another point in the past. Marisol coaches applicants to answer using a simple structure: start with a short introduction that restates the question, add two or three specific details, and end with a brief conclusion that connects the answer back to the job. For example, an applicant might say, "Yes, I had worked as a receptionist for two years before I moved to this city. In that job, I answered phones, scheduled appointments, and helped train new employees. I believe that experience prepared me well for the front-desk responsibilities in this position."

Asking Clarifying Questions

Interviews are conversations, not tests, and Marisol encourages applicants to ask questions too. If part of a question is unclear, it is completely acceptable — and often impressive — to ask for clarification politely, using an embedded question. Instead of bluntly asking "What does the job pay?", a stronger approach might be, "Could you tell me what the typical pay range is for this position?" or "I was wondering if you could explain what a normal shift schedule looks like." These embedded questions sound more polite because the question is placed inside a longer, softer sentence. Employers often view thoughtful clarifying questions as a sign that the applicant is genuinely interested in the job and paying close attention.

After the Interview

Following up is another important part of workplace communication. A short, polite email thanking the interviewer for their time, mentioning one specific detail from the conversation, and reaffirming interest in the position can leave a strong final impression. Marisol notes that employers remember applicants who communicate clearly and professionally at every stage — the application, the interview, and the follow-up. "Communication," she says, "is really the biggest qualification of all. You can teach someone the technical parts of almost any job, but clear, respectful communication is something an employer notices immediately, from the very first email."

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word Bank: applicant, qualification, reference, supervisor, shift, benefits, responsibility, interview, application, employer

1. Before you list someone as a _____, always ask their permission first.
2. My _____ told me my performance review would be next Monday.
3. I filled out the online _____ and attached my resume.
4. One important _____ for this job is being able to speak two languages.
5. The company's _____ include health insurance and two weeks of paid vacation.
6. I work the night _____, from 10:00 p.m. to 6:00 a.m.
7. Answering the phone and greeting customers are two of my main _____ at work.
8. There were over forty _____ for the same job opening.
9. My _____ asked me to come in early on my first day.
10. I felt nervous before my job _____, but I had practiced my answers.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. According to Marisol, when does the interview really "start"?
2. What should applicants do before filling out an application, according to the reading?
3. Why does Marisol warn against mismatched dates or job titles on an application?
4. What structure does Marisol recommend for answering interview questions?
5. What is one example of a polite, embedded clarifying question mentioned in the reading?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Marisol says, "Communication is really the biggest qualification of all." Do you agree or disagree? Explain your opinion using an example from your own experience or someone you know.
2. Think about a job you have had, or a job you would like to have. What questions do you think an employer might ask you using the past perfect tense? What questions would you like to ask the employer?

Reading Strategy: Facts vs. Opinions

Identifying facts versus opinions helps readers evaluate how reliable or persuasive a text is. A **fact** can be checked and proven true or false. An **opinion** expresses a belief, judgment, or feeling and cannot be proven true or false in the same way, even when it comes from an expert.

Feature	Fact	Opinion
Can it be proven?	Yes, with evidence	No, it reflects personal judgment
Common signal words	numbers, dates, "according to," measurable outcomes	"I believe," "I think," "the biggest," "should"
Example from the reading	"Many applications now happen online."	"Communication is really the biggest qualification of all."

Practice: Find one more fact and one more opinion in the reading passage, and explain how you know which is which. Share your answer with a partner (in-person/Zoom) or post it as a reply on the discussion board (Canvas).

Grammar Lesson

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Yes/No questions (past perfect)	Had + subject + past participle...?	To ask if an action was completed before another past time	before, by the time, already, yet	"Had you already applied for the job before you saw the posting online?"
Or questions (past perfect)	Had + subject + past participle...(option A) or (option B)?	To ask someone to choose between two completed past actions	or	"Had you worked in retail or in food service before this job?"
Wh- questions (past perfect)	Wh- word + had + subject + past participle...?	To ask for specific information about an action completed before another past point	where, when, why, how long, what	"How long had you worked there before you were promoted?"
Yes/No, Or, Wh- questions (past perfect progressive)	(Wh- word) + had + subject + been + verb-ing...?	To ask about an action that was ongoing/in progress before another past moment	for, since, all week, at that time	"Had you been looking for a job for very long before you found this one?"
Embedded questions	Statement/question + wh-word or if/whether + subject + verb (no auxiliary inversion)	To ask a question politely or indirectly, often within a longer sentence	could you tell me, I was wondering, do you know, can you explain	"Could you tell me what your previous responsibilities were?"

Yes/No, Or, and Wh- Questions with the Past Perfect

The **past perfect** (had + past participle) describes an action completed before another point in the past. In questions, "had" moves before the subject.

- **Yes/No:** Had you finished the application before the deadline?
- **Or:** Had you sent your resume by email or by mail?
- **Wh-:** What had you done to prepare for the interview?

Common error: Students often forget to use the base form (past participle) after "had," instead using the simple past.

- Incorrect: Had you *worked* there before? (this is actually correct — note that regular verbs use the same -ed form for past participle)
- Incorrect example to watch for irregular verbs: "Had you *went* to the interview?"
- Correct: "Had you *gone* to the interview?"

Always double-check irregular past participles (gone, done, seen, written, spoken) rather than using the simple past form after "had."

Yes/No, Or, and Wh- Questions with the Past Perfect Progressive

The **past perfect progressive** (had been + verb-ing) emphasizes the duration or continuous nature of an action before another past moment. It is especially useful for talking about how long someone had been doing something before a specific event, such as being hired, promoted, or laid off.

- **Yes/No:** Had you been working there for a long time before the company closed?
- **Or:** Had you been studying English or Spanish before you moved here?
- **Wh-:** How long had you been searching for a job before you found this position?

Form note: Past perfect progressive always uses "had been" + the -ing form of the verb, regardless of subject (I, you, he, she, we, they). There is no subject-verb agreement change, which makes this structure easier once students memorize the pattern.

Common error: Mixing past perfect and past perfect progressive incorrectly, such as saying "Had you been work there?" instead of "Had you been working there?" Remind students that "been" must always be followed by the -ing form, never the base form.

Embedded Questions

An **embedded question** is a question placed inside another sentence or question, often to sound more polite, formal, or indirect — a very useful skill in job interviews and workplace emails. When a question is embedded, word order changes: it follows statement order (subject before verb), and "do/does/did" is dropped.

- Direct question: "What were your previous responsibilities?"
- Embedded question: "Could you tell me what your previous responsibilities were?"
- Direct question: "Did you have any questions?"
- Embedded question: "I was wondering if you had any questions."

Common introductory phrases for embedded questions: Could you tell me..., Do you know..., I was wondering..., Can you explain..., I'd like to know..., Would you mind telling me...

Common error: Keeping question word order inside the embedded clause.

- Incorrect: "Could you tell me what was your previous salary?"
- Correct: "Could you tell me what your previous salary was?"

For yes/no-based embedded questions, use "if" or "whether" instead of a wh- word.

- Direct: "Have you worked here before?"
- Embedded: "I was wondering if you had worked here before."

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Multiple Choice — Choose the correct question form.

1. _____ you _____ (finish) your application before the deadline?
a) Had / finished b) Have / finish c) Did / finished
1. _____ had you _____ (be) looking for a job before you found this one?
a) How long / been b) Where / be c) What / being
1. Choose the correctly embedded question:
a) Could you tell me what were your responsibilities? b) Could you tell me what your responsibilities were? c) Could you tell me what your responsibilities was?

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank — Complete each question with the past perfect or past perfect progressive form.

1. _____ you _____ (work) as a supervisor before you applied for this job?
2. How long _____ she _____ (train) new employees before she was promoted?
3. _____ they _____ (finish) filling out the application, or _____ they still _____ (write) it when the office closed?
4. What _____ you _____ (do) before you moved to this city?
5. _____ he _____ (be) an applicant for this position before, or was this his first time applying?

Activity 3: Sentence Writing — Rewrite each direct question as a polite embedded question using the phrase given.

1. "What is your greatest strength?" (Could you tell me...)
2. "Do you have experience with customer service?" (I was wondering...)
3. "What were your responsibilities at your last job?" (Can you explain...)
4. "How long had you been working there?" (I'd like to know...)
5. "Did you have any questions for me?" (I was wondering...)

Writing Assignment

This module's writing assignment asks students to write a **professional email or cover letter responding to a job posting**. This task directly reflects the COR's College/Workforce Prep objectives around business letter and email parts, and gives students realistic practice with a document they are likely to write in real life.

Parts of a Professional Email/Cover Letter

Part	Purpose
Subject line	Clearly states the purpose of the email (e.g., "Application for Front Desk Position — [Your Name]")
Greeting/Salutation	Politely addresses the employer or hiring manager by name or title (e.g., "Dear Ms. Alvarez," or "Dear Hiring Manager,")
Opening paragraph	States the position you are applying for and where you saw it posted
Body paragraph(s)	Describes relevant qualifications, past experience, and skills that match the job posting
Closing paragraph	Expresses interest in an interview and thanks the reader for their time
Closing/Signature	A polite closing phrase (e.g., "Sincerely," or "Best regards,") followed by your full name and contact information

Topic Choices

Option	Description
1	Write a cover letter applying for a job at a local grocery store, restaurant, or retail business
2	Write a cover letter applying for a job in your current or desired career field (e.g., healthcare, construction, childcare)
3	Write a follow-up email thanking an employer after a job interview and expressing continued interest
4	Complete a sample job application form with short-answer responses (work history, qualifications, and a short-answer question such as "Describe your greatest strength")
5	Student choice: propose your own real job posting (from an actual local listing) and write a cover letter responding to it — requires instructor approval

Assignment Requirements

- Length: 150–200 words (or a fully completed sample application form with short-answer responses of similar length)
- Format: Business email/letter format with all six parts listed above (subject line, greeting, opening, body, closing paragraph, signature)
- Grammar: Include at least two questions using the past perfect or past perfect progressive tense (for example, referencing a phone conversation: "You had mentioned that the position includes weekend shifts...") and at least one embedded question (e.g., "I was wondering if you could tell me more about the training process.")
- Vocabulary: Use at least 5 of the 10 module vocabulary words naturally
- Use at least 3 transition words/phrases from the table below
- Tone: Professional and polite throughout

Transition Words for Professional Emails/Letters

Purpose	Transition Words/Phrases
Adding information	In addition, Furthermore, Also
Giving an example	For example, For instance, Specifically
Showing result	As a result, Therefore, Because of this
Concluding	In conclusion, Thank you again, I look forward to

Model Text: Sample Cover Letter

Subject: Application for Customer Service Associate Position — Ana Torres

Dear Mr. Kim,

I am writing to apply for the Customer Service Associate position posted on your company website. I saw the posting last week and believe my experience and qualifications make me a strong applicant for this role.

For the past two years, I have worked as a cashier at a busy retail store, where my responsibilities included handling customer questions, processing payments, and training new employees. Before that job, I had been studying business communication at Santa Ana College, which helped me develop strong written and spoken English skills. In addition, I am comfortable working flexible shifts, including evenings and weekends.

During our phone conversation last week, you had mentioned that this position also involves some scheduling duties. I was wondering if you could tell me more about the specific responsibilities involved in scheduling, since I have not had direct experience with that task, though I am confident I could learn quickly.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my qualifications further in an interview. Thank you very much for your time and consideration.

Sincerely, Ana Torres (714) 555-0148 anatorres_example@email.com

The Writing Process

Step	What to Do
1. Prewrite	Choose a topic; identify the job posting's key qualifications; brainstorm your matching skills and experience using the graphic organizer below
2. Draft	Write a first version, including all six required parts of the email/letter
3. Revise	Reread for organization and content; check that you included past perfect/past perfect progressive questions, an embedded question, and 5 vocabulary words
4. Edit	Check grammar, spelling, punctuation, and professional tone; read aloud to catch errors
5. Publish	Submit your final version using one of the multimodal options below

Prewriting Graphic Organizer

Job Posting Requirement	My Matching Experience/Skill
(e.g., customer service experience)	(e.g., two years as a cashier, handled customer questions daily)

Revision Checklist

Check	Yes/No
Does my email/letter include all six parts (subject, greeting, opening, body, closing, signature)?	
Did I include at least one past perfect or past perfect progressive question?	
Did I include at least one embedded question?	
Did I use at least 5 vocabulary words correctly?	
Did I use at least 3 transition words/phrases?	
Is my tone professional and polite throughout?	

Grading Rubric (20 points)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (3 pts)	Beginning (1–2 pts)
Organization/Format	All six email/letter parts present and correctly ordered	Most parts present, minor ordering issues	Some parts missing or out of order	Few or no parts follow business format
Grammar (past perfect/progressive, embedded questions)	Both structures used correctly and naturally	Both structures present with minor errors	Only one structure used, or both with frequent errors	Structures missing or mostly incorrect
Vocabulary and Content	5+ vocabulary words used naturally; content clearly matches job posting	4 vocabulary words used; content mostly relevant	2–3 vocabulary words used; content partially relevant	Fewer than 2 vocabulary words; content unclear
Tone and Mechanics	Consistently professional tone; virtually no errors	Mostly professional; few minor errors	Tone inconsistent; several errors affect clarity	Tone unprofessional; many errors interfere with meaning

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 (Typed):** Type your email/letter in a Canvas text entry box or Word document and submit through Canvas (recommended for in-person and Canvas students).
- **Option 2 (Handwritten + Photo):** Write your email/letter by hand on paper, then take a clear photo or scan and upload it to Canvas (a good option for students who are more comfortable writing by hand or have limited computer access).
- **Option 3 (Audio Recording):** Record yourself reading your email/letter aloud as though presenting it to an interviewer, and upload the audio file to Canvas (builds oral fluency and supports students who benefit from a speaking-based option).

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

Post a response addressing all three parts below:

1. **Share:** Describe a job you have had (or would like to have) and one workplace responsibility that was important in that role. What skills or qualifications helped you succeed, or would help you succeed, in that job?
2. **Compare:** Read a classmate's post. How is their work experience or career goal similar to or different from yours?
3. **Advise:** Imagine your classmate has an interview coming up. Give them one piece of interview advice, using at least one past perfect or past perfect progressive question you might expect an interviewer to ask, and one embedded question they could ask the interviewer.

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	Answers all three parts of the prompt; 80–100 words; uses at least 2 vocabulary words	10
Reply 1	Responds thoughtfully to a classmate's post with a genuine comparison or question; 40+ words	5
Reply 2	Responds to a different classmate; includes at least one piece of specific, relevant advice; 40+ words	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Sharing work experience	"I worked as a _____ for _____. My main responsibility was _____."
Sharing a career goal	"I would like to work as a _____ because _____."
Comparing experiences	"Like you, I have also _____, but unlike you, I _____."
Giving interview advice	"One question the interviewer might ask is, '_____' I would suggest _____."
Suggesting a clarifying question	"You could ask the interviewer, 'I was wondering if you could tell me _____.'"

Functional/Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrases
Stating an opinion	"In my opinion...", "I believe that...", "From my experience..."
Supporting with a reason	"This is important because...", "One reason for this is...", "For example..."
Comparing	"Similarly...", "In contrast...", "Both of us have..."
Agreeing	"I completely agree because...", "That's a great point — I also think..."
Disagreeing (politely)	"I see it a little differently...", "I understand your point, but I think...", "That's interesting, though in my experience..."

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person students discuss the three-part prompt aloud in small groups of 3–4, taking turns sharing and giving advice, then one member reports the group's best piece of interview advice back to the full class. **Zoom** students are placed into breakout rooms of 3–4 for the same discussion, with one student typing key points into a shared Google Doc that is reviewed together after returning to the main session. **Canvas** students complete the discussion asynchronously: they write and post their original response to the discussion board, then return within 48 hours to read and reply to two classmates' posts, following the same sentence frames and functional language provided above.

Discussion Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (3 pts)	Beginning (1–2 pts)
Content/Completeness	Fully addresses all three prompt parts with specific detail	Addresses all three parts, some lacking detail	Addresses only two of the three parts	Addresses one part or is off-topic
Grammar Use	Uses past perfect/progressive and embedded questions correctly and naturally	Uses both structures with minor errors	Uses only one structure, or both with frequent errors	Structures missing or incorrect
Engagement with Peers	Both replies are specific, thoughtful, and build on classmate's ideas	Replies are relevant but general	Replies are brief or minimally connected to classmate's post	Replies are missing or off-topic
Communication Clarity	Ideas are clear, well-organized, and easy to follow	Ideas are mostly clear with minor organization issues	Ideas are somewhat unclear or disorganized	Ideas are difficult to understand

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is ungraded practice to help you check your own understanding before the module assessment. Use it to identify areas you may want to review.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word (1–10) to its definition (a–j).

1. applicant
2. qualification
3. reference
4. supervisor
5. shift
6. benefits
7. responsibility
8. interview
9. application
10. employer

- a. a scheduled period of work time
- b. a person who oversees other employees
- c. a duty a person is expected to do
- d. a person or company that hires workers
- e. a formal written request for a job
- f. a person who describes your character to a new employer
- g. a formal meeting to see if someone is suitable for a job
- h. a person who applies for a job
- i. additional advantages besides salary
- j. a skill or quality that makes someone suitable for a job

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. Before the interview, I reviewed the job's required _____ (qualifications/shifts).
2. My _____ (employer/reference) offers two weeks of paid vacation each year.
3. I asked my former manager to be a _____ (responsibility/reference) on my application.
4. The company received over one hundred _____ (benefits/applicants) for one opening.
5. She works the early morning _____ (shift/interview) at the hospital.

6. Filing paperwork accurately is one of my daily _____ (responsibilities/qualifications).
7. He filled out the _____ (application/supervisor) and submitted it online.
8. My _____ (supervisor/benefits) reviews my performance every three months.

Section 3: Grammar Identification/Application

Identify whether each sentence uses past perfect (PP), past perfect progressive (PPP), or an embedded question (EQ). Then answer items 9–12 by writing your own sentence.

1. Had you finished the application before the deadline?
2. Could you tell me what your previous responsibilities were?
3. How long had she been working there before she was promoted?
4. Had they applied online or by mail?
5. I was wondering if you had experience with customer service.
6. What had he done before he moved to California?
7. Had you been studying English for a long time before you took this class?
8. Do you know if the position includes benefits?
9. Write your own Yes/No question using past perfect.
10. Write your own Wh- question using past perfect progressive.
11. Write your own embedded question using "I was wondering if..."
12. Write your own Or question using past perfect.

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the error in each sentence.

1. Had you went to the interview before you called them?
2. Could you tell me what were your qualifications?
3. How long she had been working there before she quit?
4. I was wondering if did you have any references.
5. Had you been study English before you moved here?
6. Did you had finished the application on time?
7. Could you tell me how long had you worked there?
8. Had she work as a supervisor before this job?

Section 5: Short Writing Check

Prompt: In 3–5 sentences, describe a job interview you have had, or imagine one you might have. Use at least one past perfect question, one past perfect progressive question, and one embedded question.

Self-Evaluation Checklist

Check	Yes/No
I used at least one past perfect question correctly	
I used at least one past perfect progressive question correctly	
I used at least one embedded question with correct word order	
I used at least two vocabulary words from this module	
I checked my spelling and punctuation	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Quiz me on this module's 10 workplace vocabulary words using fill-in-the-blank sentences."	A custom practice quiz with immediate feedback on your answers
Grammar	"Give me 5 practice questions about past perfect and past perfect progressive questions for a job interview scenario."	Extra grammar practice items with explanations for each correct answer
Writing Feedback	"Here is my cover letter draft. Can you check my grammar and tell me if my tone is professional?"	Specific, personalized feedback on grammar, tone, and organization
Discussion Practice	"Can you role-play a job interview with me and ask me questions using past perfect and embedded questions?"	A simulated interview conversation to practice speaking and listening in a low-pressure setting

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining Combine each pair of sentences into one sentence using the past perfect.

1. She applied for the job. Before that, she had updated her resume. → _____
2. He arrived at the interview. Before that, he had researched the company. → _____
3. They hired a new employee. Before that, they had interviewed five applicants. → _____

Activity 2: Subject-Verb Agreement in Embedded Questions Rewrite each direct question as an embedded question beginning with "Do you know..."

1. Where is the human resources office?
2. What time does the interview start?
3. Who is my supervisor?

Activity 3: Word Forms Complete the chart with the correct word form.

Noun	Verb	Adjective
application	apply	_____
qualification	qualify	_____
responsibility	_____	responsible

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Offers free drop-in and appointment-based tutoring for reading, writing, and grammar support, including help with job application materials and cover letters.
- **Writing Center:** Provides one-on-one feedback on drafts, including resumes, cover letters, and other workplace documents, at any stage of the writing process.
- **Library:** Offers access to computers, printing, and research databases, as well as librarian assistance for finding job postings and workplace-related resources.
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and support services for students with documented disabilities, including extended time, alternative testing formats, and assistive technology.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary by Skill Area

Skill Area	What Students Learned
Reading/Vocabulary	Learned 10 employment-related vocabulary words; read and analyzed an authentic-style passage on interview preparation; practiced identifying facts versus opinions
Grammar	Formed and used Yes/No, Or, and Wh- questions in the past perfect and past perfect progressive tenses; formed embedded questions for polite, indirect communication
Writing/Communication	Wrote a professional email/cover letter responding to a job posting using correct business format, tone, and grammar; practiced structuring spoken answers with an introduction, details, and conclusion; practiced asking clarifying questions

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
Purdue OWL: Business Writing	Guidance on professional email and letter formatting and tone	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/subject_s...ing/index.html
USA.gov: Finding a Job	Official U.S. government resource on job searching, applications, and workplace rights	https://www.usa.gov/finding-a-job
VOA Learning English	Listening and vocabulary practice, including workplace and career-related stories, at an accessible pace	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/
BBC Learning English	Grammar and vocabulary lessons, including question formation and business English topics	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Learner-friendly definitions and example sentences for employment vocabulary	https://learnersdictionary.com/

Looking Ahead

This Module Connects To
Module 5's focus on reading contracts, brochures, and consumer information builds on the workplace-reading strategies practiced here
The professional tone and business format practiced in this module's writing assignment will support future academic and workplace writing tasks
The oral answer structure (introduction, details, conclusion) practiced here will be used again in future oral presentations later in the course

Reflection Questions

1. What is one new vocabulary word from this module that you think you will use in real life? How might you use it?
2. Which was more challenging for you: forming past perfect questions, past perfect progressive questions, or embedded questions? Why?
3. How confident do you feel about writing a professional email or cover letter now, compared to before this module?
4. What is one piece of interview advice from this module (or from a classmate) that you plan to remember?

5. What is one goal you have for your own job search or career, and what is one step you can take toward that goal this month?

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 4: Employment and Workplace Communication | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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5: Consumer and Financial Literacy

Module 5: Consumer and Financial Literacy

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Every day, we make decisions about money — what to buy, how to pay, when to save, and what to do when something goes wrong with a purchase. Understanding banking terms, budgeting, contracts, and consumer rights is not just useful English practice; it is a survival skill that helps you protect your money, avoid scams, and make confident decisions as a consumer in the United States. In this module, you will build the vocabulary and grammar you need to talk about your financial goals, read contracts and brochures critically, and stand up for yourself when a product, service, or bill is not what you expected.

In this module, students will:

- Learn 10 key consumer and financial vocabulary words and use them in real conversations and writing
- Read and analyze an authentic-style passage about smart budgeting and consumer protection
- Practice the present unreal conditional, present wish clauses, and hope clauses to talk about financial goals and hypothetical situations
- Write an informational paragraph about a personal budgeting plan or a formal letter requesting a refund or disputing a charge
- Participate in a discussion board exchange about money-saving habits and consumer experiences
- Practice identifying an author's purpose, audience, and tone in brochures and contracts, and select correct dictionary definitions for unfamiliar financial terms

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Read an authentic-style brochure/article about budgeting and consumer rights; identify author's purpose, audience, and tone; select the correct dictionary definition for unfamiliar financial terms based on context
Vocabulary	Correctly use 10 consumer/financial terms (e.g., <i>budget</i> , <i>interest rate</i> , <i>contract</i> , <i>refund</i> , <i>overdraft</i>) in speaking and writing
Grammar	Accurately form and use the present unreal conditional, present wish clauses, and hope clauses to describe financial goals, regrets, and hopes
Writing	Write a well-organized informational paragraph explaining a personal budgeting plan, or a formal business letter requesting a refund or disputing a charge, using topic sentence, supporting details, and conclusion
Speaking and Listening	Share and compare money-saving habits and consumer experiences in pair, small-group, or online discussion using functional language for opinion, comparison, and agreement/disagreement

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1–2	Introduce module theme; pre-teach 10 vocabulary words with real bank statements/receipts as visuals; read "Smart Money, Smart Choices" passage aloud (in-person/Zoom) or via recorded audio (Canvas)	Vocabulary Practice worksheet
1	Day 3	Comprehension Check questions (Main Idea & Details, Think & Connect); mini-lesson on author's purpose/audience/tone using a real brochure excerpt	Comprehension submitted Check
1	Day 4	Grammar Lesson: present unreal conditional, wish clauses, hope clauses — explicit instruction + guided practice. Delivery adaptation: In-person: pair worksheet + whiteboard error correction; Zoom: shared-screen grammar slides + breakout-room practice; Canvas: recorded mini-lecture + auto-graded practice quiz	Grammar Practice Activities 1–2
1	Day 5	Grammar Practice Activity 3 (sentence writing); introduce Writing Assignment topic choices and model text	Grammar Practice Activity 3
2	Day 1	Writing Process: prewriting graphic organizer + drafting time. Delivery adaptation: In-person: draft during class with instructor circulating; Zoom: draft in breakout rooms with instructor visiting each room; Canvas: draft independently using organizer template, post questions to a "Writing Help" discussion thread	Prewriting organizer

Week	Days	Task	Due
2	Day 2–3	Peer review using revision checklist; revise and edit draft; Delivery adaptation: In-person: face-to-face peer review pairs; Zoom: breakout-room peer review with shared Google Doc; Canvas: peer review via Canvas discussion or peer-review tool	Revised draft
2	Day 4	Discussion Board: money-saving habits / consumer experience exchange. Delivery adaptation: In-person: oral small-group discussion with report-back to class; Zoom: breakout rooms + shared notes doc; Canvas: async discussion board original post + 2 replies	Discussion Board post + 2 replies
2	Day 5	Final writing submission; Self-Check Quiz (ungraded review); module wrap-up and reflection	Final paragraph/letter; Self-Check Quiz completed

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Present Unreal Conditional	To describe an imaginary or hypothetical present situation and its imagined result	<i>If I had more savings, I would feel less stressed about bills.</i>
Present Wish Clauses	To express a wish about something that is not true or not possible right now	<i>I wish I knew more about interest rates before I signed the loan.</i>
Hope Clauses	To express a hope, expectation, or desire about a present or future situation	<i>I hope that the store will give me a full refund.</i>

Delivery Mode Note

Module 5 is designed to work seamlessly across three delivery modes. **In-person** students will handle real (sample) brochures, contracts, and receipts, work in pairs at tables, and use the whiteboard for grammar error correction. **Zoom** students will use shared screens to read the same materials together, breakout rooms for pair/group tasks, and the chat box for quick vocabulary checks. **Canvas LMS** students will complete the same reading, grammar, and writing tasks asynchronously using posted PDFs/text, recorded mini-lectures, auto-graded quizzes, and the Canvas discussion board — with multimodal submission options (typed, handwritten/photographed, or audio-recorded) so that all students, regardless of device access or digital comfort level, can fully participate.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
budget	noun/verb	a plan for how to spend and save money over a period of time	Maria makes a monthly budget so she knows exactly how much she can spend on groceries.

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
interest rate	noun	the percentage a bank charges you for borrowing money, or pays you for saving money	The credit card's interest rate is 22%, so unpaid balances grow quickly.
contract	noun	a written agreement between two or more people or companies that is legally binding	Before signing the gym contract, read every line carefully.
warranty	noun	a company's written promise to repair or replace a product if it breaks within a certain time	The washing machine came with a two-year warranty.
refund	noun/verb	money that is given back to a customer, usually because of a return or a problem with a purchase	She asked for a refund because the shoes did not fit.
deposit	noun/verb	a sum of money paid in advance as a guarantee, or money added to a bank account	The landlord requires a \$500 security deposit before move-in.
statement	noun	an official document from a bank or company listing transactions during a period of time	Ahmed checks his bank statement every month for mistakes.
overdraft	noun	a situation where a bank account balance goes below zero because more money was spent than was available	She was charged a \$35 fee for an overdraft after her rent check cleared.
consumer rights	noun (phrase)	the legal protections a person has when buying goods or services	Consumer rights allow you to return a defective product for a refund or repair.
installment	noun	one of several regular payments made over time to pay off a debt or purchase	He is paying for his laptop in monthly installments of \$40.

Original Reading: "Smart Money, Smart Choices"

Why Budgeting Matters

Managing money well is one of the most important skills for anyone living in the United States, whether you have lived here for ten years or ten weeks. A **budget** is simply a plan that shows how much money comes in and how much goes out each month. Financial counselors often say that people who write down a budget spend less money on things they do not need and save more money for things that matter, like rent, food, and emergencies. If you had a clear budget, you would know exactly how much money is left after paying for housing, transportation, and food — and you could plan ahead instead of guessing.

Many people wish they had learned about budgeting earlier in life. I wish someone had taught me how to track my spending when I first arrived in this country, because I made several costly mistakes with my bank account. One common mistake is spending more money than is actually available, which causes an **overdraft**. Banks often charge a fee, sometimes \$30 or more, every time this happens. Reading your monthly bank **statement** carefully can help you catch these fees early and understand exactly where your money is going.

Understanding Contracts and Interest

Another important part of financial literacy is understanding **contracts**. A contract is a written agreement, and once you sign it, you are legally responsible for following its terms. This applies to apartment leases, gym memberships, cell phone plans, and car loans. Before signing anything, read every section, including the small print at the bottom of the page. If something is unclear, ask questions, or bring the document to a trusted friend, a consumer counselor, or a legal aid office before signing.

Many contracts, especially loans and credit cards, include an **interest rate**. This is the extra amount you pay for borrowing money. A lower interest rate means you pay less overall; a higher interest rate means you pay much more over time. For example, if you buy furniture and pay in monthly **installments** with a high interest rate, the furniture could end up costing far more than its original price. I hope that more people will compare interest rates before agreeing to any loan, because this single number can make a tremendous financial difference.

Knowing Your Consumer Rights

Understanding your **consumer rights** protects you when something goes wrong. If a product breaks and it still has a valid **warranty**, the seller or manufacturer must repair or replace it at no extra cost. If a store or company charges you for something you did not agree to, or a product is defective, you generally have the right to request a **refund**. Many landlords and service providers also require a **deposit**, an amount of money paid in advance; consumer protection laws often require that this deposit be returned if conditions of the agreement are met.

If you feel that a business has treated you unfairly, you do not have to stay silent. You can write a clear letter explaining the problem, keep copies of receipts and contracts, and contact consumer protection offices for help if needed. I wish more consumers knew how much power a polite, well-written complaint letter can have. Businesses often respond quickly and respectfully when a customer explains the situation calmly and provides evidence.

Building Confidence with Money

Financial literacy is not about being rich; it is about being informed. If people understood budgeting, contracts, interest rates, and their consumer rights, they would make fewer costly mistakes and feel more confident about their financial future. Whether you are opening your first bank account, signing your first lease, or disputing a surprise charge, the vocabulary and skills in this module will help you communicate clearly and protect yourself as a smart, informed consumer.

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word Bank: budget, interest rate, contract, warranty, refund, deposit, statement, overdraft, consumer rights, installment

1. Before you sign a phone plan _____, read all the terms carefully.
2. My washing machine broke, but it is still covered by the _____, so the repair is free.
3. I check my bank _____ every month to make sure there are no mistakes.
4. She paid a \$200 security _____ before she could move into the apartment.
5. If your credit card has a high _____, you will pay much more over time.
6. He returned the shirt to the store and received a full _____.
7. I make a monthly _____ so I know how much I can spend on food and bills.
8. Karen was charged a fee because of an _____ on her checking account.
9. If a company sells you a defective product, your _____ allow you to ask for a repair or refund.
10. Instead of paying all at once, she is paying for the laptop in monthly _____.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. What is the main purpose of the reading passage?
2. According to the passage, what can happen if you spend more money than you have in your bank account?
3. Why is it important to read a contract carefully before signing it?
4. How can an interest rate affect the total cost of something you buy in installments?
5. What can a consumer do if a business treats them unfairly?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Have you ever signed a contract (for an apartment, phone, car, or gym) without fully understanding it? What happened, and what would you do differently now?
2. The writer says, "I wish someone had taught me how to track my spending when I first arrived in this country." What is one piece of financial advice you wish someone had given you earlier in your life? Explain why.

Reading Strategy: Author's Purpose, Audience, and Tone

Understanding *why* a writer created a text, *who* the writer is speaking to, and *how* the writer feels about the topic helps readers understand deeper meaning — this is especially important with brochures and contracts, which often try to inform, persuade, or protect the reader (or the company).

Element	Question to Ask	Example from "Smart Money, Smart Choices"
Purpose	Why did the author write this text? (to inform, persuade, entertain, warn)	To inform and encourage readers to build financial literacy skills, and to warn them about common mistakes like overdrafts and unclear contracts
Audience	Who is the text written for?	Adult English learners who are managing money and signing contracts in the United States, possibly for the first time
Tone	What attitude or feeling comes through in the writer's word choice?	Encouraging and supportive, with a personal, reflective tone ("I wish someone had taught me...")

Grammar Lesson

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Present Unreal Conditional	<i>If</i> + subject + simple past verb, + subject + would/could/might + base verb	To talk about an imaginary, hypothetical, or untrue present situation and its imagined result	if, would, could, might	If I had more savings, I would feel less stressed about bills.
Present Wish Clauses	Subject + wish (that) + subject + simple past verb / could + base verb	To express a wish about a present situation that is not true or not possible	wish, that	I wish I knew more about interest rates before I signed the loan.
Hope Clauses	Subject + hope (that) + subject + simple present or will + base verb	To express a hope, expectation, or desire about something in the present or future	hope, that, will	I hope that the store will give me a full refund.

Present Unreal Conditional

The present unreal conditional describes situations that are imaginary, untrue, or unlikely right now, and the imagined result of that situation. Even though we are talking about the present, the "if" clause uses the **simple past** tense — this is a special grammar rule, not a real past-time meaning.

Form: *If* + subject + simple past verb, + subject + **would / could / might** + base verb

- *If I had a bigger emergency fund, I would worry less about unexpected bills.*
- *If she understood the contract better, she wouldn't have signed it so quickly.*

- *If they read consumer protection laws, they could file a complaint with confidence.*

Special note on "be": In the present unreal conditional, the verb *be* is usually written as **were** for all subjects (I, he, she, it, we, they), even though this may look grammatically unusual.

- *If I were the store manager, I would refund the customer immediately.*
- *If he were more careful with his budget, he would save more money.*

Common errors to avoid:

- Do NOT use "would" in the if-clause: ~~If I would have more money, I would save it.~~ → *If I had more money, I would save it.*
- Do NOT use present tense in the if-clause: ~~If I have more savings, I would...~~ → *If I had more savings, I would...*

Present Wish Clauses

We use wish clauses to express that we want something to be different from how it really is right now. Like the unreal conditional, the verb after *wish* is in the **simple past**, even though the meaning is present.

Form: Subject + **wish (that)** + subject + simple past verb / **could** + base verb

- *I wish I knew more about interest rates.* (In reality, I don't know enough.)
- *She wishes she had more money saved for emergencies.* (In reality, she doesn't.)
- *We wish we could afford a better apartment.* (In reality, we can't right now.)

Special note on "be": Just like the conditional, use **were** for all subjects after *wish*.

- *I wish I were better at managing my budget.*

Common errors to avoid:

- Do NOT use present tense after wish: ~~I wish I know more.~~ → *I wish I knew more.*
- Remember "that" is optional: *I wish (that) I understood this contract better.*

Hope Clauses

Unlike wish clauses, hope clauses express something that is *possible* — a real hope or expectation about the present or future. This is a key difference: *wish* is for things that are NOT true; *hope* is for things that COULD become true.

Form: Subject + **hope (that)** + subject + simple present verb OR **will** + base verb

- *I hope that the company refunds my money quickly.*
- *We hope the bank will fix the mistake on our statement.*
- *She hopes she has enough saved for a deposit on an apartment.*

Common errors to avoid:

- Do NOT confuse hope with wish: ~~I hope I had more money.~~ (This sounds like wish; use "I wish I had more money" instead.)
- Hope clauses generally use present or future forms, not the simple past for hypothetical meaning.

Wish vs. Hope — Quick Comparison

	Wish	Hope
Meaning	Something is NOT true now (regret/imaginary)	Something MAY become true (real possibility)
Verb form	Simple past / were / could	Simple present / will
Example	I wish I had a bigger budget.	I hope I get a refund soon.

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Multiple Choice

1. If I ____ more money in savings, I would feel more secure.
a) have b) had c) will have d) would have
1. She wishes she ____ more about consumer rights before she signed the contract.
a) knows b) know c) knew d) will know
1. We hope that the store ____ our refund request this week.
a) approved b) approve c) will approve d) approving
1. If he ____ the interest rate more carefully, he wouldn't have taken the loan.
a) checks b) checked c) will check d) checking
1. I wish I ____ able to negotiate a lower deposit.
a) am b) was c) were d) will be

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank

Complete each sentence with the correct form of the verb in parentheses.

1. If I _____ (understand) the warranty terms better, I would have kept my receipt.
2. She wishes she _____ (be) more organized with her monthly budget.
3. We hope that the bank _____ (fix) the overdraft fee soon.
4. If they _____ (read) the contract carefully, they wouldn't be so confused now.
5. I wish I _____ (have) more time to compare interest rates before choosing a credit card.
6. He hopes the company _____ (send) his refund by the end of the month.

Activity 3: Sentence Writing

Write your own original sentence for each structure and topic below.

1. Present unreal conditional — about saving money
2. Present wish clause — about a financial mistake you or someone you know made
3. Hope clause — about a bank or company resolving a problem

Writing Assignment

For this module, you will choose one of two informational/functional writing tasks: (1) an **informational paragraph** explaining your personal budgeting plan, or (2) a **formal business letter** requesting a refund or disputing a charge. Both options connect directly to real-life financial communication and use the grammar and vocabulary from this module.

Parts of an Informational Paragraph

Part	Purpose
Topic Sentence	States the main idea — what your budgeting plan is or what the letter's purpose is
Supporting Detail 1	Gives specific information (an amount, a category, a reason)
Supporting Detail 2	Adds more specific information or an example
Supporting Detail 3	Adds a final detail, often using module grammar (conditional/wish/hope)
Conclusion	Restates the main idea or looks ahead to a future goal or resolution

Parts of a Business Letter (Refund/Dispute Option)

Part	Purpose
Heading/Date	Your address and the date (or company address, if typed)
Greeting	"Dear Customer Service Manager," or specific name if known
Opening/Purpose	States clearly why you are writing (requesting a refund, disputing a charge)
Body/Details	Explains what happened, when, and what you would like the company to do
Closing statement	Politely restates your request and expresses hope for resolution
Signature	"Sincerely," + your name

Topic Choices

Option	Task
1	Write an informational paragraph explaining your personal monthly budgeting plan (categories, savings goals, and one hope or wish for your financial future).
2	Write a formal letter to a store requesting a refund for a defective or unsatisfactory product.
3	Write a formal letter disputing an incorrect charge on a bank or credit card statement.
4	Write an informational paragraph comparing your budget now to the budget you wish you had, using conditional and wish clauses.
5	Student choice: propose your own consumer/financial topic (e.g., a letter to a landlord about a deposit, a paragraph about saving for a specific goal) — requires instructor approval before drafting.

Assignment Requirements

- Length: one well-developed paragraph (8–10 sentences) OR a complete business letter with all required parts
- Include a clear topic sentence (paragraph) or clear purpose statement (letter)
- Use at least **4 vocabulary words** from this module's word list
- Use at least **2 of the 3 grammar structures** from this module (present unreal conditional, wish clause, hope clause)
- Use at least **2 transition words** from the table below
- Include a clear conclusion or polite closing statement
- Edit for capitalization, punctuation, and spelling before submitting

Transition Words

Transition Word/Phrase	Use
First, / To begin,	Introduce the first point
In addition, / Also,	Add another point
For example,	Give a specific example
As a result,	Show a result or consequence
Finally, / In conclusion,	Signal the final point or wrap up

Model Text: Informational Paragraph

> **My Monthly Budgeting Plan** > > Every month, I follow a simple budgeting plan to manage my income and expenses wisely. First, I set aside 30% of my paycheck for rent and utilities, because housing is my biggest expense. In addition, I put 10% into a savings account for emergencies, such as car repairs or medical bills. For example, last month my car needed a new tire, and I was able to pay for it without using a credit card because of my savings. If I did not have this budget, I would probably feel anxious every time an unexpected cost appeared. I wish I had started budgeting earlier in my life, because I made several costly mistakes with overdraft fees in the past. As a result, I now check my bank statement every week to avoid surprises. I hope that I can save enough this year to make a deposit on a small apartment of my own. In conclusion, my budgeting plan gives me confidence and control over my financial future.

Model Text: Business Letter (Refund Request)

> 123 Main Street > Santa Ana, CA 92701 > July 11, 2026 > > Dear Customer Service Manager, > > I am writing to request a refund for a blender (Model #4521) that I purchased on June 20, 2026, at your Santa Ana location. The blender stopped working after only three uses, even though it came with a one-year warranty. I have attached a copy of my receipt and the warranty information. > > If the product had worked properly, I would not need to contact you. However, since it is defective, I would like a full refund or a replacement, whichever your store policy allows. I wish I had tested the blender more carefully before the return window closed, but I contacted you as soon as I noticed the problem. > > I hope that you will process my refund request promptly. Please let me know if you need any additional information. Thank you for your attention to this matter. > > Sincerely, > Ana Reyes

The Writing Process

Step	What to Do
1. Prewrite	Brainstorm ideas using the graphic organizer below
2. Draft	Write a complete first version without worrying about perfection
3. Revise	Reread for clarity, organization, and content — add or reorder details
4. Edit	Check grammar (especially module structures), punctuation, capitalization, spelling
5. Publish	Submit the final, polished version in your chosen format

Prewriting Graphic Organizer

Section	My Notes
Topic Sentence / Purpose Statement	
Supporting Detail 1 (fact/reason)	
Supporting Detail 2 (example)	
Supporting Detail 3 (conditional/wish/hope sentence)	
Conclusion / Closing Statement	
Vocabulary words I will use (at least 4)	

Revision Checklist

Check	Yes/No
Does my paragraph/letter have a clear topic sentence or purpose statement?	
Did I include at least 3 supporting details?	
Did I use at least 4 vocabulary words from this module?	

Check	Yes/No
Did I use at least 2 grammar structures (conditional/wish/hope)?	
Did I use at least 2 transition words?	
Does my conclusion/closing restate my main idea or request?	
Did I check spelling, punctuation, and capitalization?	

Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Beginning (1)
Content & Organization	Clear topic sentence/purpose, well-organized, all parts present	Mostly clear and organized, minor gaps	Organization unclear in places, missing a part	Little organization, purpose unclear
Grammar Focus (conditional/wish/hope)	Uses 2+ structures accurately and naturally	Uses 2 structures with minor errors	Uses only 1 structure or with frequent errors	Structures missing or mostly incorrect
Vocabulary Use	Uses 4+ words accurately and naturally	Uses 4 words, mostly accurate	Uses 2–3 words, some inaccurate use	Uses fewer than 2 words
Mechanics (spelling/punctuation/capitalization)	Very few or no errors	Minor errors that don't affect meaning	Several errors that sometimes affect meaning	Frequent errors that affect meaning
Total	/16			

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 — Typed:** Type your paragraph or letter and submit as a Canvas text entry or file upload (in-person students may also email or hand in a printed copy).
- **Option 2 — Handwritten + Photo:** Write your paragraph or letter by hand, then take a clear photo and upload it to Canvas — a good option for students who are less comfortable typing.
- **Option 3 — Audio Recording:** Record yourself reading your paragraph or letter aloud and upload the audio file to Canvas — this also builds your oral fluency and pronunciation skills.

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

Topic: Money-Saving Habits and Consumer Experiences

1. Share one money-saving habit that works well for you (for example, cooking at home, using coupons, setting a weekly spending limit, or comparing prices before buying).
2. Compare your approach to budgeting with a classmate's approach. What is similar? What is different? Which method do you think would work better for you, and why?
3. Describe one consumer experience you have had — good or bad — with a refund, warranty, contract, or bank fee. What did you learn from it? What do you wish you had done differently, or what do you hope happens next time?

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	Answers all 3 parts of the prompt; uses at least 2 vocabulary words and 1 grammar structure from this module	10

Component	Requirement	Points
Reply 1	Responds thoughtfully to a classmate; asks a follow-up question or makes a comparison	5
Reply 2	Responds to a different classmate; adds a new idea or personal connection	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Share a habit	One money-saving habit that works for me is _____.
Compare	My approach is similar to/different from yours because _____.
Describe an experience	One consumer experience I had was _____.
Use conditional	If I _____, I would _____.
Use wish	I wish I _____.
Use hope	I hope that _____.

Functional/Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrase
Stating an opinion	In my opinion, ... / I believe that ...
Supporting with a reason	This is important because ... / One reason is ...
Comparing	Similarly, ... / On the other hand, ... / Unlike you, I ...
Agreeing	I agree with you because ... / That makes sense to me.
Disagreeing (politely)	I see it a little differently. / I understand, but I think ...

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person students will discuss the prompt orally in small groups of 3–4, then one member of each group will briefly report the group's main ideas back to the whole class. **Zoom** students will be placed into breakout rooms to discuss the same prompt, taking notes in a shared Google Doc that the instructor can review afterward; groups will return to the main session for a short whole-class share-out. **Canvas LMS** students will post their original response to the discussion board asynchronously and reply to at least two classmates within the module timeframe, using the sentence frames and functional language above to structure their responses in writing.

Discussion Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Beginning (1)
Content/Relevance	Fully addresses all 3 parts with specific, personal detail	Addresses most parts with adequate detail	Addresses only 1–2 parts, limited detail	Off-topic or minimal response
Grammar Use	Uses conditional/wish/hope accurately and naturally	Uses structure(s) with minor errors	Attempts structure with frequent errors	Does not attempt module grammar

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Beginning (1)
Vocabulary Use	Uses 2+ module vocabulary accurately	Uses 1–2 words, mostly accurate	Attempts vocabulary with inaccuracy	Little to no vocabulary use
Engagement with Peers	Both replies are thoughtful, specific, and extend the conversation	Replies are relevant but general	Replies are brief or generic	Missing one or both replies

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is for your own practice and self-assessment. It is not graded, but completing it will help you prepare for the module writing assignment and discussion board.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word to its correct definition.

Word	Definition
1. budget	a. a written, legally binding agreement
2. contract	b. a plan for spending and saving money
3. warranty	c. money given back after a return or problem
4. refund	d. a company's promise to repair/replace a broken product
5. deposit	e. one of several regular payments over time
6. statement	f. money paid in advance as a guarantee
7. overdraft	g. an official record of bank account activity
8. interest rate	h. legal protections for buyers of goods/services
9. consumer rights	i. spending more money than is available in an account
10. installment	j. the extra cost charged for borrowing money

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

- The car dealership offered a 6-month (**warranty** / **deposit**) in case anything broke.
- She was upset when the bank charged her an (**installment** / **overdraft**) fee.
- I read every word of the (**contract** / **refund**) before I signed my apartment lease.
- His (**consumer rights** / **interest rate**) allow him to return a defective product.
- We paid the used car in monthly (**statements** / **installments**) for two years.
- Please check your bank (**statement** / **warranty**) for any unusual charges.
- Landlords typically require a security (**deposit** / **refund**) before move-in.
- A high (**budget** / **interest rate**) can make a loan much more expensive over time.

Section 3: Grammar Identification/Application

Identify whether each sentence uses the **present unreal conditional (C)**, a **wish clause (W)**, or a **hope clause (H)**. Then, for items 9–12, complete the sentence with the correct verb form.

- If I had more savings, I would feel more secure. _____

2. I hope the bank fixes this error quickly. _____
3. She wishes she understood her contract better. _____
4. If they read the warranty, they would know their rights. _____
5. We hope that the refund arrives this week. _____
6. I wish I were more careful with my spending. _____
7. If he were the manager, he would approve the refund. _____
8. They hope the company will respond soon. _____
9. If I _____ (have) a better budget, I would save more each month.
10. She wishes she _____ (know) more about interest rates.
11. We hope the store _____ (accept) our return.
12. If he _____ (check) his statement, he would have noticed the overdraft.

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the grammar error in each sentence.

1. If I would have more money, I would save it.
2. I wish I know more about consumer rights.
3. She hope that the refund arrives soon.
4. If he was more careful, he would not have signed that contract.
5. We wishes we had a bigger budget.
6. I hope that she will fixed the mistake on my statement.
7. If they check the interest rate, they would have chosen a different loan.
8. I wish I was better at saving money. (*acceptable informally, but formally...*)

Section 5: Short Writing Check

Prompt: In 3–4 sentences, describe one financial goal you have, using at least one conditional, wish, or hope sentence.

Self-Evaluation Checklist

Check	Yes/No
I used at least one conditional, wish, or hope sentence correctly.	
I used at least one vocabulary word from this module.	
My sentences are complete and make sense.	
I checked my spelling and punctuation.	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Quiz me on the 10 consumer and financial vocabulary words from Module 5. Give me a sentence with a blank, and check my answer."	Interactive practice with immediate feedback on word choice and usage

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Grammar	"Give me 5 sentences with blanks to practice the present unreal conditional, wish clauses, and hope clauses. Check my answers and explain any mistakes."	Extra graduated grammar practice with explanations
Writing Feedback	"Here is my paragraph about my budgeting plan. Can you check it for grammar, especially conditional/wish/hope sentences, and tell me how to improve it?"	Personalized feedback on grammar, organization, and vocabulary use
Discussion Practice	"Can you role-play a classmate for the Module 5 discussion board? Ask me about my money-saving habits and respond with a comparison."	Speaking/writing rehearsal before posting to the real discussion board

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity A: Sentence Combining

Combine each pair of sentences into one sentence using the present unreal conditional.

1. I don't have a big emergency fund. I worry about unexpected costs. → _____
2. She doesn't check her statement often. She misses errors. → _____
3. They don't understand the contract. They sign it anyway. → _____

Activity B: Subject-Verb Agreement Review

Choose the correct verb form.

1. She (wish / wishes) she had more savings.
2. We (hope / hopes) the refund arrives soon.
3. He (wish / wishes) he were more careful with money.
4. They (hope / hopes) the bank fixes the mistake.

Activity C: Word Forms

Complete the chart with the correct word form.

Noun	Verb	Adjective
budget	budget	_____
_____	deposit	_____
refund	refund	_____

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Free drop-in and appointment-based tutoring for reading, writing, and grammar support. Bring your module materials for personalized help.
- **Writing Center:** One-on-one support for brainstorming, drafting, and revising your paragraph or letter assignment.
- **Library:** Access to computers, printing, and quiet study space, plus librarian help finding reliable consumer/financial information sources.
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and support services for students with documented disabilities, including extra time, alternative formats, and assistive technology.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary by Skill Area

Skill	What Students Learned
Reading/Vocabulary	Read an authentic-style passage on budgeting and consumer rights; learned 10 financial vocabulary words; practiced identifying author's purpose, audience, and tone; practiced selecting correct dictionary definitions for unfamiliar financial terms
Grammar	Practiced the present unreal conditional, present wish clauses, and hope clauses to talk about financial goals, regrets, and hopes
Writing/Communication	Wrote an informational paragraph about a budgeting plan or a formal business letter requesting a refund/disputing a charge; participated in a discussion board exchange about money habits and consumer experiences

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
USA.gov Consumer Protection	Official information on consumer rights, filing complaints, and identifying scams	https://www.usa.gov/consumer-complaints
Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB)	Plain-language guides on budgeting, bank accounts, credit, and consumer rights	https://www.consumerfinance.gov/consumer-tools/
Purdue OWL	Guidance on business letter format and formal writing conventions	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/subject_guides/index.html
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Simple definitions and example sentences for unfamiliar financial vocabulary	https://learnersdictionary.com/
VOA Learning English	Listening/reading practice with everyday and financial English topics	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/
BBC Learning English	Grammar and vocabulary lessons, including conditionals and wish/hope structures	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish

Looking Ahead

This Module Connects To

Module 6 (Education & Academic Success): future progressive and planning-based grammar builds on the goal-oriented language practiced here with conditionals, wishes, and hopes

Ongoing workforce/civic preparation: reading contracts and understanding consumer rights supports future tasks like reviewing job offers, leases, and benefits paperwork

Continued academic writing: informational paragraph and business letter skills will be reinforced in later modules' writing assignments

Reflection Questions

1. What is one new financial vocabulary word from this module that you will try to use in real life, and how?
2. How did practicing the present unreal conditional, wish clauses, and hope clauses help you express your financial goals more clearly?
3. What is one thing you learned about consumer rights that surprised you or that you did not know before?
4. Which was more useful to you: writing the budgeting paragraph or the refund/dispute letter? Why?

5. What is one money-saving habit or consumer tip from a classmate's discussion post that you might try yourself?

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 5: Consumer and Financial Literacy | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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6: Education and Academic Success

Module 6: Education and Academic Success

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Every semester, students face the same challenge: how do I balance classes, work, family, and everything else on my plate? This module gives students the language and strategies to answer that question with confidence. Education and Academic Success is about more than grammar — it is about helping students read a syllabus with confidence, take useful notes, manage a busy schedule, and talk about their goals in clear, natural English. These are skills students will use in every class they take, in every workshop they attend, and in every conversation with an instructor or advisor. Because so many ESL 304 students are balancing school with jobs and family responsibilities, learning to talk about plans, priorities, and time management is directly relevant to their daily lives.

This module also introduces two grammar structures that let students talk about the future with more precision: the future progressive tense (for actions that will be in progress at a specific future time) and reflexive/indefinite pronouns (for talking about oneself and about unspecified people or things). Together, these structures help students describe study plans, ask about classmates' schedules, and reflect on their own responsibility for their learning — all central ideas in academic success.

In this module, students will:

- Read and discuss an original passage about building strong study habits in college
- Learn and apply 10 academic/study vocabulary words in speaking and writing
- Form and use future progressive questions (Yes/No, Or, and Wh-) to talk about plans and schedules
- Use reflexive pronouns (myself, yourself, herself, etc.) and indefinite pronouns (someone, anything, everybody, etc.) accurately in speech and writing
- Write a well-developed paragraph describing a personal study plan or time-management strategy
- Practice active listening, note-taking, and syllabus/calendar reading strategies
- Participate in a discussion board exchange comparing study strategies with classmates

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Identify main ideas and supporting details in a text about study skills; distinguish facts from opinions in advice-style writing; use context clues to understand academic vocabulary
Vocabulary	Use 10 academic/study-skills words accurately in speaking and writing (e.g., <i>syllabus</i> , <i>deadline</i> , <i>priority</i> , <i>procrastinate</i> , <i>organize</i>)
Grammar	Form and answer future progressive Yes/No, Or, and Wh-questions; use reflexive and indefinite pronouns correctly in sentences
Writing	Write a well-developed paragraph (topic sentence + 3 supporting details + conclusion) describing a personal study plan or time-management strategy
Speaking and Listening	Practice active listening and note-taking strategies; discuss and compare study strategies with classmates using functional and persuasive language

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1–2	Vocabulary introduction; read "Building Habits That Help You Succeed"; comprehension questions	Vocabulary fill-in-blank + comprehension questions
1	Day 3	Grammar Lesson Part 1: Future progressive questions (Yes/No, Or, Wh-)	Grammar Practice Activity 1
1	Day 4	Grammar Lesson Part 2: Reflexive and indefinite pronouns (In-person: pair error-hunt worksheet in class; Zoom: breakout rooms editing a shared document; Canvas: async self-paced grammar module with auto-graded check)	Grammar Practice Activities 2–3
1	Day 5	Introduce Writing Assignment; model paragraph analysis; brainstorming/prewriting organizer	Prewriting graphic organizer draft
2	Day 6	Writing workshop: draft, peer feedback (In-person: paper drafts exchanged in small groups; Zoom: shared Google Doc peer review in breakout rooms; Canvas: peer review via discussion board thread)	First draft of study-plan paragraph
2	Day 7	Discussion Board opens: share study strategies and time-management tips (In-person: small-group discussion with report-back to class; Zoom: breakout rooms with shared notes doc; Canvas: async discussion board post + 2 replies)	Original discussion post
2	Day 8	Revise and edit final paragraph; submit	Final study-plan paragraph (multimodal option)
2	Day 9–10	Self-Check Quiz (ungraded); Module wrap-up and reflection	Self-Check Quiz review; Reflection Questions

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Future progressive — Yes/No questions	To ask if an action will be in progress at a specific future time	Will you be attending the workshop on Friday?

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Future progressive — Or questions	To ask someone to choose between two future actions in progress	Will you be studying at the library or at home tonight?
Future progressive — Wh- questions	To ask for specific information about an action in progress in the future	What will you be studying next week?
Reflexive pronouns	To show that the subject and object of a sentence are the same person	I organized myself a study schedule.
Indefinite pronouns	To talk about people, things, or amounts that are not specific or named	Everybody needs a plan. Someone left their notes here.

Delivery Mode Note

This module is designed to work seamlessly across all three delivery formats offered at Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education. **In-person** students will complete activities using printed worksheets, whiteboard modeling, and face-to-face pair/small-group work, with the instructor circulating to give real-time feedback. **Zoom** students will follow the same lesson sequence synchronously, using breakout rooms for pair/group tasks, the chat feature for quick comprehension checks, and screen-sharing for reviewing the reading passage and grammar examples together. **Canvas LMS** students will move through the same content asynchronously: reading the module page, submitting the vocabulary and grammar practice as auto-graded or instructor-graded quizzes, watching any recorded mini-lectures, and completing the discussion board and writing assignment on their own schedule before each due date. All three formats use the same vocabulary, grammar targets, reading passage, and rubrics, so a student who moves between modalities during the semester experiences no gap in content.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
syllabus	noun	a document from a teacher that lists course topics, assignments, and deadlines	The syllabus says our first essay is due on September 20.
deadline	noun	the latest time or date by which something must be finished	If you miss the deadline, you may lose points on the assignment.
priority	noun	something that is more important than other things and should be done first	Finishing my homework is my top priority tonight.
procrastinate	verb	to delay or put off doing something that should be done	If you procrastinate, you will feel stressed right before the test.
organize	verb	to arrange things or plans in a clear, orderly way	She organizes her notes by subject so she can find them quickly.
schedule	noun/verb	a plan that shows when events or tasks will happen	I schedule my study time every Sunday for the week ahead.
workload	noun	the amount of work a person has to do	The workload gets heavier during midterms.
concentrate	verb	to focus your full attention on one task	It is hard to concentrate when the TV is on.

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
review	verb	to look at something again in order to understand or remember it	I review my notes every night before class.
achieve	verb	to successfully complete a goal through effort	With a good plan, you can achieve your academic goals.

Original Reading: "Building Habits That Help You Succeed"

Getting Started with a Plan

Every semester, thousands of adult students walk into their first class with the same hope: to succeed. But hope alone does not create good grades — habits do. The first tool every successful student learns to use is the syllabus. A syllabus is more than a piece of paper; it is a roadmap for the entire course. It tells you what topics will be covered, which assignments carry the most weight, and — most importantly — every deadline you need to remember. Students who read their syllabus carefully in the first week rarely get surprised by a due date later in the semester. Marta, a student in an evening ESL class, keeps her syllabus taped to her refrigerator. "I see it every morning when I get my coffee," she says. "It reminds me what is coming next."

Turning a Syllabus into a Schedule

Reading a syllabus is only the first step. The real skill is turning that document into a working schedule. Many successful students transfer every deadline from the syllabus into a calendar — paper or digital — the same week classes begin. This simple habit prevents the common problem of forgetting an assignment until the night before it is due. Once deadlines are on a calendar, students can set their priorities. A priority is something that must come before other, less urgent tasks. For working adults with children, jobs, and other obligations, deciding what to prioritize each day can be the difference between a stressful week and a manageable one. Instructors often recommend a simple rule: look at your calendar every Sunday and identify the three most important academic tasks for the coming week. Everything else can wait.

Fighting the Urge to Procrastinate

Even with a clear schedule, many students procrastinate — they put off starting an assignment even when they know it is important. Procrastination often happens because a task feels too big or too boring to begin. The solution many tutors suggest is breaking large assignments into smaller pieces. Instead of thinking, "I have to write a five-paragraph essay," a student might think, "Today I will just write the topic sentence." Small steps make a heavy workload feel manageable rather than overwhelming. Time-management experts also recommend the twenty-minute rule: commit to working on a task for just twenty minutes. Often, once students start, they find it easier to keep going.

Concentration and Review

Once students sit down to study, the next challenge is learning to concentrate. Phones, family conversations, and noisy environments can pull attention away from schoolwork in seconds. Successful students protect blocks of quiet time, even short ones, and treat that time as seriously as a work shift or a doctor's appointment. Equally important is the habit of review. Reviewing notes and vocabulary regularly — rather than only right before a test — helps information move from short-term to long-term memory. A ten-minute review each evening is often more effective than a three-hour review session the night before an exam.

Reaching Your Goals

None of these habits — reading a syllabus, building a schedule, resisting procrastination, concentrating, and reviewing — guarantees success by itself. Together, though, they form a system that helps students achieve their academic goals steadily, week by week. Success in an academic program rarely comes from a single burst of motivation. It comes from small, repeated actions: opening the calendar, checking off one task, reviewing one page of notes. As one instructor tells her class every semester, "You do not need to be perfect. You just need to be organized, and you need to keep showing up." For adult learners juggling school, work, and family, that steady, organized approach is often the most realistic path to academic success.

(approximately 530 words)

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word bank: syllabus, deadline, priority, procrastinate, organize, schedule, workload, concentrate, review, achieve

1. I checked the _____ to see when our research paper is due.
2. If you _____ too much, you will end up rushing at the last minute.
3. My top _____ this week is finishing my math homework before the quiz.
4. It is hard to _____ when my phone keeps buzzing with messages.
5. Every Sunday, I _____ my study time for the whole week.
6. The professor extended the _____ for the essay by two days.
7. During finals, the _____ can feel heavy because every class has a big project due.
8. I always _____ my vocabulary flashcards before I go to sleep.
9. She uses a planner to _____ her assignments by due date.
10. With hard work and a good plan, you can _____ your academic goals.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. What is the main idea of "Building Habits That Help You Succeed"?
2. According to the reading, what is the first thing successful students do with their syllabus?
3. What rule does the reading suggest for choosing priorities each week?
4. What technique does the reading mention for overcoming procrastination?
5. Why is reviewing notes a little every day better than reviewing only before a test?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Which habit from the reading (syllabus use, scheduling, avoiding procrastination, concentration, or review) do you think would help you the most this semester? Why?
2. Marta tapes her syllabus to her refrigerator so she sees it every day. Do you have a similar strategy for remembering important dates or tasks? Describe it, or describe a new strategy you would like to try.

Reading Strategy: Facts vs. Opinions

Academic and advice-style texts, like this reading, often mix **facts** (statements that can be proven true) with **opinions** (beliefs, recommendations, or judgments that people may disagree with). Learning to tell them apart helps readers evaluate advice critically instead of accepting every statement as proven truth.

Type	How to Recognize It	Example from the Reading
Fact	Can be checked or verified; often describes what something is or does	"A syllabus is more than a piece of paper; it is a roadmap for the entire course."
Opinion	Reflects a belief, recommendation, or judgment; often uses words like <i>should</i> , <i>recommend</i> , <i>often</i> , <i>many</i> , <i>experts suggest</i>	"Time-management experts also recommend the twenty-minute rule."

Practice: Find one more fact and one more opinion in the reading passage and share them with a partner. Explain how you identified each one.

Grammar Lesson

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Future progressive — Yes/No questions	Will + subject + be + verb-ing...?	To ask if an action will be in progress at a specific future time	tonight, tomorrow at [time], this weekend, next week	Will you be attending the workshop on Friday?
Future progressive — Or questions	Will + subject + be + verb-ing...A or B?	To ask someone to choose between two future ongoing actions	or, either...or	Will you be studying at the library or at home tonight?
Future progressive — Wh- questions	Wh-word + will + subject + be + verb-ing...?	To ask for specific information about a future ongoing action (what, where, when, who, how)	what, where, when, who, how	What will you be studying next week?
Reflexive pronouns	subject + verb + myself/yourself/himself/herself/itself/ourselves/yourselves/themselves	When the subject and object of the sentence refer to the same person or thing; to emphasize that someone did something alone	by + reflexive pronoun (= alone)	I taught myself how to make a study schedule.
Indefinite pronouns	someone/somebody, anyone/anybody, everyone/everybody, no one/nobody + singular verb; something, anything, everything, nothing + singular verb	To talk about people or things that are not specific or named	some-, any-, every-, no- + -one/-body/-thing	Everybody needs a study plan. Did anyone bring a calendar?

Understanding Future Progressive Questions

The **future progressive tense** describes an action that will be in progress — happening, but not finished — at a specific point in the future. It answers the question, "What will be happening at that moment?"

Statement form: subject + will + be + verb-ing

- I will be reviewing my notes at 7:00 tonight.

Yes/No question form: Will + subject + be + verb-ing...?

- Will you be reviewing your notes tonight? → Yes, I will. / No, I won't.

Or question form: Will + subject + be + verb-ing...A or B?

- Will you be reviewing your notes or working on your essay tonight?

Wh- question form: Wh-word + will + subject + be + verb-ing...?

- What will you be reviewing tonight?
- Where will you be studying tomorrow afternoon?
- Who will you be meeting with about your project?

Common errors to avoid:

- Do not forget "be": ~~Will you studying tonight?~~ → Will you **be** studying tonight?
- Do not add "do/does/did": ~~Will you do be studying?~~ → Will you be studying?

- Remember subject-verb word order changes only in the question, not the verb form: What will she be doing? (not "What will be she doing?")

Future progressive is especially useful for talking about class schedules, study plans, and appointments — exactly the kind of planning language students need for academic success. It sounds more natural than simple future when describing an action already understood to be ongoing at a set time, such as "This time next week, I will be taking my final exam."

Understanding Reflexive Pronouns

Reflexive pronouns (myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves) are used when the subject and the object of a sentence refer to the same person or thing.

- I organized **myself** a study schedule. (I = the one organizing; myself = the one being helped)
- She reminded **herself** to check the deadline.
- They taught **themselves** how to use the online library.

Reflexive pronouns are also used after the preposition "by" to mean "alone" or "without help":

- He finished the assignment **by himself**.
- Did you review the material **by yourself**, or did you study with a group?

Common errors to avoid:

- Do not confuse reflexive pronouns with object pronouns: ~~I saw me in the mirror.~~ → I saw **myself** in the mirror.
- Match the reflexive pronoun to the subject: He helped **himself** (not herself).
- "Myself" is not used simply to sound polite in place of "me": ~~Please contact myself with questions.~~ → Please contact **me** with questions.

Understanding Indefinite Pronouns

Indefinite pronouns refer to people, things, or amounts that are not specific or named. They are formed by combining *some-*, *any-*, *every-*, or *no-* with *-one*, *-body*, or *-thing*.

	People	Things
some- (a certain unnamed one)	someone / somebody	something
any- (used in questions/negatives)	anyone / anybody	anything
every- (all, without exception)	everyone / everybody	everything
no- (none)	no one / nobody	nothing

- **Everybody** needs a study plan this semester.
- Did **anyone** bring extra pens?
- I left **something** in the classroom yesterday.
- **No one** wants to fail the midterm.

Grammar rule: Indefinite pronouns are singular and take a singular verb, even though some (like *everybody*) may feel like they refer to more than one person.

- Correct: Everybody **needs** a plan. (not "need")
- Correct: Someone **is** waiting outside. (not "are")

Common errors to avoid:

- Subject-verb agreement: ~~Everyone are~~ → Everyone **is**
- Choosing *any-* vs. *some-*: Use *some-* words in affirmative statements and offers; use *any-* words in questions and negative statements.

- I have **something** to review tonight. (affirmative)
- Do you have **anything** to review tonight? (question)
- I don't have **anything** to review tonight. (negative)

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Multiple Choice — Future Progressive Questions Choose the correct question form.

- _____ studying at the library tomorrow night?
a) Will you be b) Are you will be c) Will you being
- What _____ reviewing before the quiz?
a) will you be b) you will be c) will be you
- _____ attending the workshop or the tutoring session on Thursday?
a) Will you be b) Are you be c) You will be
- Where _____ working on your essay this weekend?
a) will you be b) you be will c) will be you
- _____ meeting with your study group at 6:00 PM?
a) Will she be b) She will be c) Will be she

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank — Reflexive and Indefinite Pronouns Choose the correct reflexive or indefinite pronoun.

- I made _____ a new study calendar this semester. (myself/anybody)
- _____ left their notebook in the classroom. (Someone/Anyone)
- Did _____ finish the reading assignment? (someone/anyone)
- He organizes his backpack _____ every night before class. (himself/anybody)
- _____ wants to fail the final exam. (Everybody/Nobody)
- We taught _____ how to use the campus library database. (ourselves/anything)
- There is _____ important on today's agenda. (something/anything)
- She reminded _____ to check the syllabus for the new deadline. (herself/somebody)

Activity 3: Sentence Writing — Combining Both Structures Write a complete sentence for each prompt, using the grammar structure indicated.

- (Future progressive Wh- question) Ask a classmate what they will be doing to prepare for the final exam.
- (Future progressive Yes/No question) Ask a classmate if they will be studying alone this weekend.
- (Reflexive pronoun) Describe something you plan to do for yourself to reduce stress this semester.
- (Indefinite pronoun) Write a sentence about something everybody in your class needs to succeed.
- (Future progressive Or question) Ask a classmate whether they will be reviewing vocabulary or grammar tonight.

Writing Assignment

In this module, students will write a **well-developed paragraph** describing a personal study plan or time-management strategy for succeeding this semester. This paragraph type follows the COR-required structure: a topic sentence that states the main idea, three supporting details that explain or illustrate it, and a conclusion that wraps up the paragraph. This is the same structural skill used throughout ESL 304 — but here, students apply it to a topic that matters immediately: their own success this term.

Parts of a Study-Plan Paragraph

Part	Purpose

Part	Purpose
Topic Sentence	States the main idea of the paragraph — your overall approach to managing your time or studying this semester
Supporting Detail 1	Explains one specific strategy or habit, with an example of how you use it
Supporting Detail 2	Explains a second specific strategy or habit, with an example
Supporting Detail 3	Explains a third specific strategy or habit, with an example
Conclusion	Restates the main idea in different words and/or reflects on why this plan will help you succeed

Topic Choices

Option	Topic
1	Describe your personal study schedule and how you plan to keep it, using specific days/times
2	Describe how you manage stress while balancing school, work, and family responsibilities
3	Describe how you use your syllabus and a calendar to stay on track with deadlines
4	Describe the note-taking or review strategies you use (or plan to use) to remember what you learn
5	Student choice: Describe your own time-management or study strategy not listed above (instructor approval required)

Assignment Requirements

- Length: one well-developed paragraph, 7–10 sentences
- Structure: topic sentence + 3 supporting details + conclusion
- Grammar: include at least one future progressive sentence (statement or question) describing a specific study plan, and at least one reflexive or indefinite pronoun used correctly
- Vocabulary: use at least 4 of the 10 module vocabulary words naturally
- Transitions: use at least 2 transition words to connect ideas
- Format: typed or handwritten (see Multimodal Submission Options below); double-spaced if typed

Transition Words for This Assignment

Purpose	Transition Words
Adding a detail	First, In addition, Also, Furthermore
Giving an example	For example, For instance, Specifically
Showing sequence/time	Every morning, After that, Next, Finally
Concluding	In conclusion, Overall, As a result

Model Text

My Plan for a Successful Semester

My main strategy for succeeding this semester is to stay organized every single week. First, every Sunday evening, I sit down with my syllabus and write all my deadlines on a wall calendar in my kitchen, where I see it every day. This habit helps me avoid last-

minute surprises about due dates. In addition, I give myself thirty minutes each evening to review my notes and vocabulary instead of waiting until the night before a test. For example, this week I will be reviewing my grammar notes on Tuesday and Thursday nights after dinner. Finally, when I feel my workload becoming too heavy, I break big assignments into smaller tasks so I do not procrastinate. Will I be perfect every week? Probably not — but everybody makes mistakes sometimes, and I know that a steady plan is more powerful than a perfect one. In conclusion, by organizing my time, reviewing regularly, and breaking down big tasks, I feel confident that I can achieve my goals this semester.

The Writing Process

1. **Prewrite** — Choose your topic and brainstorm using the graphic organizer below.
2. **Draft** — Write your topic sentence, three supporting details, and conclusion in full sentences.
3. **Revise** — Read your paragraph again. Does every sentence support your topic sentence? Add or remove details as needed.
4. **Edit** — Check grammar (especially future progressive and reflexive/indefinite pronouns), spelling, capitalization, and punctuation.
5. **Publish** — Submit your final paragraph using one of the multimodal options below.

Prewriting Graphic Organizer

Paragraph Part	Your Notes
Topic Sentence (main idea)	
Supporting Detail 1 + example	
Supporting Detail 2 + example	
Supporting Detail 3 + example	
Conclusion	

Revision Checklist

Check	Yes/No
My topic sentence clearly states my main idea.	
I included exactly 3 supporting details, each with an example.	
I used at least 4 vocabulary words from this module.	
I used at least one future progressive sentence correctly.	
I used at least one reflexive or indefinite pronoun correctly.	
I used at least 2 transition words.	
My conclusion restates my main idea in different words.	
I checked spelling, capitalization, and punctuation.	

Grading Rubric (20 points total)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Paragraph Structure	Clear topic sentence, 3 supporting details, strong conclusion	Mostly clear structure; minor gaps	Structure present but incomplete or unclear	Missing key structural parts

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Grammar (future progressive, reflexive/indefinite pronouns)	Used accurately and naturally, no errors	Used correctly with 1–2 minor errors	Attempted but with frequent errors	Not used or used incorrectly throughout
Vocabulary Use	4+ words used naturally and correctly	3 words used correctly	1–2 words used, some incorrect	Vocabulary missing or misused
Mechanics (spelling, punctuation, capitalization)	Virtually error-free	Minor errors that do not affect meaning	Several errors that affect clarity	Frequent errors that block understanding

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 (Typed):** Type your paragraph and submit it through Canvas, or hand it to your instructor in-person/print for a Zoom class as instructed.
- **Option 2 (Handwritten + Photo):** Write your paragraph by hand, then take a clear photo and upload it to Canvas — a good option for students still building digital typing skills.
- **Option 3 (Audio Recording):** Record yourself reading your paragraph aloud and submit the audio file through Canvas — this option also builds oral fluency and pronunciation practice.

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

This week's discussion focuses on sharing real strategies that can help every student in the class. Respond to all three parts:

1. **Share:** What is one study strategy or time-management tip that works well for you? Describe it in detail (when you do it, how you do it, why it helps).
2. **Compare:** Read a classmate's post. How is their strategy similar to or different from yours?
3. **Advise:** Based on what you have read and discussed, give one piece of advice to a classmate who says they are struggling to keep up with their workload this semester.

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	Answers Part 1 (Share) in 4–6 sentences; uses at least 2 module vocabulary words	10
Reply 1	Responds to a classmate's post; answers Part 2 (Compare) in 2–3 sentences	5
Reply 2	Responds to a different classmate's post; answers Part 3 (Advise) in 2–3 sentences	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Sharing a strategy	One strategy that works well for me is _____.
Explaining when/how	I usually do this _____ (when), and it helps me _____ (why).

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Comparing	My strategy is similar to yours because _____. / My strategy is different because _____.
Giving advice	If you are struggling with _____, you might try _____.
Asking a follow-up question	Have you ever tried _____? Will you be trying that this week?

Functional and Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrases
Stating an opinion	In my opinion... / I believe... / From my experience...
Supporting with a reason	This works because... / The reason I do this is...
Comparing	Similarly... / In contrast... / Unlike me, you...
Agreeing	I agree with you because... / That makes sense to me since...
Disagreeing (respectfully)	I see it a little differently... / That works for you, but I find that...

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person classes will hold this discussion as a small-group conversation (3–4 students), where each student shares their strategy aloud, compares it with group members, and then one representative from each group reports the group's best tip back to the whole class. **Zoom** classes will move into breakout rooms of 3–4 students for the same conversation, with one student in each room taking notes in a shared Google Doc to report back in the main session. **Canvas** students will complete this discussion asynchronously: they will post their original response to the discussion board by the posted deadline, then reply to two different classmates' posts by a later deadline, allowing time for genuine reflection and real written exchange between students who may never meet synchronously.

Discussion Grading Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Content and Relevance	Fully answers all parts of the prompt with specific, thoughtful detail	Answers most parts with adequate detail	Answers only part of the prompt or lacks detail	Off-topic or missing required parts
Vocabulary and Grammar Use	Uses vocabulary and grammar from this module accurately and naturally	Uses vocabulary/grammar with minor errors	Limited or inconsistent use	Vocabulary/grammar targets missing
Engagement with Classmates	Both replies show genuine comparison and thoughtful advice	Replies address the prompt with adequate engagement	Replies are brief or generic	Replies missing or unrelated to classmate's post
Clarity and Mechanics	Clear, well-organized, virtually error-free	Clear with minor errors	Some unclear sentences or frequent errors	Difficult to understand due to errors

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is for practice only and will not be graded. Use it to check your own understanding before the module assessment.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word to its definition.

1. syllabus a. to delay doing something
2. deadline b. to look at something again to remember it
3. priority c. the amount of work a person has
4. procrastinate d. a course document listing topics and due dates
5. organize e. the latest time something must be finished
6. schedule f. something more important than other tasks
7. workload g. to arrange things in an orderly way
8. concentrate h. a plan showing when tasks will happen
9. review i. to focus full attention on a task
10. achieve j. to successfully reach a goal

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. I always check the _____ before I start a new class. (syllabus/workload)
2. She never _____ her assignments; she always starts them early. (procrastinates/organizes)
3. Passing my English class is my top _____ this year. (deadline/priority)
4. He _____ his backpack every night so he is ready for class. (organizes/achieves)
5. My study _____ includes two hours every evening. (schedule/deadline)
6. This semester's _____ feels heavier than last semester's. (workload/priority)
7. I cannot _____ when the room is too noisy. (concentrate/review)
8. If you _____ your notes every night, you will remember more. (review/procrastinate)

Section 3: Grammar Identification/Application

Identify the grammar structure in each sentence (Future Progressive or Reflexive/Indefinite Pronoun), then answer or complete as instructed.

1. Will you be attending the study group tomorrow? (Identify the structure.)
2. What will you be reviewing before the test? (Identify the structure.)
3. Everybody needs a plan for the semester. (Identify the structure.)
4. She taught herself how to make a schedule. (Identify the structure.)
5. Will you be studying alone or with a partner tonight? (Identify the structure.)
6. Complete: _____ will you be meeting with about your project? (Fill in a Wh- word.)
7. Complete: I organized _____ (myself/anybody) a new calendar.
8. Complete: Did _____ (someone/anyone) bring extra paper?
9. Complete: _____ (Will she be/She will be) taking the workshop next week?
10. Complete: There is _____ (something/anything) I need to review tonight.
11. Write a future progressive Yes/No question about tomorrow's homework.
12. Write a sentence using an indefinite pronoun about your class.

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the error in each sentence.

1. Will you studying at the library tonight?
2. What will be you doing after class?
3. Everybody need a good schedule.
4. I taught me how to use a planner.
5. Did someone bring they notebook?
6. She organize herself a calendar every week.
7. Anybody are welcome to join the study group.
8. Nobody have finished the assignment yet.
9. Will you be review your notes tonight?
10. He reminded hisself to check the deadline.

Section 5: Short Writing Check

Prompt: In 3–4 sentences, describe one thing you will be doing this week to prepare for your classes. Use at least one future progressive question or statement and one vocabulary word from this module.

Self-Evaluation Checklist

Check	Yes/No
I used the future progressive tense correctly.	
I used at least one module vocabulary word.	
My sentences are complete and make sense.	
I checked my spelling and punctuation.	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Give me 5 new sentences using the words syllabus, deadline, priority, workload, and review, and check if my own sentences use them correctly."	Extra example sentences and feedback on your own sentence accuracy
Grammar	"Ask me 5 future progressive Wh-questions about my weekly schedule, and check my answers for grammar errors."	Extra guided practice with personalized error correction
Writing Feedback	"Read my study-plan paragraph and tell me if my topic sentence, three supporting details, and conclusion are clear. Point out any grammar errors with reflexive or indefinite pronouns."	Structural feedback plus targeted grammar correction
Discussion Practice	"Role-play a classmate sharing a time-management strategy. Ask me a follow-up question, and then help me practice replying with a comparison."	Simulated conversation practice for the discussion board task

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining Combine the two short sentences into one sentence using a reflexive pronoun.

1. She made a plan. She made it alone. → _____
2. I will finish this project. I will not get help. → _____
3. They organized a study group. No one helped them. → _____

Activity 2: Subject-Verb Agreement with Indefinite Pronouns Choose the correct verb form.

1. Everybody (want/wants) to pass the class.
2. Somebody (leave/leaves) their notebook here every week.
3. Nothing (matter/matters) more than finishing on time.
4. Anyone (can/cans) join the study group.

Activity 3: Word Forms Complete the chart with the correct word form.

Verb	Noun	Adjective
organize	organization	organized
schedule	schedule	scheduled
concentrate	concentration	concentrated
achieve	achievement	achieved

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Free drop-in and by-appointment tutoring is available for reading, writing, and study-skills support. Tutors can help you plan a personal study schedule or review vocabulary and grammar from this module.
- **Writing Center:** Provides one-on-one feedback on drafts, including the study-plan paragraph in this module — a great place to get help before submitting your final draft.
- **Library:** Offers quiet study space, computer access, and databases for research; librarians can also help students learn to organize research materials.
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and learning support for students with documented disabilities, including extended time, note-taking support, and assistive technology — contact DSPS early in the semester to arrange accommodations.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary by Skill Area

Skill Area	What Students Learned
Reading and Vocabulary	Read an authentic-style passage on building academic success habits; learned 10 academic/study vocabulary words; practiced distinguishing facts from opinions
Grammar	Formed and used future progressive Yes/No, Or, and Wh-questions; used reflexive and indefinite pronouns accurately in speech and writing
Writing and Communication	Wrote a well-developed paragraph (topic sentence + 3 supporting details + conclusion) describing a personal study plan; practiced peer feedback and revision; participated in a discussion board exchange comparing study strategies

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
Purdue OWL: Paragraphing	Guidance on writing clear, well-organized paragraphs with topic sentences and supporting details	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_w...agraphing.html
VOA Learning English: Ways to Make Studying More Powerful	Study techniques including focus strategies, self-testing, and building a study plan, written in learner-friendly English	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/.../5380865.html
VOA Learning English: How Do I Improve My English?	Practical tips on setting a study schedule and study goals for English learners	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/...-/5225657.html
BBC Learning English: Vocabulary	Ongoing vocabulary-building lessons and audio practice for English learners	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish/vocabulary
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Learner-friendly definitions, example sentences, and pronunciation for academic vocabulary words	https://learnersdictionary.com

Looking Ahead

This Module	Connects To
Future progressive questions	Used again for describing plans and interviews in future workplace communication tasks
Reflexive and indefinite pronouns	Reinforced in future personal narrative and autobiography writing
Syllabus/calendar and time-management skills	Applied directly in job-readiness and workforce-preparation modules (schedules, deadlines, workload at a job)
Active listening and note-taking	Builds toward evaluating authentic listening passages and podcasts in future modules (COR SLO 1)

Reflection Questions

1. Which vocabulary word from this module do you think you will use most often, and why?
2. What is one new time-management strategy from this module that you plan to try this semester?
3. Did writing your study-plan paragraph change how you think about your own habits? How?
4. Which grammar structure, future progressive questions or reflexive/indefinite pronouns, did you find more challenging? Why?
5. How did comparing strategies with classmates on the discussion board change or confirm your own approach to studying?

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 6: Education and Academic Success | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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7: Technology and Digital Literacy

Module 7: Technology and Digital Literacy

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Technology is part of almost every part of daily life — from paying bills and applying for jobs to helping children with homework and staying in touch with family. Knowing how to use technology well is important, but knowing how to *judge* technology — deciding which websites, apps, and videos are trustworthy and useful — is just as important. In this module, students will practice evaluating digital resources for credibility and usefulness, build vocabulary for talking about technology, and learn to use active and passive voice in the simple present tense to describe how technology works and is used. Students will also practice adding visuals and multimedia to a report or presentation, a skill that supports both academic and workplace communication.

In this module, students will:

- Read an authentic-style article about evaluating websites and apps for credibility
- Learn and use 10 key vocabulary words related to technology and digital literacy
- Study and practice active and passive voice in the simple present tense
- Use context clues and word parts (prefixes, suffixes, roots) to figure out the meaning of new technology words
- Write a short informational paragraph evaluating a digital resource (a website, app, or video)
- Participate in a discussion board about a useful app or website for learning English
- Practice incorporating visuals and multimedia into a short report

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Identify main ideas and supporting details in a text about evaluating digital resources; use context clues and word structure (prefixes, suffixes, roots) to determine the meaning of unfamiliar technology vocabulary
Vocabulary	Define, pronounce, and correctly use 10 technology/digital literacy words in speaking and writing
Grammar	Correctly form and use active and passive voice in the simple present tense to describe technology facts and processes
Writing	Write a well-developed informational paragraph (facts + details + conclusion) evaluating a digital resource for credibility and usefulness
Speaking and Listening	Recommend, justify, and compare digital tools with classmates using persuasive and functional language; participate in pair, group, or online discussion

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1	Introduce module theme; preview vocabulary; discuss personal technology habits (warm-up discussion)	In class / synchronous participation

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 2	Read "Is It Reliable? Evaluating Digital Resources"; complete comprehension questions	Comprehension Check Questions
1	Day 3	Vocabulary practice (fill in the blank); introduce context clues/word structure strategy	Vocabulary Practice worksheet
1	Day 4 (In-person: pair discussion evaluating sample websites in class; Zoom: breakout rooms comparing two sample websites with shared screen; Canvas: async discussion board post comparing two digital tools)	Discussion Board Part 1 — introduce a useful app/website	Discussion Board Original Post
1	Day 5	Grammar Lesson: active and passive voice (simple present); guided practice activities	Grammar Practice Activities 1–2
2	Day 6	Grammar practice continued; sentence writing activity (active/passive)	Grammar Practice Activity 3
2	Day 7	Writing Assignment introduced; prewriting graphic organizer; topic selection	Prewriting organizer
2	Day 8 (In-person: draft in class with instructor conferencing; Zoom: draft during synchronous session with breakout peer review; Canvas: draft and post to peer review discussion thread)	Draft and peer review of informational paragraph	Draft + Peer Feedback
2	Day 9	Revise and edit; incorporate one visual/multimedia element into final version	Final Writing Assignment
2	Day 10	Self-Check Quiz (ungraded review); module wrap-up and reflection	Self-Check Quiz (practice only)

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Active voice (simple present)	Use when the subject performs the action; the focus is on <i>who</i> does something	"Many people use this app every day."
Passive voice (simple present)	Use when the focus is on the action or the receiver of the action, not who performs it; form: <i>am/is/are</i> + <i>past participle</i>	"The website is updated daily."

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Passive voice with "by" phrase (optional)	Use when it is important to mention who performs the action, even though the focus stays on the receiver	"This app is developed by a team of teachers."

Delivery Mode Note

This module is designed to work equally well in three delivery modes. **In-person** students will do vocabulary and grammar practice on paper or with the instructor's projected slides, evaluate real websites in pairs using classroom or library computers, and hold discussion board conversations as spoken pair/small-group activities with a report-back to the whole class. **Zoom** students will use breakout rooms for the same pair and small-group tasks, share their screens to show classmates the websites or apps they are evaluating, and can use the chat feature for quick vocabulary or grammar checks. **Canvas LMS** students will complete the same readings, vocabulary, and grammar activities asynchronously through posted materials, submit writing and discussion posts online (with options for typed text, a photo of handwritten work, or an audio recording), and reply to classmates' discussion board posts on their own schedule. All three modes cover the same content and meet the same learning outcomes.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
credible	adjective	believable and trustworthy; based on facts	"A credible website usually shows the author's name and sources."
source	noun	a person, book, or website that gives information	"Always check the source before you share an article."
browser	noun	a computer program used to look at websites (e.g., Chrome, Safari)	"She opened her browser to search for a recipe."
download	verb	to copy a file, app, or program from the internet onto a device	"Students can download the worksheet from Canvas."
upload	verb	to send a file from your device to the internet	"He uploaded his essay to the discussion board."
multimedia	noun	a combination of text, images, video, and audio used together	"The presentation included multimedia such as photos and a short video."
verify	verb	to check that something is true or correct	"It is important to verify facts before you believe them."
digital footprint	noun phrase	the trail of information a person leaves online through websites, posts, and searches	"Every comment and photo you post becomes part of your digital footprint."
app	noun (short for "application")	a program designed for a phone, tablet, or computer that helps with a specific task	"This app helps students practice English vocabulary."
platform	noun	a type of computer system, website, or app where content or services are provided	"YouTube is a platform where people upload and watch videos."

Original Reading: "Is It Reliable? Evaluating Digital Resources"

Why Evaluation Matters

Every day, people search the internet for answers. They look for health information, news, recipes, and help with homework. A student researching a school project might find hundreds of results in seconds. But not every website, video, or app is trustworthy. Some sources are written by experts and checked carefully. Others are written quickly, without facts, just to get clicks or sell a product. Because anyone can publish anything online, readers must learn to evaluate digital resources — that means judging whether a source is credible and useful before trusting or sharing it.

What Makes a Source Credible?

A credible source is written or produced by someone who understands the topic and presents accurate information. When people evaluate a website, they should ask several questions. Who wrote this, and what are the author's qualifications? Is the website connected to a well-known organization, such as a university, government agency, or respected news company? Is the information current, or was it last updated many years ago? Many reliable websites are updated regularly, and the date of the last update is often shown at the bottom of the page. In addition, a credible source is usually checked and edited by other professionals before it is published. This process, called verification, helps remove mistakes and false claims.

Web addresses can also give clues. Addresses that end in .gov belong to government agencies, and addresses that end in .edu belong to schools and universities. These sites are generally considered reliable because they are managed by institutions with professional standards. Addresses that end in .com or .org can also be trustworthy, but readers should look more closely, since anyone can create these kinds of websites.

Apps and Videos, Too

Evaluation is not only for written websites. Apps and videos are used by millions of people, and they also need to be judged carefully. A useful app is updated often, has clear instructions, and is created by a company or organization with a good reputation. Reviews and ratings from other users can help, but readers should be careful, because some reviews are fake. Educational videos should be produced by a channel or platform known for accuracy, such as a museum, university, or established news organization. A video that includes citations, sources, or links in the description is usually more trustworthy than one that does not.

Building Digital Literacy

Digital literacy is the ability to find, evaluate, and use digital information safely and effectively. This skill is taught in schools because it is used by students and workers every day. For example, employees are often asked to research information for their jobs, and students are expected to support their writing with credible sources rather than random search results. Multimedia — a combination of text, images, video, and audio — is now used by teachers, students, and businesses to communicate more clearly. A report with a chart, a short video clip, or a labeled diagram is often better understood by an audience than plain text alone. Learning to add multimedia to a presentation, while also checking that each source is credible, prepares students for both academic work and the modern workplace.

Protecting Your Digital Footprint

Finally, digital literacy includes understanding one's own digital footprint. Every search, post, comment, and download leaves a trace. Employers, schools, and even strangers can sometimes see this information. Responsible internet users think carefully before they upload personal photos or share private details, and they check their privacy settings on each platform they use. In today's connected world, evaluating outside sources and managing one's own digital footprint are both essential parts of being digitally literate.

(approx. 530 words)

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word bank: credible, source, browser, download, upload, multimedia, verify, digital footprint, app, platform

1. Before you believe a news story, you should try to _____ the facts with another source.
2. My favorite English-learning _____ sends me a new lesson every morning on my phone.
3. She opened her _____ to search for information about local colleges.
4. YouTube is a _____ where anyone can post videos, so not every video is reliable.

5. A government website is usually a more _____ source than a random blog.
6. He needed to _____ the file before he could open it on his laptop.
7. Please _____ your homework to the class discussion board by Friday.
8. Everything you post online becomes part of your _____, so think before you share.
9. The teacher used _____ — pictures, a short video, and sound — to make the lesson more interesting.
10. A good research paper always names its _____, such as a book, article, or website.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. What is the main idea of "Is It Reliable? Evaluating Digital Resources"?
2. According to the reading, what are two questions a person should ask when evaluating a website?
3. What do the web addresses ending in .gov and .edu usually mean?
4. Why should readers be careful with online reviews of apps, according to the passage?
5. What is a "digital footprint," and why does the reading say it is important to think about it?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Think of a website, app, or video you use often. Using what you learned in the reading, is it credible? Why or why not?
2. The reading says that digital literacy is important for both school and work. Describe a time when you (or someone you know) had to check whether online information was trustworthy. What did you do?

Reading Strategy: Context Clues and Word Structure (Affixes and Roots)

When students meet an unfamiliar technology word, they do not always need a dictionary. They can often figure out the meaning by looking at context clues (the words and sentences around the unknown word) and word structure (prefixes, suffixes, and roots inside the word itself).

Strategy	How It Works	Example from the Reading
Context clues	Look at the sentences before and after the unknown word for a definition, example, or contrast that explains it	"This process, called verification, helps remove mistakes and false claims" — the word <i>called</i> signals that a definition follows
Word structure: prefixes	A prefix added to the front of a word can change or add to its meaning (e.g., <i>un-</i> = not, <i>re-</i> = again)	<i>unreliable</i> = <i>un-</i> (not) + <i>reliable</i> → not able to be trusted
Word structure: roots	Many English words share Latin or Greek roots; recognizing a root can help unlock meaning across many related words	<i>credible</i> comes from the root <i>cred</i> (to believe), also seen in <i>credit</i> and <i>credentials</i>
Word structure: suffixes	A suffix added to the end of a word often changes its part of speech (e.g., <i>-tion</i> often makes a noun, <i>-able</i> often makes an adjective)	<i>verify</i> (verb) + <i>-tion</i> → <i>verification</i> (noun)

Practice: Find the word *reliable* in the reading. The root *rely* means "to depend on or trust." Using the root and the suffix *-able* (meaning "able to be"), what do you think *reliable* means? (Answer: *able to be trusted or depended on.*)

Grammar Lesson

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Active voice (simple present)	Subject + base verb (+s/-es for third person singular) + object	Use when you want to emphasize <i>who</i> or <i>what</i> performs the action	none required; look for a clear doer of the action	"Millions of people use this app."
Passive voice (simple present)	Subject (receiver of action) + am/is/are + past participle (+ by + agent, optional)	Use when the action or the receiver of the action is more important than who does it, or when the doer is unknown/unimportant	am, is, are + past participle; often "by ____" if the doer is mentioned	"This app is used by millions of people."

Understanding Active Voice in the Simple Present

In active voice, the subject of the sentence performs the action. This is the most common sentence pattern in English and is used for everyday facts, habits, and general truths.

Form: Subject + verb (add -s/-es if the subject is he/she/it or a singular noun) + object

Examples:

- "The app **updates** the vocabulary list every week." (subject = the app; it performs the action)
- "Teachers **use** multimedia to make lessons more engaging." (subject = teachers)
- "My browser **saves** my passwords automatically." (subject = my browser)

Notice that the subject of an active sentence is always the one doing the action.

Understanding Passive Voice in the Simple Present

In passive voice, the subject of the sentence receives the action, rather than performing it. Passive voice is common in technology, science, and news writing because the writer often wants to focus on the process or result, not on who is doing it.

Form: Subject (receiver) + am/is/are + past participle (+ by + agent, if needed)

Examples:

- "The website **is updated** daily." (the focus is on the website, not on who updates it)
- "New videos **are uploaded** every Monday." (the focus is on the videos)
- "This app **is developed** by a team of teachers." (the doer, *a team of teachers*, is added with "by" because it is useful information)

Choosing between "is" and "are": Use *is* with singular subjects (the app, the website, the video) and *are* with plural subjects (the apps, the websites, the videos).

Forming the past participle: Most verbs add -ed (update → updated, verify → verified, download → downloaded). Some verbs are irregular (write → written, make → made). If the base verb ends in a consonant + -e, just add -d (verify → verified is actually -y to -ied; update → updated keeps the -e + -d).

Common Errors to Avoid

- **Missing "be" verb:** Incorrect: "The app updated every week." Correct (passive): "The app **is** updated every week."
- **Wrong participle form:** Incorrect: "The file is download." Correct: "The file **is downloaded**."
- **Subject-verb agreement in passive:** Incorrect: "The videos is uploaded weekly." Correct: "The videos **are** uploaded weekly."
- **Overusing passive voice:** Passive voice is useful, but active voice is often clearer and more direct. Use passive voice purposefully — when the action or the receiver matters more than who performs it — not in every sentence.

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Identify Active or Passive Label each sentence Active (A) or Passive (P).

1. This browser blocks pop-up ads automatically. _____
2. New lessons are uploaded to Canvas every Monday. _____
3. Millions of students use this learning app. _____
4. The website is managed by a university. _____
5. Teachers verify the sources before sharing an article. _____
6. This platform is trusted by many businesses. _____
7. The app collects very little personal data. _____
8. Old files are deleted automatically after 30 days. _____

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank — Active or Passive Complete each sentence with the correct form of the verb in parentheses. Decide if the sentence should be active or passive based on the meaning.

1. This app _____ (update) new content every week. (active)
2. The website _____ (design) by a team of engineers. (passive)
3. Many students _____ (use) this platform for homework help. (active)
4. Personal information _____ (protect) by strong passwords. (passive)
5. The teacher _____ (verify) every source before class. (active)
6. New videos _____ (post) on this channel every Friday. (passive)
7. This browser _____ (block) unsafe websites automatically. (active)
8. The app's reviews _____ (write) by real users. (passive)

Activity 3: Sentence Writing Write your own sentences using the word or topic given. Use active voice for items 1–3 and passive voice for items 4–6.

1. (active) a search engine
2. (active) a social media app
3. (active) students / technology
4. (passive) a website
5. (passive) an app
6. (passive) online videos

Writing Assignment

Informational Paragraph: Evaluating a Digital Resource

For this module's writing assignment, students will write a short informational paragraph evaluating a digital resource — a website, app, or video — for credibility and usefulness. This paragraph type follows the COR-aligned structure used across ESL 304: a clear topic sentence, supporting facts and details, and a conclusion. Students will explain what the resource is, evaluate whether it is credible, and give a final opinion about whether it is useful.

Parts of an Informational Paragraph

Part	Purpose	Example from This Assignment
Topic sentence	Introduces the digital resource and states the main idea (e.g., is it credible/useful?)	"Duolingo is a helpful and credible app for learning English vocabulary."

Part	Purpose	Example from This Assignment
Supporting fact/detail 1	Gives specific evidence about the resource (who made it, when updated, etc.)	"The app is developed by a well-known education company and is updated frequently."
Supporting fact/detail 2	Gives another piece of evidence (features, reviews, sources)	"It includes multimedia such as audio, images, and short videos to help learners practice listening."
Supporting fact/detail 3	Gives a third piece of evidence (accuracy, evaluation criteria, comparison)	"The content is checked by language teachers, so the grammar and vocabulary are accurate."
Conclusion	Restates the main idea and gives a final opinion or recommendation	"For these reasons, Duolingo is a credible and useful tool for English learners."

Topic Choices

Option	Topic
1	Evaluate a website you use for news, health information, or research
2	Evaluate an app you use for learning English or another skill
3	Evaluate an educational video or video channel (e.g., a tutorial or lesson video)
4	Evaluate a social media platform for its usefulness and credibility as an information source
5	Student choice: propose your own digital resource to evaluate (instructor approval required)

Assignment Requirements

- Length: one well-developed paragraph, approximately 8–12 sentences
- Format: one clear topic sentence, at least three supporting facts/details, and one concluding sentence
- Grammar focus: use at least **three examples of active voice** and **two examples of passive voice** (simple present) correctly
- Vocabulary: use at least **four** of the module's vocabulary words (credible, source, browser, download, upload, multimedia, verify, digital footprint, app, platform)
- Use at least two transition words/phrases to connect ideas
- Include one visual or multimedia reference (e.g., describe a screenshot, chart, or short video clip you would attach to support your evaluation) — this may be an actual attached image/screenshot or a written description, depending on submission option

Transition Words for Informational Writing

Transition Word/Phrase	Use
First, / To begin,	Introduces the first supporting detail
In addition, / Also,	Adds another supporting detail
For example,	Introduces a specific example
However,	Shows a contrast or limitation
Overall, / In conclusion,	Introduces the concluding sentence

Model Text

Evaluating a Website: MedlinePlus

MedlinePlus is a credible and useful website for anyone who wants reliable health information. First, the site is managed by the U.S. National Library of Medicine, a trusted government source, so the web address ends in .gov. In addition, the information is verified by medical professionals and is updated regularly, which means readers can trust that the facts are current. The website also includes multimedia, such as short videos and clear diagrams, that are used to explain medical topics in simple language. For example, a search about diabetes returns an article, a video, and a list of related credible sources, all in one place. However, the website is written mostly in formal English, so some new learners may need extra time to understand certain words. Overall, MedlinePlus is a strong example of a credible digital resource because it is produced by experts, updated often, and supported by multimedia.

The Writing Process

Students will move through five steps to complete this assignment: **Prewrite** → **Draft** → **Revise** → **Edit** → **Publish**.

Prewriting Graphic Organizer

Question	Your Notes
What is the digital resource? (name, type: website/app/video)	
Who created or manages it?	
Is it updated regularly? How do you know?	
What features make it useful (multimedia, reviews, sources)?	
What is your overall opinion/conclusion?	
Which visual/multimedia element will you describe or attach?	

Revision Checklist

Check	Yes/No
Does my paragraph have a clear topic sentence?	
Do I include at least three supporting facts/details?	
Do I have a clear concluding sentence?	
Did I use at least three active voice sentences (simple present)?	
Did I use at least two passive voice sentences (simple present)?	
Did I use at least four vocabulary words from this module?	
Did I use at least two transition words/phrases?	
Did I describe or attach one visual/multimedia element?	

Grading Rubric (20 points)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Content and Development	Clear topic sentence; 3+ specific, relevant supporting details; strong conclusion	Clear topic sentence; adequate supporting details; conclusion present	Topic sentence unclear or details limited/vague	Missing topic sentence and/or very few details
Grammar Focus (Active/Passive Voice)	Uses 3+ active and 2+ passive voice sentences correctly	Uses required active/passive sentences with minor errors	Uses some active/passive forms but with frequent errors	Active/passive voice missing or mostly incorrect

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Vocabulary Use	Uses 4+ module vocabulary words accurately and naturally	Uses 3 vocabulary words accurately	Uses 1–2 vocabulary words, or used inaccurately	No module vocabulary used
Organization and Transitions	Logical order; 2+ transition words used effectively	Logical order; at least 1 transition word used	Some organization issues; few/no transitions	Disorganized; no transitions

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 (Typed):** Type the paragraph in Canvas (text entry or Word/Google Doc upload) or submit a typed page in class. Best for students comfortable with typing and digital tools.
- **Option 2 (Handwritten + Photo):** Write the paragraph by hand and take a clear photo to upload to Canvas or hand in printed in person. Best for students who are still building digital/typing skills.
- **Option 3 (Audio Recording):** Record yourself reading your paragraph aloud and submit the audio file (Canvas audio upload) or play it for the instructor in person/on Zoom. Supports students focusing on oral fluency and pronunciation alongside writing.

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

Topic: A Useful App or Website for Learning English

Part 1: Choose one app or website that you personally use (or have used) to help you learn English. Describe what it is and how you use it.

Part 2: Explain why this app or website is credible and helpful. Use at least one reason connected to what you learned in this module (who created it, how often it is updated, whether it includes multimedia, etc.).

Part 3: Compare your app or website to one that a classmate shared. Which one seems more useful for a beginner, and why?

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	Answers Parts 1 and 2 in at least 5–6 sentences	10
Reply 1	Responds to a classmate's post; includes a comparison (Part 3) and a follow-up question	5
Reply 2	Responds to a second classmate's post with a genuine comment or question	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Introducing your app/website	"The app/website I use is called _____."
Describing how you use it	"I use it to _____."
Giving a reason it is credible	"It is credible because _____."
Giving a reason it is helpful	"It is helpful because it _____."
Comparing two tools	"Compared to _____, my app/website is _____."

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Asking a follow-up question	"Have you ever tried _____? What did you think?"

Functional/Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrases
Stating an opinion	"In my opinion, ...", "I believe that ...", "I think ..."
Supporting with a reason	"This is because ...", "One reason is ...", "For example, ..."
Recommending	"I would recommend ... because ...", "You should try ... since ..."
Comparing	"Unlike ..., this app ...", "Similar to ..., this website ...", "Both ... and ... are useful, but ..."
Agreeing	"I agree with you because ...", "That's a good point — I also think ..."
Disagreeing (politely)	"I see your point, but I think ...", "I had a different experience with ..."

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person students will discuss the prompt orally in pairs or small groups, taking turns describing their chosen app or website and comparing it with a partner's choice, then briefly reporting one comparison back to the whole class. **Zoom** students will be placed in breakout rooms to have the same spoken conversation, and may use a shared Google Doc or the Zoom chat to jot down the name of their app/website and one reason it is credible before reporting back in the main session. **Canvas LMS** students will complete this as a traditional asynchronous discussion board: posting their original response, then replying to at least two classmates' posts within the module deadline, using the sentence frames and functional language above to structure their comparisons.

Discussion Grading Rubric (20 points total, converted to 4-level scale)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Completeness	Fully addresses all 3 parts of the prompt in original post	Addresses most parts of the prompt	Addresses only 1 part of the prompt	Does not address the prompt
Use of Reasoning/Justification	Clear, specific reasons given for credibility and usefulness	Reasons given but somewhat general	Little or vague reasoning given	No reasoning given
Engagement with Classmates	Both replies are thoughtful, specific, and include a comparison or question	Replies are relevant but general	Only one reply given, or replies are minimal	No replies given
Language Use	Uses functional/persuasive language and vocabulary from the module accurately	Uses some functional language and vocabulary	Limited use of functional language/vocabulary	Little to no use of module language

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is for practice only and is not graded. Use it to check your own understanding before the module assessment.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word (1–10) with its definition (a–j).

1. credible
2. source
3. browser
4. download
5. upload
6. multimedia
7. verify
8. digital footprint
9. app
10. platform

a. to check that something is true or correct b. a program used to look at websites c. believable and trustworthy d. a combination of text, images, video, and audio e. a program designed for a phone or computer for a specific task f. to copy a file from the internet onto a device g. a person, book, or website that gives information h. a website or system where content or services are provided i. to send a file from your device to the internet j. the trail of information a person leaves online

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the correct word to complete each sentence.

1. Before sharing an article, I always try to (verify / download) the information.
2. This news (platform / browser) publishes stories from reporters all over the world.
3. My phone has very little storage, so I can't (upload / download) any more apps.
4. A (credible / digital) source usually names its author and is updated often.
5. The teacher used (multimedia / source) — video, images, and sound — during the lesson.
6. Everything you post online becomes part of your (browser / digital footprint).
7. I opened my (app / browser) to search for a recipe.
8. She used a language-learning (source / app) to study new vocabulary every day.

Section 3: Grammar Identification/Application

Label each sentence Active (A) or Passive (P), then for items 7–12, fill in the blank with the correct active or passive form.

1. Students download the app for free. _____
2. The video is produced by a science museum. _____
3. This website updates its articles daily. _____
4. New features are added every month. _____
5. Teachers recommend this platform for beginners. _____
6. The reviews are written by real customers. _____
7. This app _____ (translate) ten languages. (active)
8. The website _____ (manage) by a university. (passive)
9. Millions of people _____ (use) this search engine. (active)
10. New lessons _____ (post) every Monday. (passive)
11. This browser _____ (block) unsafe pop-ups. (active)

12. The app's data _____ (protect) with encryption. (passive)

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the error in each sentence.

1. The website is update every day.
2. This app develop by a team of teachers.
3. New videos is uploaded every week.
4. Millions of people uses this platform.
5. The file is downloaded, but it not verified yet.
6. This browser block unsafe websites.
7. The reviews is written by real users.
8. Students download the app it is free.

Section 5: Short Writing Check

Prompt: In 3–4 sentences, describe one app or website you trust. Use at least one active voice sentence and one passive voice sentence (simple present), and include at least two vocabulary words from this module.

Self-Evaluation Checklist

Check	Yes/No
I used at least one active voice sentence (simple present)	
I used at least one passive voice sentence (simple present)	
I used at least two vocabulary words from this module	
My sentences are complete and make sense	
I checked my spelling and capitalization	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Quiz me on these 10 technology vocabulary words: credible, source, browser, download, upload, multimedia, verify, digital footprint, app, platform. Give me a sentence with a blank and let me guess the word."	Interactive vocabulary quiz with immediate feedback
Grammar	"Give me 5 sentences about technology in simple present tense. Ask me to change each one from active to passive voice or passive to active."	Extra grammar practice with correction and explanation
Writing Feedback	"Here is my paragraph evaluating a website for credibility. Can you check if I used active and passive voice correctly and if my paragraph has a clear topic sentence, details, and conclusion?"	Personalized feedback on grammar, structure, and content

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Discussion Practice	"I want to practice talking about an app I use for learning English. Ask me questions like a classmate would, and help me practice giving reasons using phrases like 'This is because...'"	Conversational practice with functional language modeling

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining Combine each pair of sentences into one sentence using active or passive voice as indicated.

- (active) Students use this app. / The app teaches vocabulary. → Combine into one active sentence.
- (passive) A team creates this website. / The website is for teachers. → Combine into one passive sentence.
- (active) People trust this source. / The source checks its facts. → Combine into one active sentence.

Activity 2: Word Forms (Vocabulary + Grammar Connection) Complete the chart with the correct word form.

Verb	Noun	Adjective
verify	_____	_____
_____	credibility	credible
download	_____ (n/a — same word functions as noun)	_____ (downloadable)

Verb	Noun	Adjective
verify	verification	verified/verifiable
credit (related root)	credibility	credible
download	download	downloadable

Activity 3: Active/Passive Transformation Rewrite each active sentence in passive voice (simple present).

- Many people use this platform.
- Teachers recommend this app.
- Experts verify the information.
- The company updates the software.

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Free drop-in and appointment-based tutoring is available for ESL students needing extra help with reading, writing, grammar, or vocabulary. Tutors can help review technology vocabulary and give feedback on writing drafts.
- **Writing Center:** Offers one-on-one support for planning, drafting, and revising written assignments, including help with organizing an informational paragraph and using active/passive voice correctly.
- **Library:** Provides access to computers, research databases, and librarian assistance for evaluating credible sources — directly useful for this module's focus on digital literacy.
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and support services for students with documented disabilities, including alternative formats, extended time, and assistive technology for coursework.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary: Reading and Vocabulary

Skill	What Students Learned
Reading	How to identify main ideas and details in a text about evaluating digital resources for credibility
Vocabulary	10 technology/digital literacy words: credible, source, browser, download, upload, multimedia, verify, digital footprint, app, platform
Reading Strategy	Using context clues and word structure (prefixes, suffixes, roots) to determine the meaning of unfamiliar technology vocabulary

Summary: Grammar

Skill	What Students Learned
Active voice (simple present)	How to form and use active voice to emphasize who performs an action
Passive voice (simple present)	How to form and use passive voice (am/is/are + past participle) to emphasize the action or receiver of the action
Error correction	Common mistakes with subject-verb agreement and missing "be" verbs in passive voice

Summary: Writing and Communication

Skill	What Students Learned
Writing	How to write an informational paragraph evaluating a digital resource, using facts, details, and a conclusion
Speaking/Listening	How to recommend, justify, and compare digital tools using functional and persuasive language
Digital Literacy	How to evaluate websites, apps, and videos for credibility and how to incorporate multimedia into a report or presentation

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
Purdue OWL: Evaluating Sources	Guidance on evaluating the credibility of print and digital sources	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_...ion/index.html
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Definitions, pronunciations, and example sentences for technology vocabulary	https://learnersdictionary.com/
VOA Learning English	News articles and audio at an accessible level, including technology topics	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/
BBC Learning English	Grammar explanations and listening practice, including active/passive voice lessons	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish
USA.gov: Online Safety	Government guidance on evaluating websites and protecting personal information online	https://www.usa.gov/online-safety

Looking Ahead

This Module Connects To	How
Module 8: Personal Narrative and Autobiography	Students will use transitional words and paragraph structure (topic sentence, details, conclusion) built in this module to write longer personal narratives
Academic and workplace research tasks	Evaluating credible sources prepares students for research-based writing and workplace tasks that require verifying information
Oral presentations	Incorporating multimedia into a written report connects directly to preparing multimedia-supported oral presentations in future coursework

Reflection Questions

1. What is one strategy you learned in this module for deciding if a website, app, or video is credible?
2. Which was more challenging for you: using active voice or passive voice in the simple present? Why?
3. How did using context clues and word structure help you understand new technology vocabulary?
4. What is one thing you learned about your own digital footprint from this module?
5. How might you use the skill of evaluating digital resources outside of this class — for example, at work, at home, or in future studies?

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 7: Technology and Digital Literacy | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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8: Personal Narrative and Autobiography

Module 8: Personal Narrative and Autobiography

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

Module Overview

Every student in this class has a story worth telling. Maybe it is the day you arrived in the United States, the moment you learned to ride a bicycle, the birth of a child, or a family tradition passed down from your grandparents. In Module 8, we turn to one of the most powerful things we can do in any language: tell our own story clearly, in order, and with feeling. Personal narrative writing is not just an academic exercise — it is a skill you will use for the rest of your life, whether you are writing a college application essay, telling a new coworker about your background, sharing a memory with your children in English, or simply connecting with a neighbor. This module gives you the grammar tools (compound and complex sentences, time adverbs, and conjunctions) and the vocabulary you need to turn your memories into a well-organized paragraph that other people can follow and enjoy.

In this module, students will:

- Read and discuss an original narrative passage about a meaningful life journey
- Learn and practice 10 vocabulary words related to personal narrative and life stories
- Master compound and complex sentences with adverbial clauses, adverbs of time, and coordinating/subordinating conjunctions — with correct subject-verb agreement
- Learn to use idiomatic phrasal verbs and collocations naturally when telling a personal story
- Learn the basics of paraphrasing and avoiding plagiarism (a mini-lesson, since this writing task does not require outside sources)
- Write a well-organized autobiography paragraph (topic sentence + three supporting details + conclusion) about a meaningful personal experience
- Share a personal story or family tradition with classmates and practice active listening through follow-up questions

Module Learning Outcomes

Skill Area	What Students Will Be Able to Do
Reading	Identify the sequence of events, main idea, and supporting details in a personal narrative text; recognize the writer's purpose and tone
Vocabulary	Use 10 personal-narrative/life-story words accurately in speech and writing (e.g., <i>memorable</i> , <i>milestone</i> , <i>overcome</i> , <i>reflect</i>)
Grammar	Write grammatically correct compound and complex sentences using adverbial clauses, adverbs of time, and coordinating/subordinating conjunctions, with correct subject-verb agreement
Writing	Draft, revise, and publish a well-developed autobiography paragraph (topic sentence + 3 supporting details + conclusion) about a meaningful personal experience
Speaking and Listening	Share a personal experience or family tradition aloud or in writing; ask genuine follow-up questions and respond actively to classmates' stories

Module Two-Week Schedule

Week	Days	Task	Due

Week	Days	Task	Due
1	Day 1–2	Module launch: vocabulary introduction, "Finding Home in a New Place" reading, comprehension check	Vocabulary practice + comprehension questions
1	Day 3	Grammar Lesson: compound and complex sentences, adverbial clauses, subject-verb agreement	Grammar Practice Activity 1
1	Day 4	Grammar continued: adverbs of time and conjunctions; idiomatic language mini-lesson (phrasal verbs/collocations)	Grammar Practice Activities 2–3
1	Day 5 (In-person: pair interview activity in class, students ask each other about a memorable milestone; Zoom: breakout rooms of 2–3 for the same interview, then report back in main session; Canvas: asynchronous discussion board post sharing a memorable milestone, plus two replies to classmates)	Discussion Board Original Post	End of Day 5
2	Day 6–7	Writing Assignment: prewriting graphic organizer, topic selection, first draft of autobiography paragraph; mini-lesson on paraphrasing/avoiding plagiarism	Prewriting organizer + first draft
2	Day 8	Peer review/self-editing using revision checklist (In-person: partner exchange papers in class; Zoom: partner review via shared Google Doc during breakout session; Canvas: upload draft to peer-review discussion thread)	Peer feedback completed
2	Day 9	Final revision and publishing; Discussion Board Replies due	Final autobiography paragraph submitted (choice of typed, handwritten+photo, or audio)
2	Day 10	Self-Check Quiz (ungraded) and Module wrap-up/reflection	Self-Check Quiz completed; Reflection Questions

Grammar Preview

Structure	When to Use It	Example

Structure	When to Use It	Example
Compound sentence (coordinating conjunction)	To join two complete, related ideas of equal importance	I finished high school in my country, and then I moved to California.
Complex sentence (subordinating conjunction/adverbial clause)	To show a time, reason, contrast, or condition relationship between two ideas	Although I was nervous, I decided to enroll in college classes.
Adverbs of time	To show the order of events in a story	I studied English for two years. Eventually , I felt confident speaking with my coworkers.
Subject-verb agreement in clauses	To make sure the verb matches its subject in every clause of a compound/complex sentence	When my daughter starts school, she practices her English every night.

Delivery Mode Note

This module is designed to work seamlessly across all three delivery formats used at Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education. **In-person** students will do most vocabulary, grammar, and discussion work through pair and small-group talk, with printed worksheets available for those who prefer paper. **Zoom** students will use breakout rooms for the same pair/group activities, shared Google Docs for collaborative editing, and the chat feature for quick vocabulary and grammar checks. **Canvas LMS** students will complete the equivalent work asynchronously: the discussion board replaces in-class conversation, self-check quizzes and AI tutor prompts replace real-time practice, and the writing assignment can be submitted as typed text, a handwritten page photographed and uploaded, or a short audio recording — so that every student, regardless of typing speed or comfort with technology, can fully participate.

Reading and Vocabulary

Module Vocabulary: 10 Key Words

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
memorable	adjective	worth remembering; making a strong impression	Our first Thanksgiving in the United States was a memorable day for our whole family.
childhood	noun	the period of time when a person is a child	My childhood was full of noise, cousins, and my grandmother's cooking.
milestone	noun	an important event or stage in a person's life	Getting my driver's license last year was a big milestone for me.
journey	noun	a long process of personal change and growth; also, a physical trip	Learning English has been a long journey, but I am proud of how far I have come.
overcome	verb	to successfully deal with or defeat a problem or difficulty	She had to overcome her fear of speaking in front of the class.
reflect	verb	to think carefully about something, especially the past	When I reflect on my first year here, I realize how much I have grown.
achievement	noun	something successfully accomplished, especially through effort	Passing the citizenship test was one of my proudest achievements.

Word	Part of Speech	Definition	Example Sentence
tradition	noun	a custom or belief passed down within a family or culture	Making tamales together every December is a tradition in my family.
adapt	verb	to adjust to new conditions or a new environment	It took time to adapt to the different pace of life in a new country.
grateful	adjective	feeling or showing thanks and appreciation	I am grateful for the teachers who encouraged me when I doubted myself.

Original Reading: "Finding Home in a New Place"

A Difficult Decision

Rosa Delgado still remembers the night before she left her hometown in Michoacán. She sat on the edge of her bed, looking at the small suitcase her mother had packed, and she wondered if she was making the right choice. Rosa was twenty-two years old, and she had just finished a degree in accounting. It was not an easy decision to leave everything familiar behind, but she believed that a better future waited for her family in the United States. After she said goodbye to her parents and her younger brother, she boarded a bus before sunrise, and her journey began.

The First Difficult Months

When Rosa arrived in Santa Ana, she moved in with her aunt, who had immigrated ten years earlier. At first, everything felt strange. She did not understand fast conversations at the grocery store, and she felt embarrassed when she had to ask people to repeat themselves. Because she wanted to work as soon as possible, she took a job at a bakery, even though the pay was low and the hours were long. Eventually, she saved enough money to enroll in ESL classes at a local continuing education campus. Although the classes were only two evenings a week, they became the highlight of her schedule. She adapted slowly: she started watching English-language shows with subtitles, she wrote new words in a small notebook, and she practiced speaking with her coworkers whenever she had the chance.

A Turning Point

One evening, after class, Rosa's teacher asked the students to write a short paragraph about a memorable childhood tradition. Rosa wrote about the Día de los Muertos altar her family built every November, and when she read her paragraph aloud, several classmates said they had similar traditions in their own countries. For the first time since she had arrived, Rosa felt like she belonged somewhere. She realized that sharing her story connected her to people who had once been strangers. Because that assignment gave her so much confidence, she decided to keep a journal in English, writing a few sentences every night before she went to sleep.

Milestones and Growth

Over the next three years, Rosa reached several milestones. She earned a certificate in bookkeeping, she moved into her own apartment, and she became a volunteer translator at her daughter's elementary school. Whenever she faced a new challenge, she reminded herself of the courage it had taken to leave home in the first place. She often told her English classmates, "If I could overcome that first lonely year, I can overcome almost anything." Her English improved steadily, not because it happened quickly, but because she kept showing up, kept practicing, and kept believing her story was worth telling.

Looking Back

Today, when Rosa reflects on her journey, she feels grateful rather than regretful. She misses her parents and her hometown, and she still calls her mother every Sunday. At the same time, she has built a meaningful life in Santa Ana: she has a job she enjoys, a strong community of friends from her ESL classes, and a daughter who is growing up bilingual. Rosa says that the biggest lesson from her journey is simple: every immigrant carries a story of courage, and telling that story — even imperfectly, even in a second language — is itself an achievement. She now encourages every new student she meets to write down their own story before the details start to fade, because, as she often says, "Your journey matters, and so does your voice."

(approximately 520 words)

Vocabulary Practice: Fill in the Blank

Word bank: memorable, childhood, milestone, journey, overcome, reflect, achievement, tradition, adapt, grateful

1. Learning a new language as an adult is a long _____ that takes patience and practice.
2. Every year, my family cooks a big meal together — it has become a _____ we all look forward to.
3. Graduating from high school was an important _____ in my life.
4. It can be hard to _____ to a new culture, especially in the first few months.
5. When I _____ on my life, I see how much I have changed since I arrived here.
6. My _____ was spent in a small village near the coast.
7. Winning the scholarship was a huge _____ for my whole family.
8. Our trip to the Grand Canyon last summer was truly _____ — I will never forget it.
9. It took courage to _____ my fear of public speaking, but I did it.
10. I am very _____ for the support my teachers have given me this year.

Comprehension Check Questions

Part A: Main Idea and Details

1. Why did Rosa decide to leave her hometown in Michoacán?
2. What were two challenges Rosa faced during her first months in Santa Ana?
3. What happened after Rosa wrote a paragraph about her family's Día de los Muertos tradition?
4. Name two milestones Rosa reached over the following three years.
5. According to the reading, what does Rosa believe is "itself an achievement"?

Part B: Think and Connect

1. Rosa says that sharing her story helped her feel like she belonged. Have you ever had an experience where sharing something personal helped you connect with someone else? What happened?
2. Rosa kept a journal in English to build her confidence. What strategies have you used (or could you use) to practice English outside of class?

Reading Strategy: Sequencing Events in a Narrative

Personal narratives are organized around a timeline — the order in which events happened. Good readers pay attention to time-order signal words to follow the sequence of a story, and good writers use the same words to help their readers follow along.

Strategy Step	Explanation	Example from the Reading
Look for time-order signal words	Words like <i>before</i> , <i>after</i> , <i>then</i> , <i>eventually</i> , <i>at first</i> , <i>over the next three years</i> show when something happened in relation to other events	" Eventually , she saved enough money to enroll in ESL classes."
Identify the turning point	Most personal narratives have one moment that changes the direction of the story	"One evening, after class, Rosa's teacher asked the students to write..." marks the turning point of the story
Track cause and effect across time	Ask: what happened as a <i>result</i> of an earlier event?	"Because that assignment gave her so much confidence, she decided to keep a journal in English."

Grammar Lesson

This module's grammar focus builds the exact tools you need to tell a clear, connected story: compound and complex sentences, adverbial clauses, adverbs of time, and conjunctions — always with correct subject-verb agreement.

Grammar Overview

Structure	Form	When to Use It	Signal Words	Example
Compound sentence	Independent clause + comma + coordinating conjunction + independent clause	To connect two complete, equally important ideas	and, but, or, nor, for, so, yet	I finished my shift, so I went straight home.
Complex sentence with adverbial clause (clause first)	Subordinating conjunction + dependent clause + comma + independent clause	To show time, reason, contrast, or condition, with emphasis on the dependent idea	when, after, before, because, although, if, since	Before I moved here , I lived with my grandparents.
Complex sentence with adverbial clause (clause second)	Independent clause + subordinating conjunction + dependent clause (no comma)	Same relationships, with emphasis on the main idea	when, after, before, because, although, if, since	I lived with my grandparents before I moved here .
Adverbs of time	Single-word or short adverbial expressions, often at the start or end of a sentence	To show the order of events in a narrative	before, after, then, eventually, finally, meanwhile, first, later, at last	Then , I enrolled in my first ESL class.
Coordinating conjunctions	Join two independent clauses or two equal words/phrases	To add, contrast, or show a result between equal ideas	and, but, or, nor, for, so, yet (FANBOYS)	I was scared, yet I kept going.
Subordinating conjunctions	Introduce a dependent (adverbial) clause	To show time, cause, condition, or contrast	because, although, since, if, when, while, after, before	Although it was difficult, she never gave up.
Subject-verb agreement in clauses	The verb must match the subject in number/person in every clause	Applies inside both independent and dependent clauses of compound/complex sentences	—	When my parents arrive , they always bring food from home.

Compound Sentences

A compound sentence joins **two independent clauses** — two complete sentences that could each stand alone — using a comma plus a coordinating conjunction. The seven coordinating conjunctions are easy to remember with the acronym **FANBOYS**: For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So.

- I was homesick at first, **but** I slowly made new friends.
- She wanted to celebrate the milestone, **so** she invited her whole family.

Common error: Forgetting the comma before the conjunction, or using a comma without any conjunction (a "comma splice").
Incorrect: "I was tired, I kept studying." *Correct:* "I was tired, **but** I kept studying."

Complex Sentences with Adverbial Clauses

A complex sentence has **one independent clause** and **at least one dependent (adverbial) clause**. The adverbial clause begins with a subordinating conjunction and cannot stand alone as a complete sentence.

- **If the clause comes first**, use a comma after it: **When I arrived in this country**, I did not speak any English.

- **If the clause comes second**, do NOT use a comma: I did not speak any English **when I arrived in this country**.

Common subordinating conjunctions for personal narrative: *because* (reason), *although/even though* (contrast), *if* (condition), *when/while/after/before/since* (time).

Common error: Using a comma when the adverbial clause comes second. *Incorrect:* "I felt proud, after I finished the race."
Correct: "I felt proud after I finished the race."

Adverbs of Time

Adverbs of time show *when* something happened or the *order* of events — essential for telling a clear story.

- **Sequence markers:** first, next, then, after that, later, eventually, finally, at last
- **Simultaneous markers:** meanwhile, at the same time, while
- **Starting-point markers:** at first, in the beginning

Example paragraph excerpt: "**At first**, I felt lost in my new school. **Then**, a classmate invited me to sit with her at lunch. **Eventually**, I felt like I belonged."

Subject-Verb Agreement in Compound and Complex Sentences

Every clause has its own subject and verb, and they must agree — even when the sentence has more than one clause.

- Singular subject → singular verb: **My grandmother tells** stories about her childhood every Sunday.
- Plural subject → plural verb: **My grandparents tell** stories about their childhood every Sunday.
- In a compound sentence, check **each** clause separately: My brother **studies** engineering, and my sister **works** as a nurse. (Both verbs must correctly match their own subjects — do not let the first verb influence the second.)
- In a complex sentence, the verb in the dependent clause must also agree with its own subject: **Although my parents speak** Spanish at home, **they understand** English very well.

Common error: Matching the verb to the wrong noun. *Incorrect:* "My sister, along with her friends, are coming to the party."
Correct: "My sister, along with her friends, **is** coming to the party." (The verb agrees with the main subject "sister," not "friends.")

Grammar Practice Activities

Activity 1: Multiple Choice — Coordinating or Subordinating?

Choose the conjunction that correctly completes each sentence.

1. I was nervous, _____ I decided to try anyway. (a) although (b) but (c) because
2. _____ I finished my classes, I started looking for a better job. (a) After (b) So (c) Yet
3. She kept a journal every night, _____ she wanted to remember every detail. (a) because (b) or (c) but
4. _____ it was raining, we still went to the celebration. (a) So (b) Although (c) And
5. I called my mother, _____ she told me all the family news. (a) and (b) since (c) if

Activity 2: Fill in the Blank — Adverbs of Time and Subject-Verb Agreement

Complete each sentence with an appropriate adverb of time from the box, and make sure the verb agrees with the subject.

Box: *first, then, eventually, meanwhile, finally*

1. _____, I (feel/feels) shy about speaking English in public.
2. My classmates (practice/practices) every day; _____, they (become/becomes) more confident.
3. _____, I (write/writes) my ideas on a piece of paper before I speak.
4. _____, our whole class (celebrate/celebrates) when everyone passes the final exam.
5. _____ my sister studies, I (help/helps) my younger brother with his homework.

Activity 3: Sentence Writing — Combine the Ideas

Combine each pair of simple sentences into one compound OR complex sentence using an appropriate conjunction. Watch your subject-verb agreement and comma placement.

1. My family moved to a new city. We had to adapt to a new school system.
2. I was scared to speak in class. I raised my hand anyway.
3. My grandmother tells stories about her village. My cousins love listening to her.
4. I finished my ESL class. I felt proud of my progress.
5. We did not have much money. Our family always found ways to celebrate holidays together.

Mini-Lesson: Idiomatic Language — Phrasal Verbs and Collocations in Storytelling

Native speakers use phrasal verbs (a verb + preposition/particle with a special meaning) and collocations (words that naturally go together) constantly when telling personal stories. Using them will make your narrative sound more natural.

Phrasal Verb / Collocation	Meaning	Example in a Story
grow up	to become an adult; to spend childhood somewhere	I grew up in a small town near Guadalajara.
look back on	to remember and think about the past	When I look back on that year, I feel proud.
deal with	to handle a problem or difficult situation	I had to deal with a lot of change at once.
turn out	to happen in a particular way, especially unexpectedly	The move turned out to be the best decision for our family.
make a decision / make progress	(collocations) to decide / to improve gradually	I made a decision to keep studying English no matter what.
face a challenge / overcome an obstacle	(collocations) to confront a difficulty / to succeed despite a difficulty	She faced many challenges but overcame every obstacle.
settle down	to begin living a stable, calm life in one place	It took two years before we finally settled down.
hold on to	to keep, especially a memory, value, or tradition	We still hold on to our family's holiday traditions.

Quick Practice: Choose two phrasal verbs or collocations from the table and use each in an original sentence about your own life. (No answer key — open personal response; check with a partner or your instructor.)

Mini-Lesson: Paraphrasing and Avoiding Plagiarism (Bibliography Basics)

This module's writing assignment is a personal narrative, so you will not need outside sources — your own memory and experience are the source. However, in future college and workplace writing, you will often need to reference other people's words or ideas, so it is important to understand the basics now.

- **Paraphrasing** means restating someone else's idea in your own words, without copying their exact sentence structure or vocabulary.
- **Plagiarism** means using someone else's words or ideas without giving them credit — even accidentally. This is considered academic dishonesty in college courses.
- **A bibliography** (or "Works Cited" / "References" list) is a list at the end of a paper that gives credit to every outside source you used, usually including the author's name, title, publication, and date.

Quick example:

- *Original source sentence:* "Many immigrants report that learning a new language builds both confidence and community."
- *Weak paraphrase (too close — this is plagiarism):* "Many immigrants say that learning a new language builds confidence and community."

• *Strong paraphrase (your own words + credit given)*: According to researchers, immigrants who learn a new language often gain not only practical skills but also a stronger sense of belonging (Author, Year).

Rule of thumb: If you use three or more words in a row exactly as they appear in the original source, put them in quotation marks and cite the source. When in doubt, rewrite the idea completely in your own words and always name where the idea came from.

Writing Assignment

The Autobiography Paragraph

In this module, you will write an **autobiography paragraph**: a well-developed paragraph with a topic sentence, three supporting details, and a conclusion, describing one meaningful personal experience from your life. This is the exact paragraph type described in our course's learning outcomes — a personal, true story told with clear organization and correct grammar.

Parts of an Autobiography Paragraph

Part	Purpose	Example
Topic Sentence	States the meaningful experience and hints at why it matters	"Learning to drive at the age of thirty-five was one of the most challenging and rewarding experiences of my life."
Supporting Detail 1	First specific detail/event, often the beginning of the story	"At first, I was terrified every time I sat behind the wheel."
Supporting Detail 2	Second specific detail/event, showing development or a turning point	"After several lessons, I began to feel more comfortable, especially when my instructor taught me to stay calm in traffic."
Supporting Detail 3	Third specific detail/event, often the climax or result	"Eventually, I passed my driving test on the first try, and I called my children immediately to share the news."
Concluding Sentence	Reflects on the meaning or lesson of the experience	"That experience taught me that it is never too late to learn something new and gain independence."

Topic Choices

Choose ONE topic below, or propose your own meaningful personal experience (instructor approval required). You do not need to choose a difficult or emotional topic — pick whatever memory you feel comfortable sharing.

Option	Topic
1	A milestone you achieved (a graduation, a new job, a certificate, passing a test, becoming a citizen, etc.)
2	A family tradition that is meaningful to you
3	A time you had to adapt to a big change (a move, a new school, a new country, a new routine)
4	A moment you overcame a fear or a challenge
5	Student Choice: any other meaningful personal experience (must be approved by instructor; students may always choose to keep private details private and focus on non-sensitive parts of the story)

Assignment Requirements

• 6–10 sentences total (topic sentence + 3 supporting details + conclusion; supporting details may be more than one sentence each)

- Include at least **two compound sentences** and **two complex sentences with adverbial clauses**, with correct subject-verb agreement
- Include at least **three adverbs of time** to show the sequence of events (e.g., *first, then, eventually, after that, finally*)
- Include at least **two vocabulary words** from this module's word list
- Use at least **one phrasal verb or collocation** from the idiomatic language mini-lesson
- Written in past tense, first person ("I")
- No outside sources are required for this assignment; if you do reference any outside text or idea, you must paraphrase properly and give credit (see mini-lesson above)

Transition Words for Personal Narrative

Transition Word/Phrase	Use
First, / At first,	To introduce the beginning of the story
Then, / Next, / After that,	To show the next event in sequence
Eventually, / Finally, / At last,	To show the outcome or ending
Because / Since	To explain a reason
Although / Even though	To show contrast or difficulty overcome
As a result, / Because of this,	To show a result or consequence
In the end, / Looking back,	To introduce the concluding reflection

Model Text: "A New Beginning"

Moving to the United States at sixteen years old was the most difficult and transformative experience of my life. **At first**, I felt completely lost because I did not understand English well and I missed my friends back home. **Then**, my ESL teacher paired me with a classmate who had arrived two years earlier, and she showed me around the school **while I was still learning the language**. **Eventually**, I joined the school's soccer team, and I made friends **even though my English was not perfect yet**. **After several months**, I began to feel more confident, **and** I started raising my hand in class **when** I knew the answer. **Looking back**, I realize that this journey taught me resilience, **and** it helped me grow up faster than I expected. I am grateful for that difficult beginning, because it made me the person I am today.

(This model uses bolded time adverbs and conjunctions to show the required grammar; students are not required to bold their own final draft.)

The Writing Process

1. **Prewrite** — Use the graphic organizer below to plan your story before writing.
2. **Draft** — Write a complete first version, focusing on getting your ideas down in order.
3. **Revise** — Reread your draft. Add details, fix the order of events, and strengthen your conclusion.
4. **Edit** — Check grammar, punctuation, spelling, and subject-verb agreement using the checklist below.
5. **Publish** — Submit your final paragraph in your chosen format (typed, handwritten+photo, or audio recording).

Prewriting Graphic Organizer

Story Element	Your Notes
Topic Sentence idea	What is the meaningful experience, and why does it matter?
Detail 1 (beginning)	What happened first?
Detail 2 (middle/turning point)	What happened next? What changed?
Detail 3 (end/result)	How did it end? What was the outcome?

Story Element	Your Notes
Concluding reflection	What did you learn, or how did this experience affect you?
Vocabulary/grammar to include	List the 2 vocabulary words, 2 compound sentences, 2 complex sentences, 3 time adverbs, and 1 phrasal verb/collocation you plan to use

Revision Checklist

Check	Yes/No
Does my topic sentence clearly introduce the meaningful experience?	
Do I have three clear supporting details in time order?	
Does my conclusion reflect on the meaning of the experience?	
Did I include at least 2 compound sentences and 2 complex sentences with correct subject-verb agreement?	
Did I include at least 3 adverbs of time?	
Did I use at least 2 vocabulary words and 1 phrasal verb/collocation?	
Did I check spelling, punctuation, and capitalization?	

Grading Rubric (20 points total)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Organization (topic sentence, 3 details, conclusion)	All parts present, clear, and logically sequenced	All parts present with minor sequencing issues	Missing one part or sequence is unclear	Most parts missing or paragraph is disorganized
Grammar Focus (compound/complex sentences, SVA, time adverbs)	Uses required structures correctly and naturally throughout	Uses required structures with only minor errors	Uses some required structures; frequent SVA/sentence errors	Rarely or incorrectly uses required structures
Vocabulary and Idiomatic Language	Uses vocabulary words and phrasal verb/collocation naturally and correctly	Uses required vocabulary correctly, slightly less natural	Uses vocabulary but with unclear or incorrect meaning	Little to no required vocabulary used
Mechanics (spelling, punctuation, capitalization)	Virtually error-free	Minor errors that do not affect meaning	Several errors that sometimes affect meaning	Frequent errors that affect readability

Multimodal Submission Options

- **Option 1 — Typed:** Type your final paragraph in a Canvas text entry box or Word document (in-person students may also type in a classroom computer lab).
- **Option 2 — Handwritten + Photo:** Write your final paragraph by hand on paper, then take a clear photo and upload it to Canvas (ideal for students who are still building typing/digital skills).
- **Option 3 — Audio Recording:** Record yourself reading your paragraph aloud and upload the audio file to Canvas (this also builds your oral fluency and pronunciation of the grammar structures you practiced).

Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board

Discussion Prompt

Part 1: Share a meaningful personal experience or a family tradition that is important to you. Use at least one adverb of time (*first, then, eventually*, etc.) to describe when it happened or how it developed.

Part 2: Compare your experience or tradition to something in your own past, or to something you know about another culture. How is it similar or different?

Part 3: Respond to at least two classmates with a genuine follow-up question about their story (for example, ask for more detail, ask how they felt, or ask what happened next).

Discussion Requirements

Component	Requirement	Points
Original Post	5–7 sentences responding to Parts 1 and 2; uses at least 1 adverb of time and 1 module vocabulary word	10
Reply 1	Genuine follow-up question + personal comment connecting to your own experience	5
Reply 2	Genuine follow-up question + personal comment connecting to your own experience	5
Total		20

Sentence Frames

Purpose	Sentence Frame
Introducing your story	One experience that is meaningful to me is _____.
Sequencing events	First, _____. Then, _____. Eventually, _____.
Comparing to your own life	This reminds me of a time when I _____.
Comparing to another culture	In my culture, we also/instead _____.
Asking a follow-up question	Can you tell me more about _____? / How did you feel when _____? / What happened after _____?
Responding warmly	Thank you for sharing that. It reminds me of _____.

Functional / Persuasive Language Phrases

Function	Phrase Examples
Stating an opinion or feeling	I feel that... / In my opinion... / What stood out to me was...
Supporting with a reason	This is meaningful to me because... / One reason this matters is...
Comparing	Similarly,... / On the other hand,... / Unlike my experience,...
Agreeing	I can really relate to that. / I feel the same way about...
Disagreeing respectfully	I see it a little differently. / In my experience, it was more like...

Delivery Mode Adaptation

In-person students will share their stories aloud in pairs or small groups of three, then each group will briefly report one shared theme back to the whole class. **Zoom** students will be placed into breakout rooms of two or three for the same spoken sharing, and

may use a shared Google Doc or the chat to jot down notes and follow-up questions before returning to the main session. **Canvas LMS** students will complete this activity fully asynchronously: post an original response to the discussion board prompt, then return within the module window to read and reply to at least two classmates' posts with a genuine follow-up question, exactly as described in the requirements above.

Discussion Grading Rubric (20 points total)

Criteria	Excellent (5 pts)	Proficient (4 pts)	Developing (2–3 pts)	Beginning (0–1 pt)
Content and Personal Connection	Rich, genuine personal story with clear detail	Clear personal story with adequate detail	Vague or minimal personal detail	Off-topic or no personal connection
Grammar/Vocabulary Use	Correctly uses adverb(s) of time and vocabulary naturally	Uses required elements with minor errors	Uses required elements with noticeable errors	Missing required grammar/vocabulary
Engagement with Classmates	Both replies include thoughtful, genuine follow-up questions	Replies include follow-up questions with minor gaps	Replies are generic or lack real questions	Missing one or both replies
Active Listening/Responsiveness	Response clearly builds on what the classmate specifically said	Response mostly connects to classmate's post	Response only loosely connects	Response does not connect to classmate's post

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

This quiz is for your own practice and is not graded. Use it to check your understanding before the writing assignment is due.

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

Match each word (1–10) to its definition (a–j).

1. memorable
2. childhood
3. milestone
4. journey
5. overcome
6. reflect
7. achievement
8. tradition
9. adapt
10. grateful

a. to think carefully about the past b. worth remembering c. an important stage or event in life d. a custom passed down in a family or culture e. feeling thankful f. the period of being a child g. to successfully deal with a difficulty h. to adjust to new conditions i. a long process of change or growth j. something successfully accomplished

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. My grandmother's stories about her _____ always make me smile. (childhood / milestone)
2. It was hard to _____ to the cold weather after living somewhere warm. (reflect / adapt)
3. Finishing the marathon was a huge _____ for her. (achievement / tradition)
4. We _____ my father's birthday every year with a big family dinner. (overcome / celebrate)

5. I try to _____ on my progress at the end of every month. (reflect / adapt)
6. Lighting candles during the holidays is an old family _____. (tradition / journey)
7. She had to _____ many obstacles to finish her degree. (overcome / reflect)
8. I am _____ for the opportunities I have had in this country. (grateful / memorable)

Section 3: Grammar Identification and Application

Identify each sentence as Compound (C) or Complex (X), then underline the conjunction or subordinator.

1. I moved to a new city, and I had to make new friends.
2. Although I was scared, I decided to apply for the job.
3. She studied every night because she wanted to pass the exam.
4. My brother works, but my sister is still in school.
5. When I look back on that year, I feel proud.
6. I called my mother, so she could hear the good news.
7. Since I arrived, I have learned so much English.
8. We celebrated the holiday, and my whole family came together.
9. Even though it was difficult, I never gave up.
10. First I felt nervous, but then I felt confident.

Section 4: Error Correction

Find and correct the error in each sentence (comma placement, missing conjunction, or subject-verb agreement).

1. I was tired, I kept working anyway.
2. My parents, along with my aunt, are visiting this weekend for the celebration.
3. Because she was determined she never gave up.
4. My sister loves to cook, my brother prefers to bake.
5. Although it was raining we still went to the party.
6. The list of achievements were very long.
7. Eventually I feel more confident about my English.
8. My cousin, who lives with my grandparents, visit us every summer.

Section 5: Short Writing Check

Prompt: In 3–4 sentences, describe one small memorable moment from your week using at least one adverb of time and one compound or complex sentence.

Self-Evaluation Checklist

Check	Yes/No
I used at least one adverb of time.	
I used at least one compound or complex sentence correctly.	
My subjects and verbs agree in every clause.	
My sentences make sense and are easy to follow.	

Student Support and AI Practice

AI Tutor Practice Prompts

Practice Type	What to Ask the AI Tutor	What You Will Get
Vocabulary	"Give me 5 new sentences using the words milestone, journey, and overcome, and check if my example sentences are correct."	Extra example sentences and feedback on your own sentence attempts
Grammar	"Look at these three sentences and tell me if my compound and complex sentences have correct subject-verb agreement."	Sentence-level feedback identifying specific SVA or punctuation errors
Writing Feedback	"Here is my autobiography paragraph draft. Does it have a clear topic sentence, three supporting details, and a conclusion? What should I improve?"	Structural feedback on organization, plus suggestions for stronger transitions or detail
Discussion Practice	"I want to practice asking follow-up questions about a classmate's story. Can you play the role of a classmate telling a short story, and I will practice asking questions?"	A simulated conversation partner for practicing genuine follow-up questions
Idiomatic Language	"Can you check whether I used the phrasal verbs 'grow up' and 'look back on' correctly in my sentences?"	Feedback on correct meaning and natural usage of phrasal verbs/collocations

Extra Grammar Practice

Activity A: Sentence Combining

Combine each pair into a compound or complex sentence.

1. I felt nervous. I gave my presentation anyway.
2. My family arrived late. We still enjoyed the celebration.
3. I practiced English every day. My speaking improved.

Activity B: Subject-Verb Agreement Practice

Choose the correct verb form.

1. My teacher, along with several students, (attend/attends) the workshop every month.
2. Each of my classmates (has/have) an interesting story to tell.
3. Neither my brother nor my sisters (was/were) born in this country.
4. The family, including the grandparents, (gather/gathers) every Sunday.

Activity C: Word Forms

Complete the chart with the correct word form.

Noun	Verb	Adjective
achievement	achieve	_____
reflection	reflect	_____
adaptation	adapt	_____

Campus Support Resources

- **Tutoring Center:** Free drop-in and appointment-based tutoring for reading, writing, and grammar support; tutors can help you brainstorm and revise your autobiography paragraph.
- **Writing Center:** One-on-one and small-group writing support for any assignment, including help with organization, grammar editing, and preparing final drafts.
- **Library:** Access to computers, printing, quiet study space, and librarian assistance for finding reliable resources (useful for future assignments that require outside sources).
- **DSPS (Disability Support Programs and Services):** Provides accommodations and support services for students with documented disabilities, including extended time, alternative formats, and assistive technology.

Module Summary and Extra Resources

Summary by Skill Area

Skill	What Students Learned
Reading/Vocabulary	Read and analyzed a personal narrative text; learned 10 words related to personal narrative and life stories; practiced the sequencing-events reading strategy
Grammar	Compound and complex sentences with adverbial clauses, correct subject-verb agreement, adverbs of time, and coordinating/subordinating conjunctions
Writing/Communication	Wrote a well-developed autobiography paragraph (topic sentence + 3 supporting details + conclusion); practiced idiomatic phrasal verbs/collocations; learned paraphrasing and plagiarism basics; shared and discussed personal stories with classmates

Extra Resources

Resource	What It Covers	URL
Purdue OWL: Sentence Types	Clear explanations and examples of simple, compound, complex, and compound-complex sentences	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_w...sentences.html
Purdue OWL: Conquering the Comma	Comma rules for compound sentences and coordinating conjunctions	https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_w...he-comma-a.pdf
Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary	Simple definitions, pronunciation, and example sentences for this module's vocabulary words	https://www.merriam-webster.com/
VOA Learning English: Everyday Grammar — Phrasal Verbs	Clear video and text lessons introducing common English phrasal verbs	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/p/9412.html
VOA Learning English: Introducing Phrasal Verbs	Beginner-friendly explanation of how phrasal verbs work with examples	https://learningenglish.voanews.com/...s/3010251.html
BBC Learning English	Free listening and speaking practice, including everyday conversation and storytelling topics	https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish

Looking Ahead

This Module Connects To...	How

This Module Connects To...	How
Future academic writing	The paraphrasing/plagiarism mini-lesson prepares students for research-based assignments requiring outside sources and bibliographies
Oral presentations	The narrative sequencing and storytelling skills in this module support future oral presentation assignments (introduction, details, conclusion)
Workplace and civic communication	Comfort telling a personal story clearly and correctly supports job interviews, community participation, and everyday communication
Continued grammar development	Compound/complex sentence control and subject-verb agreement are foundational skills used in every future writing task in the course

Reflection Questions

1. Which vocabulary word from this module do you think you will use most often in real life, and why?
2. What part of writing your autobiography paragraph was the most challenging — choosing a topic, organizing details, or using the grammar structures?
3. Can you think of a moment during this module when you felt proud of your English progress?
4. How did listening to a classmate's personal story affect the way you think about your own story?
5. What is one grammar structure (compound sentences, complex sentences, adverbs of time, or conjunctions) you still want more practice with?

ESL 304 Intermediate High | Module 8: Personal Narrative and Autobiography | Santa Ana College School of Continuing Education

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Appendix A: Guidelines and Instructions for Faculty

Purpose of This Appendix

This appendix supports faculty teaching ESL 304 (Intermediate High) using this curriculum. It explains how to deliver each module across the course's three delivery modes, how to interpret and use the self-check exercises now that the Answer Key has been consolidated here, how the curriculum aligns with course standards, and how to calibrate expectations for this non-credit, open-entry/exit course.

Course Context Reminder

ESL 304 is a **noncredit** course (Classification K — Other Noncredit Enhanced Funding) with **Open Entry/Exit** enrollment and **CE (Continuing Education) repeatability**. Total instructional hours range from 96 to 216, and grading uses a three-tier scale rather than letter grades:

Grade	Meaning
P (Pass)	Student demonstrates proficiency in course outcomes
SP (Satisfactory Progress)	Student demonstrates proficiency in some outcomes and is progressing toward the rest
NP (No Pass)	Student has not yet demonstrated measurable progress

Because enrollment is open entry/exit, students may join or leave at different points in the term. Each module is designed to stand largely on its own so students who join mid-course can still engage meaningfully, though grammar points build across the sequence and are easiest to follow in order:

Module	Grammar Focus
1. Health and Wellness	Simple present, present progressive, present perfect, stative verbs, subject-verb agreement, <i>for</i> vs. <i>since</i>
2. Natural Disasters and Emergency Preparedness	Past modals (<i>used to</i> , <i>could have</i> , <i>should have</i> , <i>was/were able to</i> , <i>had to</i>), indirect/reported speech
3. Advocacy and Community Engagement	Tag questions, adjectival clauses (<i>who/which</i>), parallel structure, conjunctive adverbs
4. Employment and Workplace Communication	Yes/No, Or, and Wh- questions with past perfect and past perfect progressive; embedded questions
5. Consumer and Financial Literacy	Present unreal conditional, present wish clauses, hope clauses
6. Education and Academic Success	Future progressive (Yes/No, Or, Wh- questions), reflexive pronouns, indefinite pronouns
7. Technology and Digital Literacy	Active voice and passive voice (simple present)
8. Personal Narrative and Autobiography	Compound and complex sentences with adverbial clauses, adverbs of time, coordinating and subordinating conjunctions, subject-verb agreement in clauses

This sequence follows the Language Structure and Grammar strand of the ESL 304 Course Outline of Record, which specifies 19–40 hours of instruction across these structures alongside the review and expansion of grammar from previous course levels.

How to Use the Self-Check Exercises and Answer Key

Every module includes four scored practice sets (Reading and Vocabulary, Grammar Lesson, Self-Check Quiz, and grammar/vocabulary checks embedded in Student Support and AI Practice), all framed for students as **self-check practice, not graded exams**. This matches the non-credit, proficiency-based grading scale above.

Suggested faculty use of scores:

- Use performance across a module's practice sections as one input — among several, per the COR's Standards of Achievement (computer assignments/worksheets, instructor-prepared assessments, observations, performance-based assessments, portfolios, presentations) — toward determining a student's overall P/SP/NP designation.
- Do not report individual quiz scores to students as letter grades or percentages framed as "test scores" — instead, use language like "you are showing strong progress" or "let's review this skill area together."
- The Answer Key (Appendix B) is for **instructor reference and optional self-scoring by students**. Consider posting the relevant Appendix B section to Canvas after students complete each module's Self-Check Quiz so students can self-correct.
- Items marked "sample answer" or "sample answers" in the Answer Key are open-ended. Accept any response that demonstrates the correct grammar structure, vocabulary understanding, or reasoning, even if wording differs from the sample.
- Writing Assignment main tasks and the Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board prompts are intentionally excluded from the Answer Key since they are reflective, personal, or free-response by design. Evaluate these using each module's in-text self-assessment checklist, class discussion, or your own informal rubric.

Delivering the Curriculum Across Three Modalities

Each module's Delivery Mode Note gives module-specific guidance, but here are course-wide principles for each modality:

In-Person

- Vocabulary and grammar activities are completed on paper or on the board.
- Pair and small-group work supports the Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board task as a live classroom activity.
- Written work (Writing Assignment, Self-Check Quiz) can be turned in during class or uploaded to Canvas.

Zoom (Synchronous Online)

- Use the same materials as in-person sections, with screen-sharing replacing the board and breakout rooms (2–3 students) replacing physical pair/small-group work.
- Shared Google Docs can replace physical worksheets for collaborative grammar and writing practice.
- Discussion board requirements are still fulfilled asynchronously on Canvas after the Zoom session, giving a written record of participation.

Canvas (Asynchronous Online)

- All readings, grammar explanations, and practice activities are delivered as Canvas pages or PDFs.
- The Writing Assignment (process paragraph or equivalent) is submitted through a Canvas assignment.
- The Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board requirement is fulfilled through the Canvas Discussions tool, with students posting an original response and replying to at least one classmate.

Instructors should confirm which combination of these modes applies to their section and adjust due dates and synchronous participation requirements accordingly — see the Delivery Mode Note at the start of each module.

Accessibility Notes

- This document uses a logical heading structure (Heading 1 for the document title and module titles, Heading 2 for the eight standard module sections, Heading 3 for subsections) so that screen reader users can navigate efficiently using heading-based navigation. This appendix follows the same structure.
- All tables include a marked header row that repeats across pages, including the tables in this appendix.
- Text and background colors throughout the document, including this appendix, meet WCAG AA contrast requirements. No information is conveyed by color alone.
- All hyperlinks use descriptive text rather than generic phrases such as "click here."

- If you convert any module to a Canvas page, use Canvas's Rich Content Editor heading styles (not manual bold/large text) to preserve this accessibility structure, and run the Canvas Accessibility Checker before publishing.
- If you add video or audio content (e.g., recorded listening passages, sample presentations), captions or transcripts should be provided.

Pacing Suggestions

Given the course's 96–216 hour range, sections may schedule ESL 304 over different term lengths. As a general guide:

- **Shorter terms (closer to 96 hours):** Plan roughly 12 hours per module, focusing class or synchronous time on the Grammar Lesson and Speaking and Listening sections; assign Reading and Vocabulary and the Self-Check Quiz as independent work.
- **Longer terms (closer to 216 hours):** Plan roughly 24–27 hours per module, allowing time for extended discussion, additional speaking practice, guest speakers (as suggested in the COR's Instructional Methods), and deeper exploration of the Module Summary and Extra Resources links.
- Adjust pacing based on your program's actual term length and whether the course meets multiple times per week.

A Note on AI Practice Prompts

Each module's Student Support and AI Practice section suggests prompts students can use with an AI chatbot for extra practice (e.g., vocabulary review, sentence-writing feedback). These are optional supplementary practice, not a substitute for in-class, Zoom, or Canvas-based instruction. Faculty should briefly explain to students how to access any AI tool their institution has approved for student use and should clarify that AI-generated feedback is a practice aid, not an official assessment of their progress in the course.

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Appendix B: Answer Key

This answer key provides suggested answers for the Reading and Vocabulary, Grammar Lesson, Self-Check Quiz, and Student Support and AI Practice exercises in each module. Where a section contains more than one activity, answers are grouped under a bolded activity label matching the activity name in the module. Items marked "sample answer" or "sample answers" are open-ended; students may respond in their own words as long as the core grammar structure or idea is correct. The Writing Assignment main task and the Speaking and Listening: Discussion Board prompts are not included here since they are open-ended, reflective, or discussion-based; see Appendix A for guidance on evaluating these.

Module 1 Answer Key: Health and Wellness

Reading and Vocabulary

1. routine
2. immune system
3. consult
4. habit
5. nutrition
6. prevention
7. wellness
8. mental health
9. chronic
10. maintain

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. recommends
2. am trying
3. have followed
4. understands
5. have
6. is drinking
7. helps
8. have changed

Activity 2

1. for
2. since
3. for
4. since
5. for
6. since

Activity 3

Answer Key (sample answers — accept any grammatically correct sentence with correct agreement):

1. My best friend exercises every morning.
2. Right now, the students are discussing healthy habits.
3. My family has eaten more vegetables since last year.
4. The nurses at that clinic explain treatment options clearly.
5. I have maintained a healthy sleep schedule for six months.

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-h, 2-d, 3-f, 4-e, 5-c, 6-i, 7-b, 8-j, 9-g, 10-a

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. prevention
2. habit
3. mental health
4. maintain
5. routine
6. immune system
7. nutrition
8. consult

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. jogs
2. is eating
3. have practiced
4. knows
5. have changed
6. understand
7. walk
8. has had
9. offers
10. are learning
11. wants
12. since

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. My sister exercises every day after work.
2. Right now, I want to change my sleep schedule.
3. We have followed this routine for two months.
4. He drinks water before every meal.
5. She knows that stress affects sleep. (correct — was already correct)
6. My parents have started a new habit together.
7. They have practiced yoga since 2021. (correct — no change needed)

8. The students are learning about nutrition this week.

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

Answer Key (sample combinations):

1. Since I drink more water now, I feel more energetic.
2. She started yoga last year, and she has practiced it since then.
3. He eats vegetables every day, and he avoids sugary drinks every day.

Activity 2: Grammar Practice

1. improves
2. have
3. plays
4. recommend
5. has maintained

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

1. nutrition
2. habitual
3. preventive
4. maintain

Module 2 Answer Key: Natural Disasters and Emergency Preparedness

Reading and Vocabulary

1. alert
2. precaution
3. evacuate
4. aftermath
5. emergency kit
6. shelter
7. survivor
8. damage
9. response
10. warning

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. used to
2. could have
3. had to
4. was able to
5. should have

Activity 2

1. could have evacuated
2. used to keep
3. had to leave
4. was able to reach
5. should have warned

Activity 3

1. The officer told us to leave our homes immediately.
2. The forecaster said that a storm would arrive that night.
3. The survivor said that she had lost everything in the flood.
4. The nurse asked if I needed any medical supplies.
5. The mayor announced that they were opening two new shelters.

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-c, 2-g, 3-e, 4-i, 5-d, 6-f, 7-b, 8-a, 9-j, 10-h

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. aftermath
2. response
3. emergency kit
4. damage
5. alert
6. precaution
7. shelter
8. survivor

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. used to
2. should have
3. had to
4. were able to
5. should have
6. The officer told us to stay away from the river.
7. The forecaster said that the storm would hit that night.
8. The nurse asked if I had any injuries.
9. could have avoided
10. used to keep

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. The officials should have warned us sooner.
2. Before, my family used to keep flashlights in every room.
3. She was able to swim across the flooded street to reach her neighbor, so she did.

4. The officer asked if we needed help.
5. We had to evacuate last night because of the fire.
6. The rescue team was able to reach the trapped hikers before the storm returned.
7. He said that he would call once the roads reopened.
8. They didn't have to leave because the fire changed direction.

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

Answer Key (sample answers):

1. The family should have evacuated earlier.
2. Although the road was blocked, the firefighters were able to find another way.
3. In the past, people used to rely on the radio because they did not have text alerts.

Activity 2: Grammar Practice

1. The emergency kits were placed near the front door.
2. Every survivor has a different story to tell.
3. The warnings were sent to all residents.

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

1. prepared; damage; surviving

Module 3 Answer Key: Advocacy and Community Engagement

Reading and Vocabulary

1. resident
2. petition
3. ordinance
4. advocate
5. municipal
6. complaint
7. civic duty
8. public hearing
9. representative
10. resolution

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. b (isn't it)
2. b (have they)
3. a (can't you)
4. a (will they)
5. c (didn't she)

Activity 2

Answer Key (sample combinations):

1. The petition which was created by neighbors collected 240 signatures.
2. The representative who visited Maple Street wanted to see the crosswalk.
3. The ordinance which passed last spring requires new lighting downtown.
4. The residents who spoke at the hearing live near the park.
5. The department which received the complaint is responsible for street repairs.

Activity 3

1. "The plan will save money, improve safety, and reduce traffic."
2. "Good advocates listen carefully, ask clear questions, and remain persistent."
3. "The city approved the petition; however, it has not released the funds yet."
4. "Residents attended the public hearing; in addition, they wrote letters to the newspaper."
5. "The crosswalk had no working light; as a result, several accidents occurred there."

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-i, 2-f, 3-b, 4-a, 5-d, 6-h, 7-c, 8-j, 9-e, 10-g

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. municipal
2. civic duty
3. residents
4. public hearing
5. representative
6. complaint
7. ordinance
8. resolution

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. tag question
2. adjectival clause
3. parallel structure
4. conjunctive adverb
5. tag question
6. adjectival clause
7. parallel structure
8. conjunctive adverb
9. (Items 9–12) Answers will vary; check for correct form (see Grammar Lesson section for models).

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. "The mayor is attending the meeting, isn't she?" (tag must be negative after a positive statement)
2. "The woman who organized the petition lives on our street." (use "who" for people)
3. "The plan will save money, reduce traffic, and improve safety." (parallel verb forms)
4. "The city approved the request; however, they have not released the funds." (semicolon needed before conjunctive adverb)

5. "The residents don't agree with the new schedule." (subject-verb agreement — plural subject)
6. "The complaint was filed last Tuesday." (subject-verb agreement — singular subject)
7. "He is the representative who answered my letter." (use "who" for people)
8. Correct as written — no error. (This item checks whether students can recognize a correctly formed tag question.)

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

1. "The city council, which meets every Tuesday, reviews resident complaints." OR "The city council meets every Tuesday; in addition, it reviews resident complaints."
2. "The petition had 500 signatures; however, the city still delayed its decision."
3. "The new ordinance, which passed last month, affects downtown businesses."

Activity 2: Grammar Practice

1. want
2. has
3. meets

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

1. advocacy/advocate/advocated (or advocative — accept reasonable variants); resolution/resolve/resolved; complaint/complain/complaining

Module 4 Answer Key: Employment and Workplace Communication

Reading and Vocabulary

1. reference;
2. supervisor;
3. application;
4. qualification;
5. benefits;
6. shift;
7. responsibilities;
8. applicants;
9. employer;
10. interview

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. a;
2. a;
3. b

Activity 2

1. Had / worked;
2. had / been training;
3. Had / finished... had / been writing;

4. had / done;
5. Had / been

Activity 3

1. Could you tell me what your greatest strength is?
2. I was wondering if you have experience with customer service.
3. Can you explain what your responsibilities were at your last job?
4. I'd like to know how long you had been working there.
5. I was wondering if you had any questions for me.

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-h, 2-j, 3-f, 4-b, 5-a, 6-i, 7-c, 8-g, 9-e, 10-d

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. qualifications;
2. employer;
3. reference;
4. applicants;
5. shift;
6. responsibilities;
7. application;
8. supervisor

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. PP;
2. EQ;
3. PPP;
4. PP;
5. EQ;
6. PP;
7. PPP;
8. EQ;
9. (Items 9–12) Answers will vary — check for correct form (had + past participle; had been + verb-ing; embedded word order without inversion).

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. Had you gone to the interview before you called them?
2. Could you tell me what your qualifications were?
3. How long had she been working there before she quit?
4. I was wondering if you had any references.
5. Had you been studying English before you moved here?
6. Had you finished the application on time?

7. Could you tell me how long you had worked there?
8. Had she worked as a supervisor before this job?

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

1. Before she applied for the job, she had updated her resume.
2. Before he arrived at the interview, he had researched the company.
3. Before they hired a new employee, they had interviewed five applicants.

Activity 2: Grammar Practice

1. Do you know where the human resources office is?
2. Do you know what time the interview starts?
3. Do you know who my supervisor is?

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

1. applicable/applied; qualified; take responsibility for (verb: "to be responsible for")

Module 5 Answer Key: Consumer and Financial Literacy

Reading and Vocabulary

1. contract
2. warranty
3. statement
4. deposit
5. interest rate
6. refund
7. budget
8. overdraft
9. consumer rights
10. installments

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. b
2. c
3. c
4. b
5. c

Activity 2

1. understood
2. were
3. fixes / will fix
4. read
5. had

6. sends / will send

Activity 3

Answer Key (sample answers — students' original sentences will vary):

1. If I had a stronger budget, I would save \$100 every month.
2. I wish I hadn't spent so much money on my credit card last year. (Note: also acceptable — "I wish I knew more about credit card fees before I applied.")
3. I hope that the landlord returns my full deposit next week.

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-b, 2-a, 3-d, 4-c, 5-f, 6-g, 7-i, 8-j, 9-h, 10-e

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. warranty
2. overdraft
3. contract
4. consumer rights
5. installments
6. statement
7. deposit
8. interest rate

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. C
2. H
3. W
4. C
5. H
6. W
7. C
8. H
9. had
10. knew
11. accepts/will accept
12. checked

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. If I had more money, I would save it.
2. I wish I knew more about consumer rights.
3. She hopes that the refund arrives soon.
4. If he were more careful, he would not have signed that contract.
5. We wish we had a bigger budget.

6. I hope that she will fix the mistake on my statement.
7. If they checked the interest rate, they would have chosen a different loan.
8. I wish I were better at saving money. (formal form)

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

1. If I had a big emergency fund, I wouldn't worry about unexpected costs.
2. If she checked her statement often, she wouldn't miss errors.
3. If they understood the contract, they wouldn't sign it anyway.

Activity 2: Grammar Practice

1. wishes
2. hope
3. wishes
4. hope

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

1. budget → budgeted (adj., e.g. "a budgeted amount"); deposit (noun) → deposited (adj.); refund → refundable (adj.)

Module 6 Answer Key: Education and Academic Success

Reading and Vocabulary

1. syllabus
2. procrastinate
3. priority
4. concentrate
5. schedule
6. deadline
7. workload
8. review
9. organize
10. achieve

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. a
2. a
3. a
4. a
5. a

Activity 2

1. myself
2. Someone
3. anyone

4. himself
5. Nobody
6. ourselves
7. something
8. herself

Activity 3

Answer Key (sample answers):

1. What will you be doing to prepare for the final exam?
2. Will you be studying alone this weekend?
3. I am going to give myself a short break every hour while I study.
4. Everybody needs a clear schedule to succeed this semester.
5. Will you be reviewing vocabulary or grammar tonight?

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-d, 2-e, 3-f, 4-a, 5-g, 6-h, 7-c, 8-i, 9-b, 10-j

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. syllabus
2. procrastinates
3. priority
4. organizes
5. schedule
6. workload
7. concentrate
8. review

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. Future progressive Yes/No question
2. Future progressive Wh- question
3. Indefinite pronoun
4. Reflexive pronoun
5. Future progressive Or question
6. Who
7. myself
8. anyone
9. Will she be
10. something
11. (sample) Will you be doing your homework tonight?
12. (sample) Everyone in my class wants to pass the final.

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. Will you be studying at the library tonight?
2. What will you be doing after class?
3. Everybody needs a good schedule.
4. I taught myself how to use a planner.
5. Did someone bring their notebook?
6. She organizes herself a calendar every week.
7. Anybody is welcome to join the study group.
8. Nobody has finished the assignment yet.
9. Will you be reviewing your notes tonight?
10. He reminded himself to check the deadline.

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

1. She made a plan by herself.
2. I will finish this project by myself.
3. They organized a study group by themselves.

Activity 2: Grammar Practice

1. wants
2. leaves
3. matters
4. can

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

1. (as shown above — students fill in blanks; instructor may remove some cells before distributing)

Module 7 Answer Key: Technology and Digital Literacy

Reading and Vocabulary

1. verify
2. app
3. browser
4. platform
5. credible
6. download
7. upload
8. digital footprint
9. multimedia
10. source

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. A
2. P

3. A
4. P
5. A
6. P
7. A
8. P

Activity 2

1. updates
2. is designed
3. use
4. is protected
5. verifies
6. are posted
7. blocks
8. are written

Activity 3

Answer Key (sample answers — student answers will vary):

1. "A search engine finds information quickly."
2. "This social media app connects people around the world."
3. "Students use technology to complete homework."
4. "This website is updated every day."
5. "This app is downloaded by thousands of users."
6. "Online videos are watched by people of all ages."

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-c, 2-g, 3-b, 4-f, 5-i, 6-d, 7-a, 8-j, 9-e, 10-h

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. verify
2. platform
3. download
4. credible
5. multimedia
6. digital footprint
7. browser
8. app

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. A
2. P

3. A
4. P
5. A
6. P
7. translates
8. is managed
9. use
10. are posted
11. blocks
12. is protected

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. The website is updated every day.
2. This app is developed by a team of teachers.
3. New videos are uploaded every week.
4. Millions of people use this platform.
5. The file is downloaded, but it is not verified yet.
6. This browser blocks unsafe websites.
7. The reviews are written by real users.
8. Students download the app; it is free. (or: "...download the app because it is free.")

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

Answer Key (sample combinations):

1. "Students use this app to learn vocabulary."
2. "This website is created by a team for teachers." (or "This website, created by a team, is for teachers.")
3. "People trust this source because it checks its facts."

Activity 2: Word Form Practice

Answer Key (Word Form Practice — Verb / Noun / Adjective):

1. verify / verification / verified, verifiable
2. credit (related root) / credibility / credible
3. download / download / downloadable

Activity 3: Grammar Practice

1. "This platform is used by many people."
2. "This app is recommended by teachers."
3. "The information is verified by experts."
4. "The software is updated by the company."

Module 8 Answer Key: Personal Narrative and Autobiography

Reading and Vocabulary

1. journey
2. tradition
3. milestone
4. adapt
5. reflect
6. childhood
7. achievement
8. memorable
9. overcome
10. grateful

Grammar Lesson

Activity 1

1. (b) but
2. (a) After
3. (a) because
4. (b) Although
5. (a) and

Activity 2

1. At first, feel
2. practice; eventually, become
3. First, write
4. Finally, celebrates
5. Meanwhile / While, help

Activity 3

Answer Key (sample answers — other correct combinations are acceptable):

1. When my family moved to a new city, we had to adapt to a new school system.
2. I was scared to speak in class, but I raised my hand anyway.
3. My grandmother tells stories about her village, and my cousins love listening to her.
4. After I finished my ESL class, I felt proud of my progress.
5. Although we did not have much money, our family always found ways to celebrate holidays together.

Self-Check Quiz (Ungraded Practice)

Section 1: Vocabulary Matching

1. 1-b, 2-f, 3-c, 4-i, 5-g, 6-a, 7-j, 8-d, 9-h, 10-e

Section 2: Vocabulary in Context

1. childhood
2. adapt
3. achievement

4. celebrate
5. reflect
6. tradition
7. overcome
8. grateful

Section 3: Grammar Practice

1. C (and)
2. X (Although)
3. X (because)
4. C (but)
5. X (When)
6. C (so)
7. X (Since)
8. C (and)
9. X (Even though)
10. C (but) — note: #10 also contains an adverb of time ("First," "then")

Section 4: Sentence Correction

1. I was tired, but I kept working anyway.
2. My parents, along with my aunt, is visiting this weekend for the celebration. (subject is "my parents," so "are" is actually correct — corrected sentence should keep "are"; if originally written as "is," change to "are")
3. Because she was determined, she never gave up.
4. My sister loves to cook, but my brother prefers to bake.
5. Although it was raining, we still went to the party.
6. The list of achievements was very long. (subject is "list," singular)
7. Eventually, I feel more confident about my English.
8. My cousin, who lives with my grandparents, visits us every summer. (subject is "cousin," singular)

Student Support and AI Practice

Activity 1: Sentence Combining / Practice

Answer Key (sample answers):

1. I felt nervous, but I gave my presentation anyway.
2. Although my family arrived late, we still enjoyed the celebration.
3. Because I practiced English every day, my speaking improved.

Activity 2: Grammar Practice

1. attends
2. has
3. were
4. gathers

Activity 3: Word Form Practice

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